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## IN BRIEF



### Shah to Christian bodies: FCRA Bill ‘religion-neutral’

**NEW DELHI**  
Amid concerns raised by Christian bodies over the FCRA Bill, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday met two delegations and assured them that the proposed law was “religion-neutral”. » [Page 13](#)

### Need to address Gen Z’s concerns, says RSS chief

**MUMBAI**  
Gen Z’s grievances are genuine and need to be addressed, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat said on Thursday. He added that protest is a way of dialogue in a democracy and that it should be used to evolve a consensus. » [Page 12](#)

# DMK lays down conditions to support delimitation Bill

These conditions come amid renewed efforts from the Centre to reach out to the Opposition to secure numbers for the Bill; however, a top DMK leader says govt. has not approached them yet

**Sandeep Phukan**  
**Sobhana K. Nair**  
NEW DELHI

As the Narendra Modi government explores the possibility of bringing in a constitutional amendment Bill to carry out a fresh delimitation exercise, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) may consider extending support if the Centre revises the legislation that reached the Lok Sabha in April with three essential changes.

There is a freeze on Lok Sabha seats based on the 1971 Census and this freeze ends after the latest Census, which is expected to be completed in 2027. The DMK wants the constitutional freeze to remain for another 25 years, while amending the Constitution to introduce a 50% blanket

## Terms for support

The DMK will support the NDA government’s delimitation Bill only if the following conditions are met, according to sources

**1. A freeze on the 1971 Census as the basis for delimitation for another 25 years**

**2. A blanket 50% increase in Lok Sabha seats for all States, as verbally promised by Home Minister Amit Shah when the legislative package to bring about delimitation was introduced in Parliament in April**



**3. A Schedule of the number of seats that each State will have in the legislative package**

increase in the Lok Sabha seats for all States, which was verbally promised by Home Minister Amit Shah when the legislative package aimed at bringing about delimitation was tabled in Parliament in April.

Additionally, the party wants a Schedule of the number of seats that each State will have in the legis-

lative package, as per sources in the DMK. A top DMK leader said the government has not yet approached them on the issue either “formally or informally”. The party maintains that it will take a final call only after the form and substance of the Bills are known.

These conditions come

amid renewed efforts from the Centre to reach out to the Opposition, with Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju speaking to Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi again on Thursday.

“I had a productive conversation with Rahul Gandhi. I have made a request on a few specific issues and also discussed other matters. We expect continuous communication with the Congress and other Opposition parties,” he said.

He had met Mr. Gandhi on Wednesday too, during which the Congress leaders are said to have reiterated their opposition to any constitutional amendment to carry out delimitation.

**CONTINUED ON**  
» [PAGE 12](#)  
**RELATED REPORTS ON**  
» [PAGE 13](#)

## HC convicts Tarun Tejpal in 2013 sexual assault case

**Chinmay Gaikwad**  
**Yohaan Varghese**  
MUMBAI

The Bombay High Court on Thursday convicted Tarun Tejpal, former editor of *Teelka* magazine, in a 2013 sexual assault case and sentenced him to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment.

The Goa Division Bench of Justice Neela Gokhale and Justice Amit Jamsandekar set aside a trial court’s 2021 judgment that had acquitted Tejpal.

Terming the ruling “perverse”, the Bench said the trial court fell for the notion that a sexual assault complainant must be a “perfect victim” and conduct herself in a certain way to appear credible.

The court ordered Tejpal to surrender within two weeks but extended it to four weeks on a request.

**CONTINUED ON**  
» [PAGE 12](#)



**FOCUS ON PUBLIC DIALOGUE**

## CJP starts nationwide membership drive

**NEWS » PAGE 12**

**TAXATION BILL**

## Payments via UPI may attract charges

**BUSINESS » PAGE 15**

**PARLEY**

## Is it time for the Commonwealth Games to end?

*Number of events and athletes continues to dip*

**OPINION » PAGE 9**

## Peace campaign



**No to bloodshed:** Students participating in an anti-nuclear peace rally on Hiroshima Day, pledging to work towards a nuclear-free world, at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus in Mumbai on Thursday. PTI

## SC to consider plea alleging ‘targeted’ voter deletions in U.P.

**Krishnadas Rajagopal**  
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has agreed to consider a plea by a Congress MP stating that there is evidence to show that the Form 7 process during the claims and objections phase of the special intensive revision of electoral rolls in Uttar Pradesh was utilised to “facilitate targeted deletion attempts against voters”.

**DETAILS ON**  
» [PAGE 4](#)

# J&K police register FIR over PDP protests to mark 7th anniversary of Article 370 dilution

**The Hindu Bureau**  
SRINAGAR

The J&K police on Thursday lodged an FIR against leaders and workers of the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) after the party took out multiple street protests in Srinagar to mark the seventh anniversary of the dilution of Article 370, which had granted special status to the erstwhile State. The PDP termed the FIR “a blatant misuse of power and authority”.

A senior PDP leader said on condition of anonymity that the name of former Chief Minister and party chief Mehbooba Mufti has been mentioned in the FIR for taking out rallies on August 4 and 5 “without prior police permission”.

The name of Ms. Mufti’s daughter, Iltija, also figures in the FIR. Ms. Iltija was stopped by the police after leading a protest at Lal Chowk late in the evening on August 4. She has been



PDP leader Iltija Mufti, who has been named in the FIR, taking out a protest march with party workers in Srinagar on Wednesday. PTI

charged under Sections 132 (assaults on a public servant), 121 (voluntarily causing hurt to deter public servant from doing their duty) and 191(2) (political rallies and mob violence) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

According to the FIR, workers of the party, led by Ms. Mufti and Ms. Iltija, started moving towards the main road. “Police personnel requested them not to assemble on the main road as such a gathering

could disrupt the smooth movement of traffic. The request was not well received by the PDP workers. Instead, they turned aggressive and attacked the police party,” it stated.

The FIR added that the PDP workers used criminal force against the police team, “obstructed them in the discharge of their official duties, and also resorted to pushing and manhandling”. “As a result, several police officers sus-

tained injuries,” it stated.

Ms. Iltija said the FIR was “an attempt to intimidate the PDP to normalise abrogation of Article 370 like the National Conference”. “No rioting broke out at the site... A police officer, Neha Jain, dragged me and manhandled me in spite of being a woman herself,” she alleged.

## ‘Police question Iltija’

Meanwhile, a PDP spokesperson alleged that the police reached Ms. Mufti’s residence in Srinagar’s Khimber and were questioning Ms. Iltija, “who is currently undergoing medical treatment following the injuries she sustained”. “Questioning an injured person while she is under treatment raises serious concerns and is deeply insensitive. Authorities must respect her medical condition and ensure that due process is followed with dignity and humanity,” the party spokesperson said.

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INBRIEF



CM inaugurates STEM lab at Sarvodaya Vidyalaya campus

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday inaugurated a Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) Innovation Lab at Sarvodaya Vidyalaya in Pitampura. She said STEM disciplines are not merely academic subjects but form the foundation of the future economy and nation-building. The Delhi government, she said, is committed to expanding infrastructure in schools to equip students for future challenges. The initiative will promote experiential learning and build skills for an innovation-driven future in government schools across the Capital.

AISA holds victory march, launches ‘Gen Z Rising’ drive

The All India Students’ Association (AISA), which featured prominently in the 36-day Jantar Mantar protest against the alleged NEET-UG paper leak, held a victory march near Delhi University’s Arts Faculty on Thursday. AISA national president Neha, who had been on a 23-day hunger strike at Jantar Mantar, addressed a gathering. The outfit also launched a month-long ‘Gen Z Rising’ campaign under which Ms. Neha will embark on a nationwide tour. AISA said it would intensify its struggle to abolish the National Testing Agency, repeal the National Education Policy 2020, and seek accessible education and dignified employment for the youth.

Delhi govt. plans direct bus link to Jewar airport

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

The Delhi government plans to introduce bus services to the Noida International Airport at Jewar, senior officials said on Thursday. “We plan to start the bus service right up to the Jewar airport. A Reciprocal Transport Agreement will be signed soon between Delhi and Uttar Pradesh transport authorities in this regard,” an official said.

The proposal envisages services from Anand Vihar and Kashmere Gate inter-State bus terminals to the airport. “After the two authorities finalise the details of the agreement, the services will start. This initiative is part of the effort to strengthen public transport infrastructure and expand inter-State mobility,” the official said.

The airport was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on March 28 and began passenger operations last month.

Earlier this year, the Delhi Transport Corporation approved the introduction of 100 electric inter-State buses on 17 routes and began services on routes linking Delhi with Baraut, Sonapat, Dharuhera and Panipat.

300 Chandni Chowk shops asked to shut from Aug. 12-15

I-Day security measures tightened in area after last year’s Red Fort blast; deployment of additional personnel, inspection drives advanced by 2 weeks; traders express concern over potential losses

Lavpreet Kaur  
NEW DELHI

Nearly 300 shops located along the 1-km stretch in Chandni Chowk, between Gurdwara Sis Ganj Sahib and Red Fort, have been asked to remain shut from August 12 to 15 as part of heightened security measures put in place by the Delhi police ahead of Independence Day.

An officer said additional deployment, verification drives and inspections in areas surrounding Red Fort and along the I-Day march route began on July 2 this year, nearly two weeks earlier than the usual date of July 15.

Sources said additional curbs are being imposed this year in view of the November 10, 2025 explosion near Red Fort that claimed 13 lives.

“Beat officers have already informed traders about the shutdown from August 12 to 15. Patrolling has also been intensified across the market,” the officer said.

Unlike previous years, when shops were allowed to operate outside the hours of I-Day rehearsals



Unlike previous years, when shops near Red Fort were allowed to ply partially between Aug. 12 and 14, traders this year have been told to shut shops throughout the 4-day period. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

between August 12 and 14, traders this year have been asked to keep shops closed throughout the four-day period. Establishments in the area have traditionally remained closed on August 15 because of the celebrations at Red Fort.

Subdued atmosphere

Meanwhile, traders at one of the Capital’s busiest commercial and tourist hubs expressed concern over potential losses due to the additional measures.

On Thursday, the rain-soaked lane of shops opposite the heritage structure bore little resemblance to its usual bustle. “This time,

the security forces’ presence is much higher. Police and Army personnel are making regular rounds. Moreover, the police are conducting random searches of shops almost daily,” said Anil, who runs a bridal accessories shop.

Pal, who runs a 70-year-old bag shop, said traders have grown used to annual disruptions but this year’s security arrangements are the most extensive he has seen in decades. “Business suffers every year during Independence Day preparations, but this year’s deployment and screening are much more intensive,” he said.

Monsoon Session starts today: security stepped up

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

A day ahead of the Monsoon Session, the Delhi police on Thursday ramped up security at the Assembly premises following a meeting with Speaker Vijender Gupta.

Special Commissioner of Police (Law and Order) Devesh Shrivastava said about 130 police and paramilitary personnel will be deployed throughout the four-day session.

The police also conducted a mock drill at the Assembly to assess the emergency response capability.

The arrangements come in the wake of a series of bomb threats to the Assembly and a security breach in April this year, when a man drove his vehicle into the Assembly complex and remained within the premises for five minutes before driving off. He was later arrested.



L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu asked officials to track saplings through geotagging. FILE PHOTO

DDA to digitally track survival of 23L saplings

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Thursday launched a digital monitoring system to track the survival of 23 lakh saplings that it aims to plant under its Mega Plantation Drive 2026-27.

Introduced at the direction of Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, the system comprises a mobile app for field officials and a central dashboard that records plantation activity via geotagged photographs. The system uploads data in real time, enabling officials to monitor maintenance, identify plant mortality and undertake replacement. To verify survival rates, the DDA said it would engage a third-party agency to assess the plantations and identify locations requiring corrective measures.

Man fakes kidnapping after concealing year-long unemployment, mounting debt

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

A 35-year-old man allegedly faked his own kidnapping after concealing his year-long unemployment from his family and falling into debt, the police said on Thursday.

According to the police,

the man, a resident of Rohini Sector 23, had been unemployed for nearly a year but continued to leave home daily, pretending to go to work. During this period, he took loans from multiple finance companies and was unable to repay the EMIs, leading to financial stress. On August

3, he allegedly staged his kidnapping and made a distress call to his home.

His family approached the police and filed a kidnapping case. The police later found him near the Kaushambi metro station bus stand. He then disclosed that he had been unemployed for the past

year and took multiple loans, leading to pressure over unpaid EMIs.

“Unable to cope with the stress and fearing confrontation, he left home, staged the abduction and stayed at different locations to avoid being traced. Further investigation is under way,” said an officer.

AAP claims voters wrongly marked as ‘shifted’, seeks details from Delhi CEO

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Thursday met Delhi’s Chief Electoral Officer Ashok Kumar, alleging that genuine voters were being wrongly marked as “shifted” during the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. A party delegation sought details of such voters to independently verify their status.

Led by Delhi AAP chief Saurabh Bharadwaj, the team told the CEO that



AAP State president Saurabh Bharadwaj with Delhi CEO Ashok Kumar on Thursday. ANI

Booth Level Officers had not distributed enumeration forms in several unauthorised colonies, villages and *jhuggi-jhopdi* clusters. “A large number

of the forms have not been distributed, yet people have been marked as shifted on paper,” Mr. Bharadwaj said.

According to data from the office of the Delhi CEO, 99.99% of the forms have been distributed so far while 64.39% have been digitised. Mr. Bharadwaj said his party had requested the Election Commission (EC) to share the names, addresses and phone numbers of voters marked as shifted with political parties’ booth-level agents, who could verify

whether the voters had actually relocated. The former Minister said the EC accepted the suggestion. He also raised concerns about migrant tenants from U.P., Bihar, Rajasthan and Haryana, saying they frequently change rented accommodation within the city and risk being left out of the SIR drive. AAP’s Burari MLA Sanjeev Jha said the CEO told them that cases involving voters who shifted within the same locality would be addressed in the claims and objections stage.

**Social Justice, Empowerment, Welfare of Scheduled Castes & Backward Classes and Antyodaya (SEWA) Department, Haryana, Bays No. 53-54, Sector-2, Panchkula**

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**Director**  
**Social Justice, Empowerment, Welfare of Scheduled Castes & Backward Classes and Antyodaya (SEWA) Department, Haryana**

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**EMPLOYMENT NOTIFICATION**

**Subject : Invitation of applications for appointment of the first Vice Chancellor, Tripura University of Health Sciences (TUHS).**

Applications are hereby invited from interested and eligible candidates for appointment to the post of the **Vice Chancellor**, Tripura University of Health Sciences (TUHS). The detailed Employment Notification, along with the prescribed application format has been uploaded on the official website ([dme.tripura.gov.in](http://dme.tripura.gov.in)) of the Directorate of Medical Education (DME), Government of Tripura.

Interested candidates are requested to submit their applications in the prescribed format, either by email at [healthfinanecp@gmail.com](mailto:healthfinanecp@gmail.com), or physically on or before **7<sup>th</sup> September, 2026** positively at the **O/o the Secretary, Health & Family Welfare Department, State Civil Secretariat, New Capital Complex, PO - Kunjaban, Agartala, West Tripura, PIN- 799010.**

The prescribed application format may be collected from the Office of the Directorate of Medical Education, Government of Tripura, Agartala, on any working day between 11:00 AM and 4:00 PM, or downloaded from the official website of DME ([dme.tripura.gov.in](http://dme.tripura.gov.in)). Any further information regarding this engagement shall be notified from time to time. Candidates are requested to regularly visit the official website of DME for detailed information in this regard.

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I, **MALIHA** Khan, D/O Muslim Khan, born on 24/10/95, residing at A29, Press Enclave, Saket, New Delhi, have changed my name to Maliha Sharma and my religion to Hindu vide affidavit dated 24/03/26 at Delhi.

I, **SANIA** Khan, D/O Muslim Khan, born on 18/7/94, residing at A29, Press Enclave, Saket, New Delhi, have changed my name to Sania Sharma and my religion to Hindu vide affidavit dated 24/03/26 at Delhi.

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I, **JEETESH** Yadav, E-422, Paramount Golf Foreste, Greater Noida, declare that my daughters Agrisha and Abhedya shall henceforth be known as Agrisha Yadav and Abhedya Yadav respectively.

**GOVERNMENT OF HIMACHAL PRADESH**  
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**NOTICE INVITING e TENDERS**

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| Sr. No. | Name of work                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Estimated Cost | Earnest Money | Cost of Tender | Time       |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|---------------|----------------|------------|
| 1.      | Restoration of rain damages to LWSS Mewa Bamson Project in Tehsil Bhoranj (SH: Replacement of Rising Main at valuenreable RD.s Providing, Laying, Joining and Testing of G.I. Pipe in Gravity Main and C/O Anchor Blocks at various RD's (under PDNA). | 3,43,86,236/-  | 4,18,865/-    | 7000/-         | Six Months |

Last date of filing/ uploading the tender through e- tendering **18.08.2026** up to 11.00 AM. The tender forms and other detailed conditions can be obtained from the website [www.hptenders.gov.in](http://www.hptenders.gov.in).

**HIM SUCHANA**  
**AVAM JAN SAMPARK**

**Executive Engineer,**  
**Jal Shakti Division, Bhoranj.**

HP / 2477/26-27

**THE HINDU**

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# Maharashtra resident doctors call off protest after HC order

Court raises concern over impact of strike on patients; it directs protesters to discuss matter of registration of homoeopaths with govt. and arrive at amicable solution; will comply with court's direction, says CM Fadnavis

Chinmay Gaikwad  
MUMBAI

Resident doctors, who were protesting against the State government's decision to permit homoeopaths to register under the Maharashtra Medical Council (MMC) and prescribe allopathic medicines, withdrew their State-wide indefinite strike on Thursday following a directive from the Bombay High Court.

The doctors, affiliated with the Maharashtra Association of Resident Doctors (MARD), had been on strike since August 5, affecting outpatient department services in medical colleges associated with MARD across the State and those run by the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation.



Doctors at KEM Hospital affiliated with the Maharashtra Association of Resident Doctors protesting with placards in Mumbai on Thursday. PTI

The decision came after the High Court directed the doctors to discuss the matter with the State government and arrive at an amicable solution. The court ordered the resident doctors to immediately call off their strike, raising concern ov-

er the protest's impact on patients. Later, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said the State government would comply with the court's directions on the strike by doctors.

"Our demands remain unresolved, our commitment to the

cause remains unwavering, and Central MARD will continue this fight through constitutional, legal, and democratic means. Following discussions with the Chief Minister, the association will take an appropriate stand and announce its further course of action," the association stated in a release.

Earlier in the day, the HC took suo motu cognisance of the strike. A Division Bench observed that doctors cannot resort to strike and put the lives of patients at risk.

Senior advocate Suresh Kamdar, appearing for the Indian Medical Association, informed the court that the association would withdraw the strike. The court posted the matter for further hearing on September 8.

## Civic body chief shifted after waterlogging in Gurugram; WFH advisory issued for today

The Hindu Bureau  
GURUGRAM

Amid waterlogging following heavy rain, the Haryana government on Thursday transferred Municipal Corporation of Gurugram Commissioner Pradeep Dahiya to Rohtak as Deputy Commissioner. The transfer came just two days after similar scenes of flooding disrupted normal life across the city.

In view of the continuing rain and the India Meteorological Department's 'orange alert' for Thursday, the Gurugram administration issued an advisory asking corporate offices and private institutions to allow employees to work from home (WFH) on

August 6 and 7. Overnight rain of 97 mm left several key stretches inundated, including the unidirectional underpass near Medanta Hospital and Narsinghpur on National Highway-48, triggering traffic congestion.

"Citizens are requested to avoid unnecessary travel, stay updated with official advisories, and cooperate with the administration," the advisory said, citing the possibility of waterlogging and traffic congestion at multiple locations in the district.

### On social media

Residents took to social media platform X to share images and videos of flooded roads from several parts of the city, including

IFFCO Chowk and Sector 69, where vehicles were seen driving through waterlogged streets. Roads in Kadipur, Pataudi and Sector 10 also witnessed water accumulation.

Several vehicles, including buses and trucks, broke down on inundated roads, slowing traffic movement. Police teams later towed away the stranded vehicles to restore traffic flow.

Meanwhile, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Prateek Gahlot defended the administration's preparedness, saying coordinated efforts by Gurugram Police and civic agencies had significantly reduced the impact of the monsoon compared to previous years.

Timings  
DELHI

|                   |       |           |
|-------------------|-------|-----------|
| FRIDAY, AUG. 07   |       |           |
| RISE              | 05:46 | SET 19:08 |
| RISE              | 00:00 | SET 14:10 |
| SATURDAY, AUG. 08 |       |           |
| RISE              | 05:47 | SET 19:07 |
| RISE              | 00:33 | SET 15:19 |
| SUNDAY, AUG. 09   |       |           |
| RISE              | 05:47 | SET 19:06 |
| RISE              | 01:33 | SET 16:24 |

|               |     |     |
|---------------|-----|-----|
| Delhi Weather | max | min |
| Delhi City    | 28  | 26  |
| Safdarjang    | 28  | 26  |
| Palam         | 27  | 23  |

Delhi Palam Today  
31°C The weather will be slight warm. Few spells of moderate rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur. Night will be comfortable.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow  
33°C The weather will be warm. Spell of light to moderate rain and thundershower with gusty winds to occur.

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INBRIEF



A.P. CM hits out at YSRCP president ahead of local polls

Andhra Pradesh politics witnessed another sharp escalation on Thursday as Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu hit out at YSRCP president Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, stating that it would take him “just two minutes” to bring “Jagan and his company” under control. The remarks, made during a marathon Cabinet meeting at the State Secretariat in Amaravati, underscored the ruling alliance’s increasingly aggressive political strategy ahead of local body elections. Beyond a routine administrative review, the meeting took on a political dimension, with discussions centred on responding to the YSRCP on multiple fronts.

Guwahati-Tezpur corridor to be built at a cost of ₹8,970 cr.

The Union Cabinet on Thursday gave the nod for a four-lane access controlled 135-km-long corridor connecting Guwahati and Tezpur. The project is expected to be built at a total cost of ₹8,970 crore. It will reduce travel time by half, a statement from the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways said. The project will be developed under the Build-Operate-Transfer mode under which the National Highways Authority of India grants a private vendor the right to construct a facility and run it for a set period to recover costs. The project includes a 5-km-long emergency landing facility on Tezpur bypass for the Indian Air Force.

SC to consider Cong. MP’s petition alleging ‘targeted’ deletions of voters in U.P.

Barabanki MP alleges ‘misuse of Form 7 during SIR to facilitate bulk, fraudulent deletion bids against eligible electors, particularly of minority and marginalised groups’; ‘BLOs received pre-filled Form 7’

Krishnadas Rajagopal  
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has agreed to consider a plea by Congress MP Tanuj Punia highlighting “widespread misuse and fraud” in connection with Form 7 during the claims and objections phase of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Uttar Pradesh.

Form 7 is a statutory mechanism under the Registration of Electors Rules of 1960 intended to enable limited and bona fide objections to the inclusion of names in the electoral roll or deletion on narrowly defined grounds such as death or permanent shifting of residence.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on August 5, senior advocates Salman Khurshid and advocate Shariq Ahmed, representing Mr. Punia, said there was documented evidence to show that the Form 7 process was utilised to “facilitate bulk, fraudulent and targeted deletion attempts against eligible electors, particularly of those belonging to minority and marginalised sections of society”.



People searching for their names in the draft voter list after SIR in U.P. The EC exercise in the State ended in April. FILE PHOTO

The MP has arraigned the Election Commission of India and the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of Uttar Pradesh as respondents.

The Uttar Pradesh SIR process ended in April with the final voter list showing a reported 84 lakh increase in the electorate to 13.39 crore. Mr. Khurshid and Mr. Ahmed pointed out that the issue raised in Mr. Punia’s application needed to be taken up without any further delay as the process for

and, in several instances, in the names of persons who had subsequently denied filing any such objections.

It also referred to instances of Booth Level Officers having received pre-filled Form 7 applications seeking deletion of multiple electors, including electors who had already been verified during the SIR process.

The Barabanki MP said these instances had raised “serious apprehensions regarding the integrity of the objection mechanism”. The application referred specifically to one instance in which a person named ‘Yogendar’ filed objections under Form 7 against 32 electors within the same Assembly constituency in Hata, Kushinagar district.

Mr. Punia’s application said there were credible reports indicating that “numerous” Form 7 applications were generated and submitted with incomplete or false particulars of the objector, invalid identifying details, forged signatures,

State Assembly election may commence as early as December 2026 or early January next year. The court has tentatively scheduled it to come up towards the end of August.

RJD dissolves organisational units after Bankipur loss amid calls to ‘get rid of sycophants’

Amit Bhelari  
PATNA

Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) national working president Tejashwi Yadav on Thursday dissolved all organisational units in Bihar, including district, block, and panchayat committees as well as units associated with various cells and other affiliated bodies, with immediate effect.

Issuing a press note in Hindi, RJD State president Mangani Lal Mandal said the process of reconstituting the committees at all levels within the State will commence shortly.

Party sources said the decision was taken following the “crushing defeat” of RJD candidate Rekha Kumari in high-profile Bankipur byelection in which the party’s traditional vote



Tejashwi Yadav

banks, Muslims and Yadavs, “voted aggressively” for Jan Suraj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor.

The political strategist-turned-politician bagged 64,151 votes and defeated Bharatiya Janata Party’s Neeraj Kumar Sinha by a margin of 19,324 votes. Mr. Sinha finished second with 44,827 votes. The RJD candidate suffered a major setback and secured the third position with just 14,273 votes, losing her security deposit.

The defeat seems to have

rung alarm bells and forced serious introspection within the RJD as Ms. Kumari had secured 46,363 votes in the November 2025 Assembly election. In less than nine months, the core voters shifted their loyalties to a new party, JSP, which drew a blank in the 2025 election, party sources said. “In the new organisational units, the party will give opportunity to dedicated workers at the grassroots so that the RJD could be strengthened at the district, block and panchayat levels,” a senior leader said.

After the defeat, senior leader and MLA Bhai Virendra had urged Mr. Yadav to take action against some “irresponsible” leaders maligning the party’s name. He also said there was a need to get rid of the “sycophants” around Mr. Yadav.

Centre imposing E20 without any scientific assessment: Kejriwal

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convener Arvind Kejriwal on Thursday challenged the Central government to make public any scientific research report before the implementation of E20 fuel (petrol blended with 20% ethanol).

The AAP leader alleged that the Centre imposed E20 without any scientific assessment and would similarly “push E50” while those raising concerns are being intimidated into silence. Mr. Kejriwal said Prime Minister Narendra Modi is “forcing ethanol on the country under pressure from US President Donald Trump”, disregarding scientific evidence in the process. “Today, even if someone buys a new E20-compatible vehicle, the government will eventually force E50 petrol into it and damage that as well. The government is also planning to introduce ethanol blending in diesel. Therefore, people should avoid purchasing new petrol or diesel vehicles for the next few years,” he said.

‘Instagram restricted’ Mr. Kejriwal also alleged that his Instagram account has been restricted under pressure from the government and every voice raised against paper leaks and E20 fuel is being suppressed. “If they can do this to me, I can only imagine what they must be doing to ordinary people. As soon as I raised this issue, I started receiving messages and phone calls from people saying that their accounts had also been restricted,” he added.

‘Baghel go back’ chants disrupt Congress meeting in Punjab; Warring blames ‘RSS agents’

Press Trust of India  
LUDHIANA

The internal rift within the Punjab Congress seems to show no signs of abating with an organisational meeting, convened here on Thursday to take stock of the party’s preparations for the 2027 Assembly election, witnessing ‘go back’ slogans and protests against senior leaders Bhupesh Baghel and Amrinder Singh Raja Warring.

Both Congress’s Punjab in-charge Mr. Baghel and the party’s State president Mr. Warring attended the meeting at the Guru Nanak Bhawan.

Some people wearing T-shirts bearing the slogan ‘Baghel Go Back’ were spotted at the event venue and they raised slogans against both Mr. Baghel



Congress’s Punjab in-charge Bhupesh Baghel. FILE PHOTO

and Mr. Warring, alleging that the party leadership was disregarding internal dissent.

The situation escalated when Mr. Warring allegedly referred to the protesting members as “RSS agents” during his address asking them to leave, prompting renewed sloganeering and a brief scuffle between his supporters and allegedly those of former Minister Bharat Bhushan Ashu.

The disruption undermined the party’s efforts to project unity and once again brought the Punjab Congress’s internal divisions into public focus.

Mr. Warring, who is also the MP from Ludhiana, took on his detractors and those who tried to disrupt the programme. Without naming anyone, he said he had personally helped some of them “when they were hounded by the State Vigilance Bureau” and now they are raising slogans.

‘Action will be taken’ Speaking on the occasion, Mr. Baghel made it categorically clear that indiscipline has no place in the party. Those who had tried to disrupt the party programmes will be identified and action will be taken against them, he added.

Smart IDs in hand yet facing eviction, say authorised Mumbai vendors

Snehal Mutha  
MUMBAI

Holding up her laminated QR code-enabled ID card, Maya Satheliya, 52, said, “This card is not helping me as it holds no value in the eyes of the police.”

Ms. Satheliya hails from Gujarat’s Bhavnagar and has been running an authorised garment stall with her husband in Mumbai’s Borivali suburb for the past 35 years. She said the ID card was issued to her husband in June, but the “police treat us like robbers”.

“When the police aren’t around, we make a sale; when we see their car, we run like rats and they trail us. For the past one and a half years, business has been like this. Even after getting the card, there has been no change,” she said.

The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) began issuing the ID cards in May after the Bom-

bay High Court pulled up the civic body for failing to curb illegal hawking. The ID cards have been issued to 51,000 authorised vendors so far. When scanned, the QR code links to a BMC verification portal displaying the hawker’s name, ID number, and ward.

‘Clear demarcation’ “This is a smart identification system that will clearly distinguish licensed vendors from unauthorised hawkers. During anti-encroachment drives, those with ID cards will not be targeted. It will also help curb fake licences and illegal occupation of public spaces,” BMC Deputy Municipal Commissioner (Special) Vinayak Vispute said.

On May 6, a Division Bench of Justices A.S. Gadkari and Kamal Khata had given the BMC five weeks to issue the cards to 99,435 authorised hawkers identified by the civic body dur-



Authorised street vendors in Mumbai’s Borivali suburb displaying their QR code-enabled ID cards issued by the BMC. SNEHAL MUTHA

ing a survey in 2014 under the Street Vendors Act, 2014. It added that hawkers outside this list, including Bangladeshi nationals, can be evicted. The Bench was hearing seven petitions filed by hawkers’ associations in August 2024 challenging the election process of the Town Vending Committee (TVC).

The 2014 Act mandates the constitution of the TVC within six months. Despite the Act coming into force

on March 5, 2014, the Bench observed that the panel had not been formed and the process “appears to have become entangled in considerations of money, power, and politics rather than governance”.

The TVC’s role is to conduct surveys and designate vending zones and pitches. “We are awaiting government nod. Wards have proposed hawk zones. The TVC will be formed within a week,” Mr. Vispute

had said on August 5.

According to the BMC, Mumbai will have eight TVCs – one in each of the city’s seven zones and an apex panel for overall management. Each panel will have eight members drawn from the State government, hawkers’ unions, and other stakeholders.

‘Livelihoods affected’ However, the delay in forming the TVC is hurting authorised hawkers across the city. “The rampant crackdowns and delay in designating vending zones have been affecting our livelihood,” Jai Singh, representative of the Azaad Hawkers’ Association, said. Nagraj, who runs a Chinese food stall in Kurla, said his cart was seized at least three times this year. “Each time, I had to pay ₹1,200 to get it back.”

In Borivali’s Jamli Gali, Shantaram Shinde, 57, questioned the logic of is-

suing the ID cards first. “They say hawking will be allowed only when the TVC is formed; is it fair?”

Hawkers in Borivali, Kurla, and Jogeshwari have demanded at least three to four hours of daily vending during non-peak hours until zones are notified.

Ravindra Yadav, 46, a third-generation fruit seller from Jogeshwari who migrated from Jaunpur, Uttar Pradesh, received his ID card in June. He submitted it at the local police station, but was turned away.

“The police say there is no such order from the court. They ask us to bring them a circular issued by the BMC. When we approach authorities in our ward, they say the BMC is yet to send it. There is no coordination,” he said.

Mr. Yadav and the Azaad Hawkers’ Association submitted a letter at the Jogeshwari police station on July 29 seeking clarity.

Tamil Nadu budget is far-sighted and offers hope, says CM Vijay

The Hindu Bureau  
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday said the revised budget estimates, with its far-sighted vision, had instilled hope in students, youth, women, children, persons with disabilities, transpersons, workers, fishermen, weavers, entrepreneurs, government employees, and other sections of society.

In a post on social media, the Chief Minister congratulated Finance Minister N. Marie Wilson and Agriculture Minister R. Vinodh for presenting what he described as forward-looking budgets.

Mr. Vijay said the agriculture budget not only contained measures to strengthen the farm sector,



C. Joseph Vijay

but also laid emphasis on the development of allied sectors such as fisheries, dairy development, food processing, and value addition.

No relief, says Stalin DMK president M.K. Stalin dismissed the agriculture budget as an “empty” document, alleging that it had failed to provide any meaningful relief to farmers in the Cauvery delta region.



CBI arrests 4 persons in tech-support fraud case

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested four persons, including the “mastermind”, who were part of a syndicate that ran a tech-support fraud and extortion racket through call centres and offices across Punjab and Delhi. The group primarily targeted U.S. nationals, said the agency on Thursday.

In the intervening night of August 5 and 6, the CBI raided 10 locations in Punjab and Delhi, including a call centre operated from the premises of the main accused in Mohali, and arrested the accused. It seized communication and storage drives, cash, and details of cryptocurrency wallets.

Those arrested are Sourabh Rana, the prime accused; and his alleged associates Indermohan Singh, Harneet Singh, and Jappandeep Singh. The CBI alleged that the accused posed as representatives of Microsoft, financial institutions, and law enforcement agencies to cheat victims.

In one case in 2022, the syndicate allegedly extorted \$4.40 lakh from a Florida resident by “threatening” her that her personal and financial information had been compromised and that illegal material had been planted on her computer. She was coerced into making multiple transactions into a Bitcoin ATM. The funds were routed to a specific wallet address for transfer to the accounts controlled by the accused.

Kerala set to launch project to improve police-citizen ties

‘My Police Station’ aims at making police force accessible and accountable; the responsibility of Station House Officers will be entrusted to sub-inspectors, says Home Minister Chennithala

The Hindu Bureau  
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Kerala’s police system and police stations will undergo a major transformation starting August 15, with the launch of a new initiative titled “My Police Station”, which is aimed at making the police force more accessible and accountable to the public, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said at a press conference here on Thursday.

Calling it a historic reformation of the Kerala Police, Mr. Chennithala said the new initiative was a decisive step towards democratic policing that delivers better service to citizens.



Sub-inspectors will take charge as SHOs in 419 stations out of the State’s 484 law-and-order police stations. REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

Another key objective would be to completely eliminate custodial crimes, including custodial deaths and custodial violence.

From August 15, the responsibility of Station House Officers (SHOs) will be entrusted to sub-inspec-

tors. This is a reversal of the previous government’s decision to appoint Circle Inspectors to the posts.

**Strategic placements**  
The Minister said that this change would give young male and female officers

directly recruited to the posts of SIs, a greater sense of responsibility and sharpen their efficiency and decision-making abilities, he added.

Sub-inspectors will take charge as SHOs in 419 stations out of the State’s 484 law-and-order police stations. Notably, women sub-inspectors will become SHOs in 63 police stations across the State.

In 64 stations of strategic significance, police officials in the rank of Circle Inspectors will continue to serve as SHOs.

Given the strategic importance of the Mullaperiyar dam, the SHO post at that station will remain with a Deputy Superintendent of Police (DySP).

SC mulls shift of T.N. case against ED officer to CBI

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday mulled the transfer of a Tamil Nadu Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) case of bribery against the Enforcement Directorate (ED) officer Ankit Tiwari to an independent Central probe agency.

A Bench headed by the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, meanwhile, refused to lift the stay on criminal proceedings in the case.

The court was hearing a plea by the ED to transfer the case from the State DVAC to an agency such as the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI). The apex court had stayed the proceedings in the DVAC case in January 2024.

‘Collaboration, not blame game, needed to tackle Assam flood’

Rahul Karmakar  
GUWAHATI

Assam and Nagaland should avoid blaming each other for the devastating flood and adopt a collaborative approach to tackle natural disasters, Nagaland’s Tourism and Higher Education Minister Temjen Imna Along said.

Many in Assam believe illegal mining activities and large-scale felling in Nagaland contributed to the devastating flood in eastern Assam’s Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat districts. Since April, the flood in these and 13 other districts has claimed 95 human lives and affected more than 7.5 lakh people so far.

“The Nagaland government has noted what Assam’s Chief Minister has conveyed. We are sure that the CMs of both the States are in touch regarding the natural calamities,” Mr. Along, a senior Bharatiya Janata Party leader, said on Wednesday. “We cannot blame each other for anything. We have to take collective measures to minimise such disasters,” he said, pointing out that Nagaland also suffered damage due to the recent spell of heavy rain. At least 11 people were killed in Nagaland’s Mon town on July 19 after heavy rain triggered landslips.

**‘Logging banned’**  
Mr. Along added that the Nagaland government has been undertaking afforestation and biodiversity conservation initiatives to restore the ecological ba-



Nagaland Minister Temjen Imna Along. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

lance. He claimed logging has been almost banned in the State.

Meanwhile, Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday announced a crackdown on unauthorised flood relief collection drives in public spaces, warning of strict police action against those demanding donations in the name of the flood victims.

Many groups have been collecting money ostensibly for flood-affected people from business establishments and residential units in urban centres, including Guwahati, and from motorists and pedestrians on the streets and highways. Individuals and organisations have been moving around with collection boxes or using QR codes to seek contributions.

Education Minister Ranoj Pegu said regular classes in schools across the flood-affected districts would resume from August 10. “There will be alternative arrangements for students of institutions that remain unfit for reopening due to flood damage,” he said.

Karnataka holds talks with Anthropic on AI

The Hindu Bureau  
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Thursday held discussions with a delegation from Anthropic on forging a long-term partnership to accelerate the adoption of artificial intelligence across governance, higher education, healthcare, research and the State’s startup ecosystem.

The meeting focused on

deploying applied AI solutions for both government and enterprise use cases, with an emphasis on “beneficial deployment” of AI while ensuring responsible use, data privacy and data sovereignty.

Discussions also covered the introduction of AI-focused certification programmes, including Claude certification and the use of AI in healthcare and life sciences, including AI for scientific research.

‘Raise income cap for tribals’ scholarships’

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The Kerala government has demanded that the Centre enhance the family income ceiling from ₹2.5 lakh to ₹4.5 lakh-₹5 lakh for availing post-metric scholarships by tribal students. In a memorandum submitted to Union Tribal Affairs Minister Jual Oram, Kerala Minister for Welfare of Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Back-

wards Classes K.A. Thulasi said the change in the ceiling was necessary, given the rising living costs.

The State said in the memorandum that the Centre might consider revising the implementation guidelines for the Grants-in-Aid under Article 275(1) of the Constitution to provide flexibility in the prescribed project period, particularly for infrastructure works executed in remote tribal areas.



सत्यमेव जयते  
दिल्ली सरकार

Greetings on

# National Handloom Day

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Today is a day to celebrate our rich weaving traditions, which showcase the creativity of our people. We are proud of India’s handloom diversity and its role in furthering livelihoods and prosperity.

-Narendra Modi, Prime Minister



Preserving Heritage | Empowering Artisans | Weaving India’s Future

**Rekha Gupta**  
Chief Minister, Delhi



YAMUNA RIVER  
RED FORT  
CONNAUGHT PLACE  
INDIA GATE  
AKSHARDHAM  
LOTUS TEMPLE  
QUTUB MINAR  
CHHATTARPUR TEMPLE

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/064/26-27

Narendra Modi  
Prime Minister

Preserving Heritage | Empowering Artisans | Weaving India’s Future

Rekha Gupta  
Chief Minister, Delhi



SPOTLIGHT



West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya holds the party's flag as former Trinamool Congress MPs Sushmita Dev, Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, and Prakash Chik Baraik join his party, in Kolkata. SAIKAT PAUL

# Bengal BJP fights against its ‘Trinamoolification’

Having coming to power in West Bengal earlier this year, the State unit of the BJP is facing a major political challenge, which party leaders are describing as its ‘Trinamoolification’. Implicit in this word is that several leaders from the Trinamool Congress are joining the party and being given key responsibilities, and that the BJP is embracing the very culture of the party it opposed and contested against, finds **Shiv Sahay Singh**

**D**ays after the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) swept the West Bengal Assembly poll in 2026, winning 207 of the 293 seats, West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya made a bold political claim. “Our doors are closed for Trinamool. There will be no ‘Trinamoolification’ of the BJP,” Bhattacharya had said. The 62-year-old leader, who had been a foot soldier of the party when its vote share was in single digits in West Bengal was among the first to use the phrase, “Trinamoolification of the BJP”.

He didn’t know then that on the afternoon of July 9, he would be handing out lotus-insignia party flags to three former Trinamool Congress (TMC) MPs at the BJP office in Kolkata’s Salt Lake area. The three MPs were Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Sushmita Dev, and Prakash Chik Baraik. They had been nominated to the Rajya Sabha by the Trinamool Congress, and had resigned after the party suffered an electoral setback in the Assembly poll. When in the Trinamool, they had publicly criticised the BJP.

Within hours of Bhattacharya welcoming the Trinamool leaders into the BJP fold, the party announced that the former Trinamool MPs were to be renominated to the Upper House with the support of newly elected BJP legislators. Bhattacharya tried to defend opening doors for the Trinamool leaders by saying that the decision was in national interest.

“Syama Prasad Mookerjee has taught us that the party is bigger than an individual, and the nation is bigger than the party,” he said, trying hard to say that inducting the three leaders into the party was an “exception”.

The Bengal BJP president who had spoken about the party’s doors being closed for Trinamool members, is now saying that those in the Trinamool who could not raise their voices in the party are now knocking on BJP doors and the party may consider opening its doors at an opportune moment.

To many, the Trinamoolification of the BJP started even before the party won the 2026 Assembly poll. Former West Bengal BJP president Dilip Ghosh, now a prominent Minister in the West Bengal government, took a swipe at Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari by saying that it was

**“We do not know what our central leadership is thinking. They want to increase numbers in Parliament. But why will (former) Trinamool leaders be nominated to the Rajya Sabha by the BJP?”**  
**NIKHIL RANJAN DEY**  
FORMER BJP MLA  
FROM COOCH BEHAR

not new for Trinamool leaders to join the BJP. “Where is it written in the BJP that people from other parties cannot join. Our Chief Minister is also a former Trinamool (leader),” Ghosh said.

Ghosh’s reference to Adhikari points to the unease in BJP’s rank and file. Adhikari, once a key Trinamool leader and Minister in Mamata Banerjee’s government, defected to the BJP in December 2020. Adhikari, who defeated Mamata Banerjee twice at Nandigram in 2021 and Bhabanipur in 2026, was chosen to lead the BJP government in West Bengal, five years after joining the party.

### Good TMC vs not-so-good TMC

After the defeat in the West Bengal Assembly poll in 2026, the Trinamool Congress has been torn apart by rebellion and desertions. The majority of Lok Sabha MPs and party MLAs decided to part ways with party chairperson Mamata Banerjee.

Despite being the beneficiaries of the Trinamool Congress’s politics, these MPs and MLAs have blamed the party chairperson for favouring her nephew Abhishek Banerjee and allowing corruption and misrule to persist.

Of the 28 Lok Sabha MPs of the Trinamool Congress, 20 have merged with the little-known Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), and have become a part of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

Of the 80 MLAs of the Trinamool Congress who were elected to the 18th West Bengal Legislative Assembly, 65 legislators decided to support the claim of Ritabrata Banerjee as the Leader of the Opposition, against the writ of Mamata Banerjee. One of the reasons behind the rebellion of both the MPs and MLAs of the Trinamool Congress is the opportunity to cosy up to the

BJP, the party in power both at the Centre and in the State.

The BJP leadership in West Bengal, which is perceived as being soft on the rebel MPs and MLAs, has come out with a theory of “*bhalo* (good) Trinamool”. The Lok Sabha MPs, who have decided to join the NDA, have allegedly been told that after delimitation, when the seats increase, so will their chances of returning to Parliament in 2029.

On August 4, Chief Minister Adhikari met the NCPI MPs in Delhi. He was joined by Union Minister Bhupender Yadav, who was election-in-charge of West Bengal, and BJP MP Nishikant Dubey. If the photograph of Samik Bhattacharya handing over party flags to the three Rajya Sabha MPs created discomfort in the BJP’s rank and file, the Chief Minister’s photograph with the NCPI MPs was reason for heartburn.

The “good Trinamool” is the rebel camp led by Leader of the Opposition Ritabrata Banerjee. Banerjee, who was a Communist Party of India (Marxist) nominee to Rajya Sabha, joined the Trinamool Congress in 2020 after the CPI(M) expelled him. The Trinamool Congress re-nominated him to Rajya Sabha for a second term in 2024. In 2026, he resigned from the Upper House to contest the Assembly poll from Uluberia Purbia.

The rebel MLAs led by his camp are claiming to be the “original Trinamool” and have sought the party’s symbol from the Election Commission and laid claim to hundreds of crores of party funds.

After the change of regime, hundreds of local-level Trinamool Congress workers have been arrested by the police on charges of corruption, extortion, and electoral violence. Many were attacked with eggs when they were being taken into custody or being produced before courts. However, the MPs and MLAs of the “good Trinamool” have not faced police action after warming up to the BJP.

Among the handful of loyalists left by Mamata Banerjee’s side is Belegghata MLA Kunal Ghosh. After an under-construction warehouse collapsed in Kolkata’s Taratala area on June 24 burying 16 workers, Chief Minister Adhikari blamed it on the former Trinamool Congress regime.

Adhikari held up a document in the West Bengal Legislative Assembly with the signature of former mayor of Kolkata Municipal Corporation Firhad Hakim, and said no one would be spared. Ghosh dared the Chief Minister to act against Hakim to prove that the State government was serious about taking action against those responsible for the deaths. Hakim, who was one of the key Ministers during Mamata Banerjee’s regime, joined the Ritabrata Banerjee camp, and despite the Chief Minister blaming him for the tragedy, the only high-profile arrest was his former personal assistant.

With the majority of the Trinamool leaders now part of the “good Trinamool” camp, it is Mamata Banerjee and a handful of her loyalists who are being blamed by the BJP for they say was “misrule and corruption” over the past 15

years. The BJP government in West Bengal is yet to complete 100 days. It is already faced with something it had accused the Trinamool Congress leadership of over the past several years: extortion and political corruption.

### The reverse ‘egg therapy’

In the past three months several businesses have alleged that BJP leaders have demanded money from them and they have had to reach out to the police seeking protection.

Sources in the BJP said that the party has suspended 22 functionaries, including several mandal presidents, over allegations of extortion and indiscipline.

Senior leaders of the BJP, including party president are warning its workers against extortion. While former State BJP president and Minister Dilip Ghosh said that many leaders are becoming addicted to this “honey of extortion”, the current State BJP chief has warned party members to mend their ways.

“The unwarranted egg therapy we see now (referring to Trinamool leaders being attacked with eggs) can turn on its head and start falling on the other side as well. Everyone, including those in my party, must understand that. Those ‘Sanatanis’ who have suddenly found a place in our party and are harbouring aspirations for influence and advantage must also remain careful because the trajectory of those eggs can change in no time,” Bhattacharya said.

It is the BJP workers in the districts who are most upset with Trinamool leaders warming up to the BJP, but only a few have mustered the courage to speak about it publicly. Nikhil Ranjan Dey, a former BJP MLA from Cooch Behar, came out in public against the nomination of the three former Trinamool Congress MPs to Rajya Sabha by his party.

“We do not know what our central leadership is thinking. They want to increase numbers in Parliament. But why will (former) Trinamool leaders be nominated to the Rajya Sabha by the BJP? Are there not enough qualified and educated people in the BJP?” the former MLA said.

Dey said that several BJP workers have suffered at the hands of the Trinamool Congress and are still languishing behind the bars after being booked under what he claims are false charges during the Trinamool Congress regime.

In fact, former Trinamool leaders had once even allegedly called for violence against BJP members. One such example is of former Trinamool Congress MP and actor Nushrat Jahan, who represented the Jadavpur Lok Sabha seat from 2019 to 2024.

She was photographed with BJP leaders at an event to honour exiled Bangladeshi writer Taslima Nasrin. The photo went viral and was criticised by several right-wing online portals.

The portals highlighted how, before the election, the actor-turned-politician had been heard telling the electorate to beat up BJP leaders with bamboo sticks if they came seeking votes.

### Personal versus the political

Sudip Bandyopadhyay is an MP from the Kolkata North Lok Sabha seat. After parting ways with Mamata Banerjee, he is the senior-most MP of the NCPI, and is now holding meetings with the BJP leadership in the national capital.

While Bandyopadhyay is meeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Adhikari, BJP’s Tapas Roy, now Minister of Industries and Commerce in the West Bengal government, is fuming. “I will never have anything to do with him. I hate him, because of what he did to me,” Roy said.

The Manicktala MLA left the Trinamool Congress and joined the BJP in 2024. That year, he lost the Lok Sabha polls to Bandyopadhyay. Roy has publicly said that Bandyopadhyay was the reason he had to quit the Trinamool Congress, and join the BJP. He claims that Bandyopadhyay was behind a raid at his residence when he was with the Trinamool, a charge Bandyopadhyay has vehemently denied.

The only thing that is keeping the 70-year-old BJP leader happy: “It is very comforting to see the Trinamool Congress crumbling.”

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West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari with former Trinamool Congress MPs who have merged with NCPI, in Delhi. Three former Trinamool MPs who were nominated to the Rajya Sabha on a BJP ticket are also present. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT





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No human was hurt in the making of this film, says Amit Rai, tongue firmly in cheek, as he explains the unique selling point of his recent film *Ohh My Dog*. The title is a play on the writer-director's last film, *Oh My God 2*, his first commercial and critical success after years of struggle following the National Award-winning *Road To Sangam*. The inspiration, Amit says, was the dog at home, Oscar. "You think you have rescued a dog, brought him home, and you are nurturing him. Within a month I realised that it was not me; it was the dog that was cradling me. If I had to save one person in life, it would be Oscar."

A dog, he says, gives you unconditional love, but it cannot be explained to someone who does not have a pet. "You will understand what a dog does to you only when you bring one into your life. That's why I suggest that those who have a pet watch the film, but those who haven't must definitely watch it."

Coming at a time when the fate of stray dogs is being debated in courtrooms and resident welfare associations, the film, Amit says, draws from the famous

# Rooting for the underdog

**Amit Rai, director of *Ohh My Dog*, seeks compassion for strays and questions the decline in the number of children's films made in the country**

*Mahabharata* story in which Yudhishtir insists that he will enter the gate of heaven only with his dog. "Dharamraj says the dog has followed his duty; he will fulfil his. The dog stayed with him when his near and dear ones left him. Yudhishtir's righteousness helps the canine cross over."

Amit says the system works according to its own wisdom, "but we can't let our compassion die. If you are not compassionate towards dogs today, I guarantee you will not show mercy towards humans in the future. We have to find a solution. We can't be ruthless." This

problem, he adds, has not come overnight. "During dark nights when community dogs kept thieves out, we didn't complain. I don't know when the dog became a symbol of abuse in our vocabulary. But we do know that life is about coexistence. An ant has as much right on this land as I have."

On the role of dog feeders, Amit says that just as no one knows the pains a filmmaker endures to complete a film; not many know the effort one puts into caring for stray dogs. "We can see their intent; the process can be debated upon. Nobody appoints those who are

Teaching the future (Left) A still from the sets of *Ohh My Dog*; (below right) director Amit Rai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



speaking in favour of dogs. They are speaking out of their own volition."

Amit says the subject had been with him for a long time, and that it was fast-tracked when yet another of his projects fell through just days before going into production. "I came to Mumbai in bathroom slippers. After struggling for many years, if the ecosystem is not letting us flow with the tide, let it be. We will flow against it," says the filmmaker. "*Ohh My Dog* is a big film, and I haven't cut corners even if it meant co-producing it."

Shot in Assam and Bihar, the film has a crucial scene where over 200 dogs are shown chasing ambulances. "These are untrained dogs. With the help of an NGO that uses an ambulance to feed stray dogs, we followed a process for several days to create the cinematic impact."

For the trailer, he has used the popular Amitabh Bachchan number, 'Mere Paas Aao Mere Dosto Ek Kissa Suno' from *Mr Natwarlal* to evoke curiosity about the story. "I didn't have the budget to cast

Bachchanji, so the next best thing was to use his voice. Sa Re Ga Ma liked the intent and waived off the charges for using the song."

Filled with love, imagination, passion and loyalty, Amit says, on the one side is a boy who does everything to save his dog, and on the other is a dog who puts its life on the line to save his master. It reminds one of the Jackie Shroff-starrer *Teri Meharbaniyan* (1985) that the Doordarshan generation grew up watching. "It takes the conversation forward, but I must say *meharbani* (kindness) is the right word for a dog's role in our life. They say, 'we never gave up on you; now it is your turn'," says the filmmaker whose son Mahi plays the lead role of the child in search of his dog, Momo, played by Oscar, along with seasoned actors Pawan Malhotra and Pankaj Tripathi. The star of the film is Bruno, an indigenous dog whom Amit borrowed from a friendly neighbour. "In the last 10 years, we have hardly had any meaningful children's films. If films are not made for children, how will they appreciate cinema, how will they imbibe values they must uphold?"

*Ohh My Dog* is currently running in theatres.

## STEP OUT



**A painter's vision**

For more than five decades, CK Rajan has explored colour, geometry and space through a quietly evolving visual language. Rajan Too, a new exhibition curated by Grant Watson, brings together works that reflect the breadth of the artist's practice while offering fresh insight into his enduring engagement with abstraction. The exhibition opens on August 7 with a preview from 6pm to 8.30pm, followed by a curator-led walkthrough by Watson on August 8 at 11.30am. It will remain on view until September 26 at Galerie Mirchandani + Steinruecke.



**Artistic heritage**

Classical dance traditions take centrestage as the 21st edition of Saare Jahan Se Accha – Vande Maataram: Bharat Ki Virasat, Bharat Ka Gaurav returns to Delhi. Presented by Utsav Educational & Cultural Society and curated by Ranjana Gauhar, the two-day festival features Odissi, Bharatanatyam and Kathak performances by leading gurus and their disciples. The opening evening includes Ranjana's production *Chitrangada – The Warrior Princess* and the presentation of the Utsav Samman Lifetime Achievement Awards. On August 10 and 11, from 7pm onwards, at Stein Auditorium, IHC.

# Piece of pie

**Restaurateur Amol Kumar on his culinary journey and plans for expansion in Delhi-NCR**



Staying original Leo's Pizzeria in Delhi has been making artisanal pizzas for a decade now. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

## Deepali Dhingra

When Amol Kumar launched Leo's Pizzeria in a quiet by-lane off Delhi's MG Road in December 2016, he was not looking to build a long-term legacy. He was only trying to survive. "I wasn't even sure if we'd make it to year one," Amol recalls, sitting at their spacious Vasant Vihar outlet. "I was making every pizza at the time. I thought if I could just do this for a year, I'd be proud of myself." Ten years later, the neighbourhood pizzeria has rewritten Delhi's artisanal pizza narrative. Today, Amol is orchestrating a massive regional expansion, preparing a new Gurugram outpost for a mid-August 2026 launch and has debuted NYNY, a New York-style slice shop in Hauz Khas, even as he eyes other cities. The growth comes on the heels of a major international validation. Leo's was recently named in One To Follow in the prestigious The Best Pizza - Milan 2026 list, alongside its fourth consecutive appearance on the 50 Top Pizza Asia-Pacific list, ranking at No. 41. However, for someone who helped pioneer India's authentic Neapolitan movement, Amol spent his youth as far away from the kitchen as possible. While studying



Hospitality in Switzerland, he had teachers who told him that he didn't belong in the kitchen. It took a decade for him to find his way back to the stoves. The seeds, however, had been planted long before. In Switzerland, he watched a husband-and-wife team run a tiny pizzeria. "I thought, that's the dream. You find your person, you run a little place, and you share it with the world."

When Leo's first opened in December 2016, the challenges were monumental. Italian flour was a myth on local shelves, tomatoes lacked consistency, and finding premium charcuterie required a bit of espionage. Educating the diner was an even bigger challenge. With customers familiar with the pan-baked or thin crusts from fast-food giants, a soft, blistered Neapolitan slice was an alien concept. In fact, the first Leo's menu included a graphic-heavy booklet teaching people how to fold and hold their pizza. Amol is still hands-on with the dough, keeping his palate sharp with annual trips to Italy and Tokyo. And when the day is over, the globally-lauded pizzaiolo still retreats to the same comfort food that sustained him during the brutal first few years of Leo's. "I just want my *dal chawal*," he smiles.



Runway glam (From far left) Aditi Rao Hydari walks for Jayanti Reddy; and models don creations by Masaba and Isha Jajodia; (below) design by Masaba. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

of Roseroom shared, "Form-flattering corsets offer a timeless silhouette that enhances the figure, provides structure and can be adapted for various styles, from classic to contemporary." For this outing, corsetry held the entire collection together. It ran through more than 50 looks: corseted gowns, skirts, sarees, tailored jackets, tuxedos and tulle skirts. That range was the experiment: proving corsetry isn't a bridal-gown technique alone, but flexible enough to move through a sari as easily as a tuxedo, while letting a bride carry both softness and strength. Bralettes replaced the traditional blouse seen at almost every designer showcase this season – from Falguni and Shane Peacock to Masaba and Arpita Mehta. Designer Jayanti Reddy's collection explored the idea of refined opulence. With the Gilded Era, she wanted to celebrate light as a design element, using shimmer, metallic textures and intricate embellishment in a way that feels subtle, fluid and modern rather than overtly ornate. Celebrated for his maximalist designs steeped with a deep heritage narrative, designer JJ Valaya was fascinated by the Siddhis and by this extraordinary confluence of African origins and the many cultural influences absorbed over generations on the Indian subcontinent. "This is not a literal interpretation of a community. For me, it became a larger meditation on movement, memory and identity .... and on how cultures evolve when they travel," he says.



# Train, corset, repeat

**From statement capes and sculpted corsets to bold bralettes, we bring you trends from the Hyundai India Couture Week 2026**

## Manish Mishra

For designers participating at the Hyundai India Couture Week 2026, the modern bride was about whimsy as much as she was about tradition. Held in association with Nexxus New York, the Fashion Design Council of India-led showcase in New Delhi witnessed 13 leading Indian designers re-examine contemporary bridal couture with a fresh lens. This season saw designers experiment with newer silhouettes and unexpected embroidery techniques, and propose a sartorial palate-cleansing wedding closet for brides, grooms and their families. Read on for our picks from the season, to get your wardrobe wedding-ready. There is no stopping the popularity of statement capes, capelets and trains seen across brands like Falguni Shane

Peacock, JJ Valaya, Arpita Mehta, Roseroom Couture, Jayanti Reddy and Masaba. While Falguni Shane Peacock's menswear saw cocktail and reception attires layered with billowing parachute-like long capes, Masaba's capes in saturated hues evoked a playful destination pre-wedding bash, and JJ's tasselled capelets added drama to ornate ensembles. "Capes and veils are definitely replacing the dupatta for a certain kind of consumer, but I think the market is divided into two categories. One wants a more experimental layer, which could be a cape or a veil. The other still prefers a dupatta because it can be treated as a separate piece, styled in different ways, and worn across multiple looks," said designer Masaba. Jewellery informs couture Known for high-octane shine and inventive textiles, Rimzim Dadu's collection's take-off point was mother-of-pearl, its luminosity

and the way it catches and reflects light. "The collection also draws inspiration from the intricate inlay work of Mughal architecture and the ornamentation and opulence of jewellery from that era," she said. "We paired mother-of-pearl with our signature steel wire textiles, metallic cords and sculptural constructions, experimenting with how these contrasting materials could coexist." Designers underscored the drama with a clever incorporation of jewellery accents – from beaded headgear to veils partially covering model's faces. JJ Valaya's brides came with bejewelled facial veils. Designer Isha Jajodia





## Stop the scam

The digital arrest scam persists from overseas actors

The Supreme Court of India’s order of August 4 on the “digital arrest” menace is notable for not being lured into complacency. After all, the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre’s status report showed that complaints on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal fell from 1,23,672 in 2024 to 58,249 in 2025, and stood at 16,377 in the first six months of 2026. The Court called the figures “certainly encouraging” and directed the Reserve Bank of India to circulate a standard operating procedure for temporary debit holds on mule accounts, States to notify cybercrime coordination centres and operationalise e-Zero FIRs, and an inter-departmental committee to examine a victim compensation framework. Thanks to advisories from banks, telecom operators and the police, fewer senior citizens and others are getting victimised by these scams, which have succeeded due to older victims’ deference to authority and fear of legal trouble. Yet, scammers find it easy to target youth and professionals, and senior citizens the advisories have not reached. And there have been very few convictions despite scrutiny and investigation, which suggests that law enforcement must move faster in tackling these scams.

The digital scammers have proved nimble in their *modus operandi*. They route calls through SIM boxes to mask their origin, making them appear as Indian numbers, and use multiple mule accounts across many States to move funds swiftly. They are now known to deploy deepfakes on video calls to dupe victims and remain untraceable by investigators. In effect, the fraudsters always seem to be a step ahead of those pursuing them. The Court’s insistence on restoring money – completed in 36,290 cases involving ₹18.05 crore – and on the swift disposing of account-freeze cases, alongside detection systems such as MuleHunter.AI, used in over 20 banks, will help limit the damage even when perpetrators are not caught or convicted. But convictions are rare as many of these fraud and extortion schemes are run from overseas “scam compounds” in Myanmar, the wider Golden Triangle, and Cambodia. In Myanmar, scam centres proliferated through direct and indirect official patronage, even as recent scrutiny produced raids that were largely for show with these centres shifting to new areas in the conflict-ridden country. After Beijing’s crack-down, in 2023, on scam centres targeting Chinese victims, scammers shifted focus to other countries, with Indians also being trafficked and tortured to commit digital crimes against fellow citizens. New Delhi must use diplomatic pressure in coordination with China, the U.S. and ASEAN to compel Naypyidaw and Phnom Penh to act against the networks that host these compounds.

## Access paradox

Private medical education widens access, but affects affordability

The scope of medical education in India has expanded so rapidly that it raises important questions about access to it. The number of seats has nearly tripled in 12 years, thanks in part to the government’s push to improve access to health care, entailing infrastructure upgrades and simplified regulations. However, much of the growth has been happening in the private sector, in addition to new government colleges attached to district hospitals. This year, for the first time, private institutions host more than half of all MBBS seats. Of the roughly 10,000 new seats, 79% are in such institutions, a sign that growth in the near future will remain concentrated thus. The increase in seats is, in and of itself, commendable as India’s students still compete fiercely for MBBS seats even as health-care centres suffer a debilitating shortage of specialist practitioners. Thousands of students also seek education abroad. Therefore, expanding domestic ‘capacity’ is a natural response and the rising number of seats ought to relieve the bottleneck and keep talent at home.

But problems abound. Whereas an MBBS seat in a government college rarely exceeds ₹5 lakh for the full term, that in a private institution can cost 10 times more, sustained in part by the unflagging demand for health care. These institutions’ commercial viability is clustered in specific geographies, especially in tier-I and -II cities in the more prosperous States, where incomes are higher. Unless their students deliberately fan out after graduation, their skills also become concentrated in these clusters, whereas the paucity of health-care providers is felt more keenly in the rural areas farther away. Rapid growth also raises the risk of highly uneven quality, with institutions seeking to secure NMC accreditation with the bare minimum of facilities rather than mindfully addressing local needs. ‘Capitation fees’, which persist despite government bans, create new debt that can influence behaviour after graduation. Finally, sans competitive salaries, housing and schools, and assured career progression, graduates gravitate to private practice or abroad. Paradoxically, then, the surge in private capacity obligates the government to keep adding capacity, including opening new AIIMS-like institutions, so the number of cheap seats also keeps increasing. The NMC’s rule of having half of all private institution seats be charged at government rates should be enforced; the NMC should also embrace mechanisms that support surprise inspections and the ability to inspect records without institutions’ permission. Finally, beyond compelling rural service, governments should reward it, in addition to ensuring that the daily needs of rural health-care workers and their families and of hospitals are both well-met.

“When we are finished, take over your government. It will be yours to take. This will be probably your only chance for generations,” United States President Donald Trump told Iranians on February 28, 2026, after the U.S. and Israel assassinated Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and launched a war against the country. More than five months later, the war that Mr. Trump believed would be over in weeks, if not days, is far from over. The Islamic Republic has not only survived but has also consolidated its position, at home and in the region. Mr. Trump has alternated between strikes, ceasefires, talks, threats, ultimatums, renewed strikes, and U-turns in an attempt to shape the course and outcome of the conflict and the behaviour of the Iranian state, while seeking a face-saving exit. But with the war unresolved and his objectives unmet, Mr. Trump, confronting a resolute yet risk-tolerant Tehran, has found himself in a strategic cul-de-sac.

The U.S. and Israel launched the war with four principal objectives: destroy Iran’s nuclear programme; dismantle its missile capabilities and military industrial base; end Tehran’s support for its non-state quartet (Hamas, Houthis, Hezbollah and Hashad) and bring about a regime change. The first three objectives, however, were inseparable from the fourth. Without toppling the Islamic Republic, achieving any of the other goals appeared impossible even before the war began. This makes regime change or regime collapse the central strategic aim of the war on which all the others depended.

### The President’s grave miscalculation

The challenge before Mr. Trump was to engineer regime change through an aerial campaign alone. He was unwilling to commit ground troops, and the U.S. lacked a credible local ally capable of leading an armed insurgency against Tehran. Mr. Trump initially seemed aware of the risks of attacking Iran. In June 2025, the U.S. joined Israel in striking Iran’s nuclear facilities but quickly stepped back. He then declared that he had “obliterated” Iran’s nuclear programme and compelled Israel to accept a ceasefire. Determined to avoid a wider regional conflict, he sought to prevent the war from spiralling out of control.

But by February 2026, two developments, along with sustained pressure from Israel, appeared to have convinced him that Iran could be defeated in a short war. The first was the U.S. invasion of Venezuela in early January, which in Mr. Trump’s view was a resounding success. U.S. forces abducted President Nicolás Maduro, and withdrew without suffering casualties. Venezuelan Vice-President Delcy Rodríguez, who assumed the acting presidency, quickly offered full cooperation with Washington. The second was the wave of violent protests and riots across



Stanly Johny

Iran in January, which reinforced the belief in Washington and Tel Aviv that the government in Tehran had been fatally weakened. They believed that by bombing Iran and decapitating its leadership, the regime would either collapse or result in a new leadership willing to cooperate with Washington, much as they believed had happened in Venezuela. This proved to be a grave miscalculation.

### The three pillars of Iran’s response

Iran’s response rested on three pillars – preserving the state; regionalising the war; and enhancing its economic cost through horizontal escalation. Tehran understood that because Mr. Trump’s other war aims were dependent on regime change, preserving the Islamic Republic would, by itself, deny Washington its broader objectives. Mr. Trump mistook Iran for a personality-driven authoritarian regime, which could crumble once the head was taken out. But the Iranian state is sustained by a deeply-entrenched institutional system and an ideology that fuses Shia notions of sacrifice with the ideals of political revolution. Under attack, the state – designed and built to withstand both internal and external shocks – consolidated, while millions rallied around the flag.

The second element was to turn the U.S. bases in the region, built to project American power and protect its allies, into vulnerable targets. Tehran shut down the Strait of Hormuz through which roughly 20% of the world’s seaborne crude oil passed before the war. It turned the Persian Gulf into a battlefield and kept American warships out of it. The Iranian view was that if it was not allowed to export crude, nobody in the Gulf would be able to do so through the Strait. Surprisingly, the U.S. had no contingency plan for the closure of the Strait. Once the waterway was shut, the dynamics of the war began to shift. It was at that point that Mr. Trump began to lose the strategic initiative.

After 40 days of bombing, Mr. Trump announced a ceasefire on April 8. Since then, he has been searching for a dignified exit from the conflict. On June 17, he signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with Iran, under which Washington made significant concessions. Unable to present the MoU as a victory at home, however, Mr. Trump soon resumed military strikes, only to be met each time with Iranian retaliation. The ensuing cycle of escalation pushed Washington even farther from its original objectives, while Iran’s willingness to take risks continued to grow.

The war has inflicted immense damage to Iran’s military infrastructure and economy. Yet, Tehran, which has lived under U.S. sanctions for nearly five decades, seems willing to absorb the pain because it sees a strategic opportunity to reshape the regional balance of power at a time when the U.S. is confronting the limits of its own overreach.

America’s Iran war stalls as Tehran turns pressure into strategic advantage

# Handloom — weaving India’s heritage into global growth

The making of a developed nation is not defined by technology alone. It is shaped by the ability to transform enduring strengths into engines of future growth. As India advances towards Viksit Bharat 2047, it is investing in frontier technologies, strengthening manufacturing and building globally competitive industries.

Yet, one of India’s greatest strengths has been with India all along – its handloom tradition. On August 7, as India marks the 12th National Handloom Day, it is time to view handloom as a strategic sector for a world that values sustainability, authenticity and resilient supply chains.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision of Viksit Bharat 2047 is built on prosperity, self-reliance, inclusivity and cultural confidence. Handloom embodies this vision by bringing together heritage and innovation, while driving women-led development, rural entrepreneurship, livelihoods and global competitiveness.

### Threads of India’s legacy

Every handwoven fabric reflects the courage to preserve tradition, the patience to perfect every thread, the integrity of honest craftsmanship and the wisdom passed down through generations. That is why handloom is not merely a craft, but one of India’s greatest civilisational strengths. From the Indus Valley Civilisation, where cotton was first cultivated and woven, to the 18th century when Indian textiles dominated global trade, India set global benchmarks in textile excellence. Bengal’s legendary muslin – so fine that a 25-metre length could pass through a ring – along with Banarasi silk, Kanchipuram weaves, Pochampally Ikat and countless regional traditions, earned India worldwide admiration.

Today, as the world turns towards authentic, sustainable and handcrafted products, India has a historic opportunity to reclaim that leadership.



Giriraj Singh

Union Minister of Textiles, Government of India

India’s ancient handloom traditions can transform heritage into a globally competitive creative economy

India’s next handloom revolution must export not just textiles, but also craftsmanship, heritage, innovation and trust, making every handwoven product an ambassador of Brand India.

### Transformation through policy

Handloom is India’s largest cottage industry, supporting the livelihoods of more than 35 lakh weavers and allied workers, nearly 72% of whom are women. Over the past decade, the Government has strengthened the sector through the Raw Material Supply Scheme, 797 handloom clusters, over 1.24 lakh improved looms, skill upgradation for nearly 97,000 artisans, and initiatives such as Producer Companies, GI tagged products, the Handloom Mark, India Handmade certification, Urban Haats and Design Resource Centres.

Today, 29 Weavers’ Service Centres provide end to end support through training, upskilling, design development, raw material assistance and market linkages, while the 11 Indian Institutes of Handloom Technology are being strengthened to expand advanced training and develop niche, high-value handloom products. The forthcoming National Handloom and Handicraft Programme will accelerate this transformation by strengthening 1,800 clusters across more than 500 districts, benefiting 65 lakh weavers and artisans and establishing Handmade in India as a globally recognised brand.

Innovation has always been part of India’s handloom journey. Mahatma Gandhi’s Ambar Charkha made spinning easier, faster and more efficient, advancing the vision of self-reliance.

More recently, Assam’s Maina Loom and the Chitrnanjan Handloom developed in Sivasagar have shown how better loom design can make weaving easier and more productive. The Centre of Excellence for Handloom Technology, established with the Indian Institutes of Technology, is developing lighter, stronger and easier to use looms that reduce physical effort

As the war dragged on, Iran stepped out of the shadows of asymmetric warfare and increasingly shaped both the course and the pace of the conflict. When U.S. bombing resumed in July following the collapse of the MoU, Washington’s primary objective shifted to reopening the Strait of Hormuz, which had remained open until February 27. Four months into the war, Iran had forced the U.S. to set aside its original objectives – from regime change to the destruction of Iran’s nuclear programme – and instead contend with a new strategic problem created by Tehran itself. In July, while responding to U.S. strikes, Iran widened the conflict by intensifying attacks on Jordan and targeting Iraqi Kurdistan, Syria, and the Persian Gulf monarchies. Yemen’s Ansar Allah (the Houthis) struck Saudi oil facilities and imposed a naval blockade on the kingdom’s Red Sea ports. The conflict thus expanded horizontally in July, something which Mr. Trump was unprepared.

### Trapped in escalation

Consider America’s major military campaigns in the 21st century. In Afghanistan, U.S. forces achieved an initial swift victory by toppling the Taliban and establishing a new political order. They began losing the war only after the Taliban began regrouping and started a sustained insurgency. In Iraq and Libya, Washington succeeded in bringing down the regimes, even though the interventions destroyed those states and societies. In each of those theatres, the U.S. at least achieved its immediate military objectives, before failing to manage the post-war order.

But in Iran, the U.S. lost the war in the first phase itself. The U.S. now faces a diminished presence in West Asia, while Iran, with Hormuz under its control, is reasserting itself as a Persian Gulf regional power. Mr. Trump is no longer talking about Iran’s missile programme, its foreign policy or the character of the Iranian state. Forget regime change; today, he is asking the Islamic Republic, the same regime he sought to topple, to make a deal with Washington.

Trapped in this Persian labyrinth, Mr. Trump has few good options. He can acknowledge defeat and exercise diplomatic patience to reach a deal with Tehran and extricate the U.S. from the conflict. For Washington, which has been the dominant power in the Persian Gulf at least since the 1956 Suez War, this would come at a significant strategic cost. Alternatively, Mr. Trump could turn his failed air campaign into a full-scale invasion, with more devastating strikes and the potential deployment of ground troops. But there is no guarantee that escalation would help him win the war. On the contrary, it could draw the U.S. deeper into the sands of Iran, where a military of roughly 6,00,000 soldiers would be waiting.

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## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### End the deadlock

Thanks to the relentless disruptions by the Opposition, Parliament has been unable to conduct any meaningful business since the start of the monsoon session (Front page, August 6). Parliament is the sanctum sanctorum in a democracy and should be a

forum for debate, not disruption. Nothing is lost if the government considers the Opposition’s two key demands. If doing so can help break the impasse, this must be pursued. The government must note that relying solely on its numerical strength will only deepen the stalemate. The

sooner this stand-off ends, the better it will be for parliamentary democracy. **V. Johan Dhanakumar**, Chennai

### First Budget

The maiden Budget of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam government in Tamil Nadu deserves appreciation for

placing youth and women at the centre of its welfare agenda. Several of its initiatives will provide families with a modest financial cushion at milestones. The only jarring aspect is the naming of some of the schemes, which inadvertently reinforces

patriarchal notions that sit uneasily with the ideals of gender equality and women’s empowerment. The government’s decision to prioritise welfare despite fiscal constraints, banking on governance reforms to create additional fiscal space is significant. While the Budget’s intent is

laudable, the true test will be whether the government can sustain these generous welfare commitments without undermining fiscal discipline.

**M. Jeyaram**, Sholavandan, Tamil Nadu

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The views expressed are personal



# Should the Commonwealth Games be scrapped?



Anju Bobby George

is a distinguished sportsperson who is a recipient of the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna Award and is now the senior vice president of the Athletics Federation of India



Heena Sidhu

is a multiple-time champion at the CWG, winning a gold and a silver medal each at the 2010 and 2018 editions. In 2014, she became the first ever Indian pistol shooter to become world number one

## PARLEY

The recently concluded Commonwealth Games (CWG) were unlike the usual multidisciplinary sporting extravaganzas that we are used to seeing. A late replacement to Victoria as host, the Glasgow Games were more akin to an abridged version with fewer events and fewer participants. India finished fourth on the medal table, a commendable performance given that most of the sports that have formed the bulk of our medal haul had been removed. But questions of uncertainty have been whirling around the Games for a long time. Should the Commonwealth Games be scrapped? Anju Bobby George and Dr. Heena Sidhu discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Uthra Ganesan**. Edited excerpts:

### What is the importance of the CWG for sports in general and for India particularly?

**Anju Bobby George:** From an athlete's or athletics point of view, it is one of the biggest competitions after the Olympics and World Championships, coming before the Asian Games. Winning a medal in the Commonwealth Games is precious, and athletes take it very seriously. Initially, in 2002, we got only two medals; but in the recent CWG, our athletes bagged 10 medals.

When looking at the scale of the competition, in the World Championships and the Olympics, we compete with more than 210 countries. In the CWG, there are about 80 countries, and in the Asian Games, more than 40. As the number of countries goes up, the competition will also go up. So for us in athletics, the CWG comes in third place. Most of the elite, top-level, world-ranking athletes compete, making it very tough. Also, it is a preparation for the Olympics and World Championships.

**Heena Sidhu:** For shooting, World Championships are the toughest, followed by the Olympic Games, the Asian Games and then the CWG. The Asian Games is far tougher for shooters than the CWG, where competition is not even as tough as our National Championships. I would rank the CWG around a 4 out of 10 in difficulty, whereas World Championships are a 10 out of 10.

However, the games hold immense personal value and play a crucial role in preparation. Competing under pressure, living in the village, handling media, and representing India prepares you. Because the Asian Games is so tough, you cannot experiment there. The CWG is a place where shooters could experiment, understand their process, and take that



President of the Indian Olympic Association P.T. Usha hands the flag to Neeraj Chopra during the closing ceremony of CWG in Glasgow on August 2. REUTERS

momentum to the Asian Games and World Championships.

### With shooting absent from recent editions, how does that impact the sport?

**HS:** It is a bittersweet feeling. Shooting will appear in the CWG after 12 years in 2030, with the last edition being 2018 where I won two medals. The CWG has always been very special to me because I have four medals and I know how important it was for me to go to these Games. Some of the defining moments of my career have come from there. The CWG removing shooting hurts because any broadcasting or media interest helps our sport, which is not often shown on television.

Shooting is being cut out from many events, including the Asian Games, as squad limits force federations to select athletes playing two or more events rather than bringing top rankers from every discipline. Additionally, issues such as European restrictions on lead pellets, and negative perceptions tied to mass shootings create hurdles. Shooting is considered spectator-unfriendly, as stands are empty in places such as Glasgow. However, Indian spectators want to see it. If we want to save the sport, countries with fan demand must host it.

### How do you view challenges around hosting multi-sport events and squad restrictions?

**ABG:** Countries do not want to host multi-event sports due to costs, and they are reducing athlete numbers. This time, there was a restriction allowing only 32 athletes (16 men and 16 women) in athletics. Federations face a difficult situation because even qualified athletes cannot all be sent; we have to carefully select so that no medal winner is left behind. It is sad for athletes who qualify without knowing if they will



Modern multi-sport events such as the Olympics, the Asian Games and the CWG struggle because hosting at this scale is extremely expensive. Research shows that hosting the Olympics often leaves countries in severe debt and economic downfall, as seen in Greece and Brazil

HEENA SIDHU

go. But these are hurdles we have to tackle.

**HS:** Modern multi-sport events such as the Olympics, the Asian Games and the CWG struggle because hosting at this scale is extremely expensive. Research shows that hosting the Olympics often leaves countries in severe debt and economic downfall, as seen in Greece and Brazil, with China being an exception. I also know that the CWG as an institution is at a crossroads, and not everybody wants to host it. The traditional ways of hosting games are no longer valid in modern times. We definitely need to do something about it.

### What can be the options that make sure that multi-disciplinary events like the Commonwealth Games actually survive?

**ABG:** Actually, that is what countries are doing now – like the FIFA World Cup, it was held in three different countries. On a smaller scale, we do it for the National Games, where we conduct different sports in different cities or districts. But personally for me, you miss the beauty of the Games that way. Those who are coming to watch the events will have to fly all over. When it's together, they can just watch shooting one day, go and watch athletics the next day, day after that go for wrestling and so on. That won't happen with multiple venues.

**HS:** It is obvious that it's very difficult to host events at this scale. Traditional hosting is no longer valid: countries and sports bodies need to collaborate, sit down and find a solution. If a host cannot accommodate certain sports, other countries could host specific events – such as India hosting shooting, badminton, or wrestling – rather than kicking those sports out entirely. This is something that the big sports bodies, including the International Olympic Committee, need to think about.

But I agree on the social aspect. If you go to the Olympics for one month, it's like a 'mini world', mingling with athletes from across the world and across sports. That is an experience that will definitely be missed.

### What role does India play in the future of the CWG and hosting big events?

**ABG:** India is evolving and is ready to host big events. Financially, money is not an issue for us. Hosting the 2030 CWG is very important as a stepping stone towards our 2036 Olympic bid. By 2030, we can complete our infrastructure, so that by 2036 we would need only upgrades. Our athletes can train in those venues, and organisers can gain experience handling the pressures of big events. The entire sporting ecosystem will grow significantly, and if managed well, hosting will not backfire on India.

**HS:** India can definitely look at these Games as something that they can host regularly because once you make the infrastructure, you really don't have to invest much. And honestly, given the lack of a regular National Games programme in India – when was the last time we knew with surety that the National Games were going to happen – we need some kind of ecosystem where these kind of multidisciplinary games can happen. While initial investments in infrastructure, marketing, and fan engagement are high, getting it right can turbocharge our sporting business. Major global bodies like Wimbledon and FIFA are courting Indian fans because of the country's huge potential.

### What are your final expectations for the 2030 Commonwealth Games and beyond?

**ABG:** For me, the 2030 CWG is a stepping stone towards the bigger dream of the 2036 Olympics. We must build momentum starting now, identifying 12 to 14-year-old talents in schools today and nurturing them for the Olympics in 10 years. India is currently in 4th place in the CWG medal tally; my dream is to see India finish in 1st place in 2030, and reach the top five at the Olympics in 2036.

**HS:** I am looking forward to 2030 because shooting returns after 12 years. India should use this opportunity to make shooting accessible and engaging for fans. If you think about the last CWG we hosted in 2010, it was a defining moment for Indian sports because after that, we had really good infrastructure that helped us launch our athletes for the 2012 and 2016 Olympics. By taking sports seriously and building proper engagement, India can build a strong sporting ecosystem for the future.



To listen to the full interview  
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## NOTEBOOK

# The language of obscenity in Tamil Nadu politics

The arrest of the LoP for his allegedly crude remarks has rekindled memories of a time when leaders would scathingly attack their rivals

B. Kolappan

The arrest of the Leader of the Opposition in Tamil Nadu Udhayanidhi Stalin in connection with his allegedly obscene remarks during a demonstration on the Cauvery water dispute in Thanjavur has rekindled memories of an era when political leaders launched no-holds-barred attacks on their rivals.

In those days, political parties in Tamil Nadu had an unwritten division of labour. While senior leaders articulated the party's ideology and policies, fiery oratory speeches – often punctuated with personal attacks and, at times, obscene remarks – was largely left to second- and third-rung leaders of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), and, to a much lesser extent, the Congress.

These speakers had a devoted following. Their speeches were not merely exercises in invective; they forcefully explained the political issues of the day and defended their party's positions. Yet, every now and then, they would veer into caustic attacks on rival leaders, employing language that, despite its crudeness, was relished by sections of the audience.

I vividly remember a speech delivered by Theepori Arumugam, one of the DMK's most colourful platform speakers, in the aftermath of the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi. Renowned for his fiery style, he rarely exercised restraint and routinely launched obscene and deeply personal attacks on political rivals. On that occasion, he spared no one, even weaving in references about his own family life into his speech to entertain the crowd.

His inflammatory rhetoric also had consequences. On one occasion, angry members of a rival political party assaulted him, injuring the tip of his tongue. Ironically, after recovering from the injury, his speeches became even more scathing. Theepori Arumugam eventually joined the AIADMK – the very party he had spent years attacking with his acid tongue!

Party leaders generally turned a deaf

ear to such rhetoric. They intervened only when there was public backlash, suspending the speakers for a brief period. More often than not, the suspension proved temporary, and the speakers returned to the political stage with renewed vigour.

Though Mr. Udhayanidhi has courted controversy over his choice of words in the past, his remarks in Thanjavur appeared to have been made in response to repeated prodding from sections of the crowd. However, he went on to reiterate the expression. He subsequently denied that he had used words with a double entendre, insisting that his words had been misconstrued.

Women – both politicians and those associated with political leaders – have often been at the receiving end of public political invective in Tamil Nadu. Personal attacks directed at women have long formed an unfortunate strand of platform rhetoric, reflecting the deeply gendered nature of political discourse.

Though former Chief Minister J. Jayalithaa herself was often the target of deeply personal attacks, it did not prevent her from making personal remarks against her opponents. During one election campaign, she targeted DMK Parliamentary Party leader Kanimozhi, and on more than one occasion had ridiculed senior DMK leaders, including M. K. Stalin. In a sense, Jayalithaa also brought some of the combative style of platform politics into the Tamil Nadu Assembly. She displayed extraordinary aggression on the floor of the House, using forceful body language and a high-pitched, confrontational tone to take on her political adversaries. Her exchanges with the founder of the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), Vijayakanth, remain among the most dramatic confrontations in the Assembly's history.

That style of politics appears to have found echoes in the present Assembly. Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's aggressive delivery during his exchanges with the DMK leadership have reminded many of Jayalithaa's combative presence.

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## PICTURE OF THE WEEK

### At a steady pace



**Miles to go:** A Rabari shepherd from Rajasthan leads his herd of cattle in the Bhiwani district in Haryana on August 5. Rabaris are a nomadic and predominantly pastoralist group who travel across Gujarat and Rajasthan in search of green pastures. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

## FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 7, 1976

### Second satellite model to be ready by next year

Bangalore, August 6: The engineering model of India's second satellite is now fast nearing completion at Peenya, a city suburb. A team of about 400 space scientists, engineers and others is busy keeping up the model schedule displaying a unique team spirit.

The space engineers at the Indian Scientific Satellite Project (ISSP) are in the age group of 25 to 32 and they appear to be as much excited

## The Hindu

and interested in the design, fabrication and testing of the second satellite as they were about the first satellite "Aryabhata".

Dr. U.R. Rao, Director of the ISSP, told a Samachar correspondent who visited the project to-day that he found among his staff the same enthusiasm and team spirit that enabled the successful fabrication and testing of the "Aryabhata" for making the second satellite now. The second satellite, called the Satellite for Earth Observation (SEO), will conduct experimental studies in the earth observation with special application in areas of meteorology, oceanography and forestry. It is expected to be launched from a USSR cosmodrome in 1977-78.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 7, 1926

### British industrial mission to America

Rugby, August 6: It is understood that a Commission which with the approval of British Government will proceed to the United States to enquire into industrial conditions there will consist of five members. Two will be representative of the Trade Union movement, two will represent the employers and the Commission will be headed by Sir William Mackenzie, who has served on many important industrial enquiries.

An official of the Ministry of Labour will accompany the Commission.



# Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

**Cabinet-approved cost of Guwahati-Tezpur NH-15 corridor**

**8,970** in ₹ crore. The Union Cabinet on Thursday approved the development of 135.871 km, 4-lane access-controlled Guwahati-Tezpur Corridor of NH-15 in Assam for ₹8,970.20 crore. The project will be developed on a build-operate-transfer (BOT) toll mode. PTI

**Number of saplings to be monitored by digital system**

**23** in lakh. The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has launched a first-of-its-kind digital monitoring system to track its ongoing plantation drive in real time, with geo-tagged data, photographs and a public dashboard aimed at ensuring the survival of saplings, officials said on Thursday. PTI

**Cabinet approved cost for GOBARdhan scheme**

**23,731** in ₹ crore. The Cabinet on Thursday approved a unified circular bioenergy scheme with an outlay of ₹23,731 crore to boost biogas production in the country. The GOBARdhan scheme will be implemented from 2026-27 to 2035-36. PTI

**India's non-fossil fuel electricity generation capacity**

**300** in GW. India's non-fossil fuel electricity generation capacity has crossed 300 GW and the country is on track to achieve its target of 500 GW of renewable energy capacity by 2030, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi said on Thursday. PTI

**Iron ore resources in Gadadharpur block won by Coal India**

**258** in million tonnes. Coal India has won the Gadadharpur iron ore block in Odisha through a competitive auction, according to the State's director of mines and geology. The block contains 258 million tonnes of iron ore resources. REUTERS  
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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## The Beijing model of innovation

Beijing's innovation model brings together universities, start-ups, industry and the state to turn research into commercially viable technologies by bridging the 'valley of death'; the ecosystem is driving China's push in AI and humanoid robotics through state-backed funding, talent and industrial clusters

WORLD INSIGHT

Ananth Krishnan

If the conventional wisdom about innovation is that it is best left to individuals and private enterprise – and the best thing a government can do is get out of the way – that is certainly not the thinking in Beijing.

How innovation happens in Beijing offers a snapshot into China's model in which research universities, start-ups, the market and the state all have a role to play.

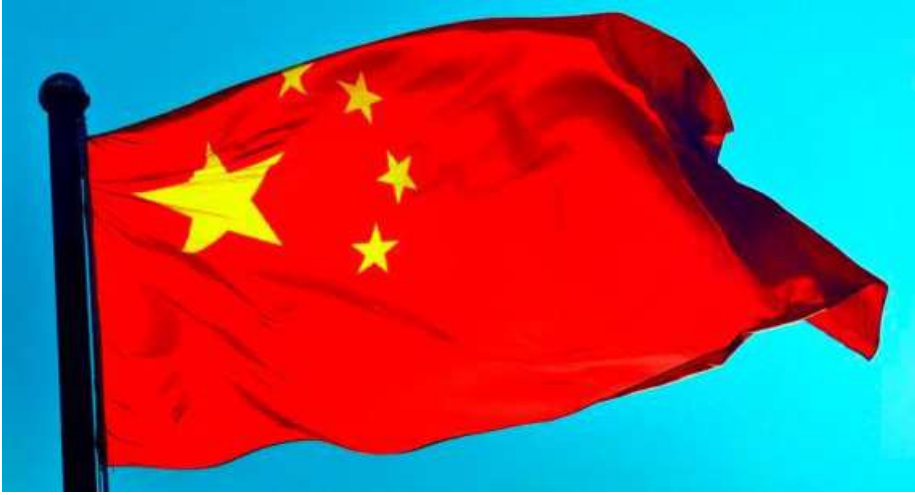
The Chinese capital has always had the country's most important cluster of research universities, with Peking University and Tsinghua leading the list. It is also home to several cutting-edge robotics and AI companies, including Moonshot, which was started by graduates of Tsinghua and made waves over its latest Kimi K3 open-source model.

"A closed loop from project discovery to incubation" is how Yang Xiuling, who as the Director General of the Beijing Municipal Commission of Development and Reform leads the city's top economic planning body, describes the ecosystem. "Our greatest strength," she says, "is talent and the concentration of top research universities."

The challenge that then follows is how to leverage that talent, or, as she puts it, "how to move results out of the lab". The gap between translating early research into commercially sustainable ventures is known as the "valley of death" for innovation. To cross that valley in Beijing, the state steps in.

Beijing's Zhongguancun research cluster is at the forefront of tech innovation in China, along with clusters in Shenzhen, Shanghai and Hangzhou. A strong undercurrent of competition underpins the national innovation ecosystem, especially when it comes to attracting and keeping talent.

To deal with the "valley of death", Beijing set up what it calls "an intelligent



GETTY IMAGES

platform for results commercialisation" led by a group of tech managers, who, Ms. Yang says, "are a bridge because they understand both the tech and the market". In 2025, the city's platform executed 1.04 lakh tech contracts.

"Markets and companies are still at the centre," Ms. Yang says. "But the way we look at it is that the companies pose questions, and the universities can provide answers. The companies still play a key role in R&D and in taking the lead in collaborative research with institutions".

The universities provide the foundation from which the rest follows, says Zhang Jihong, who is a Director at the state-run Zhongguancun Science Park. "It's the universities that have helped incubate a number of high-tech enterprises," he says. "We have formed a virtuous cycle where the universities produce talent, the talent provides intellectual support for innovation, and innovation again reinforces the growth of universities."

The state as investor

The state's role here is twofold. It provides the hard infrastructure, as seen in the science park and a number of incubators littered around Zhongguancun.

More importantly, it also provides

capital, not only linking start-ups to private venture capital (VC) but also stepping in with state-backed capital to help bear some of the risk.

The state taking a direct stake in companies is a unique feature of this ecosystem. The upside is it helps bear losses and allows for the longer-term, patient kind of support that VC might not afford. This has played a key role in enabling the speed and scale of innovation in China.

The downside is wasteful spending, if state funds do not do their due diligence, which is often the case. So much so that this has emerged as a growing concern for Chinese regulators, who in June issued new rules to tighten how local governments spend these funds.

The intense competition among different clusters, coupled with the collapse in land sales as a source of revenue for local governments, has led to a splurge in spending at the local level, with each province putting in funds with the hope of finding its national champions, even if they lack the capacity to do the needed due diligence. The new rules have now called for stricter control over how these funds are spent and for more approvals from the Central government.

Humanoids on the factory floor

AI and robotics are the twin peaks of Beijing's current innovation drive. If Zhongguancun in the north is the home of tech talent, the Yizhuang industrial cluster in the city's southern suburbs offers a snapshot of how innovation is playing out on the factory floor. Here, a hub-and-spokes model has the state's Humanoid Robot Innovation Centre at its centre, which funnels talent to a number of robotics companies around its periphery. "The idea," explains Che Zhengping, who is Head of Embodied AI at the Beijing Humanoid Robot Innovation Centre, "is to build a full supply chain that is ready for mass production". The current focus in humanoids is to "shift from industrial use scenarios to daily use scenarios", including healthcare, which is expected to be a major source of demand in an ageing society.

Among the companies in Yizhuang is Lingyi iTech, which in April started production on humanoid robots and is already planning to scale up. "Advancements in technology are making it more affordable" to scale, says Vice President Philip Yang. "As we move from semi automation to full automation," he estimates, "costs in 2030 will be half of what they are today."

Lingyi already has production capacity "for the next 5 to 6 years". By the end of 2027, it will be making 20,000 robots annually. The plan is to scale up to 1 lakh units by 2028 and 5 lakh by 2030 from this Yizhuang facility (the company has four others), by when it hopes to be "one of the world's top three".

At the state-run innovation centre next door, researchers pore over unfinished humanoid robots, getting them to perfect a range of delicate movements before the latest model is given the green light.

State subsidies of land, policy and tax support are among the more well-known elements of China's industrial policy. The state's enabling of talent and intellectual support are perhaps less well-known, but arguably just as important when it comes to getting innovation right.

THE GIST

Beijing's Zhongguancun and other innovation clusters are using research universities, technology managers and incubators to help move scientific results from laboratories into the market.

The city's push for AI and humanoid robots is being supported by industrial hubs, state-backed capital and policies aimed at building a full supply chain for mass production.

## Why are households pledging gold instead of selling it?

How are rising prices reshaping India's traditional appetite for gold jewellery?

Santosh V. Perumal

The story so far:

For centuries, gold has had a prime position in India's economic and social landscape. Gold has proved its timeless appeal, but global uncertainties and their disruptions have led to a structural change in its holding pattern in India, exhibiting a dual-track economy, one steeped in tradition (as wedding and festival buying to provide seasonal support) and another shaped by modern portfolio management.

How is the demand pattern for gold changing?

India's overall gold demand was up 2% year-on-year (YoY) to 282 tonnes in the first half (H1) of this year, driven by investment demand as ETFs hit a record high; while jewellery demand declined 17.1% to 141.2 tonnes (also the second-lowest first quarter or Q1 on record since 2000), according to the

World Gold Council (WGC) data.

In the second quarter (Q2) alone, India's overall gold demand was down 6% YoY to 131.4 tonnes, with jewellery demand (30% of overall gold demand, the lowest since the WGC began tracking the data in 2000) falling faster at 15% to 75.1 tonnes, the second-lowest in Q2 since 2000. India was the world's largest gold jewellery market in the quarter, accounting for 27% of global demand, WGC data suggest.

Investment demand was seen softening in Q2 to 54 tonnes but was higher than the long-term quarterly average of 49 tonnes, hinting at above-average demand and pointing towards sustained investment interest.

Q1 was a record for Indian gold ETFs, with net demand of 20 tonnes, driven by strong investor participation amid elevated gold prices and subdued domestic financial markets. Similarly, bars and coins saw a 21.3% and 105.5% surge in volume and value, respectively, in H1FY27.

Is investment gold overtaking jewellery?

The shift in allegiance to investment instruments such as ETFs, gold bars, and coins is palpable as the price of the yellow metal increased more than fivefold in the last 10 years, against India's national average (economic growth), and is seen favourably from a current account perspective.

According to IIFL's Capital Outlook 2026, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), in 2025, stepped up gold purchases just as global gold prices rallied sharply.

The combination (household gold and the RBI purchases) helped cushion the impact of rupee depreciation and strengthened India's external balance at a time when foreign portfolio flows were under pressure, it said.

Affordability pressures pushed jewellery demand down. Yet, consumers' gold purchases hit a record ₹1.98 lakh crore, reflecting the extraordinary jump in prices.

The domestic MCX spot gold price was

broadly flat in Q2FY27, supported by the import duty hike and the rupee depreciation (down by 4% QoQ). Even with this quarterly moderation, the domestic prices remained substantially higher than a year earlier. To put it in perspective, 10 grams of gold jewellery bought in 2016 for about ₹28,000 and more than ₹89,000 in H1 last year would cost ₹1.5 lakh or more in 2026.

Given the scenario, jewellery's monopoly as the preferred form of ownership started slowly fading, while financial gold made inroads and gained legitimacy among urban and younger investors, who preferred gold bars, coins and ETFs, which are seen as better investment vehicles.

The rising popularity of investment gold comes amid a previous unsuccessful attempt by the government to encash it, although India has one of the world's largest private gold stocks.

The Gold Monetisation Scheme, introduced in 2015, was designed to mobilise idle household gold by allowing individuals and institutions to deposit gold with banks and earn interest. But was met with lacklustre performance due to taxation concerns and procedural complexities.

Why are households pledging gold instead of selling it?

The apparent contradiction in India's gold market – falling jewellery demand but rising investment appetite – is now accompanied by a third trend as

households increasingly use the existing gold holdings as collateral.

According to the WGC, outstanding retail bank loans backed by pledged gold jewellery reached around ₹4.3 lakh crore by February 2026, rising 124% YoY.

The broader banking system has also seen an extraordinary acceleration in gold-backed lending, with gold loan portfolios reaching about ₹5.4 lakh crore by June 2026, registering close to 94% YoY growth. Despite domestic gold prices being around 60% higher YoY, holders showed limited appetite to sell, preferring to monetise their gold holdings rather than liquidate them, keeping recycled supply "muted", according to WGC.

The rapid expansion of gold loans needs careful monitoring in view of financial vulnerabilities it can create.

The RBI strengthened its regulation to promote responsible lending, as it mandated borrowers to make full repayment of the principal and interest before repurchasing the asset.

What is next?

India's huge household gold stock can evolve from a passive store of wealth into an active financial asset, which could ease some of the traditional pressure that gold imports place on the current account.

Time is not too far for India's financial markets to see a better combination of monetisation schemes, financial innovation, recycling, market reforms and digital transparency for unlocking the huge pile of privately held gold.



EXPLAINER



The Asan Wetland Conservation Reserve lies at the confluence of the Asan and Yamuna rivers in Uttarakhand and was designated a Ramsar site in 2020. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

# How will the Supreme Court order impact mining around Ramsar wetland sites?

What did the Supreme Court clarify on mining near wetlands? What is the significance of the Asan Wetland Conservation Reserve? Do Ramsar sites have a statutory buffer zone for mining? How do mining restrictions near protected areas differ?

Jacob P Koshy

**The story so far:** The Supreme Court has clarified that its February 2024 direction, requiring prior approval before mining can take place within a 10-km radius of the Asan Wetland Conservation Reserve, would, for the sake of parity, apply to wetland conservation reserves across the country. The clarification potentially extends a judicial safeguard that was earlier confined to the Asan Ramsar site in Uttarakhand to similarly notified wetland conservation reserves elsewhere.

**What prompted the Supreme Court to dwell on this question?** The clarification arose while the Supreme Court was hearing an application from the Himachal Pradesh government. The State argued that the February 14, 2024 interim order concerning the Asan Wetland Conservation Reserve in Uttarakhand should not automatically apply to it because the Asan reserve was not located within Himachal Pradesh and, unlike national parks and wildlife sanctuaries, wetland conservation reserves do not have a statutory buffer zone.

The Bench, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, orally clarified that the principle laid down in the Asan case was not confined to Uttarakhand. Justice Joymalya Bagchi observed that wherever there is a community reserve or wetland conservation reserve, the directions issued in the Asan case would apply for the sake of parity. At the same time, the court directed the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (NBWL) or the Ministry of Environment, Forest and

Climate Change (MoEFCC) to determine whether the Asan wetland extends into Himachal Pradesh. If it does, the 2024 directions would apply there as well. If not, mining proposals would be governed by the applicable statutory framework.

**What is the background to the Asan wetland case?** The Asan Wetland Conservation Reserve lies at the confluence of the Asan and Yamuna rivers in Uttarakhand and was designated a Ramsar site in 2020. It is an important habitat for migratory waterbirds and supports rich aquatic biodiversity. In an interim order dated February 14, 2024, the Supreme Court directed that no mining activity should be carried out within a 10-km radius of the reserve unless the project proponent first obtained permission from the Standing Committee of the NBWL and/or the MoEFCC. The Bench said the wetland's designation as a Ramsar site warranted heightened scrutiny of activities that could affect its ecological character. The latest clarification indicates that the same principle would apply to other wetland conservation reserves across India.

**What are Ramsar sites?** Ramsar sites are wetlands designated under the Ramsar Convention on Wetlands, an international treaty adopted in Ramsar, Iran, in 1971 to promote the conservation and wise use of wetlands of international importance. India became a Contracting Party to the Convention in 1982. India currently has 101 Ramsar sites, the maximum among Asian countries. On August 3, 2026, Glaw Lake in Arunachal Pradesh became the country's 101st Ramsar site and the State's first, taking

India's tally from 98 earlier this year to 101. A Ramsar designation does not itself create a separate statutory protection regime under Indian law. Rather, it recognises the international ecological importance of a wetland and commits India to maintaining its ecological character through domestic environmental laws.

**What does the law say about mining in Ramsar wetlands?** Neither the Ramsar Convention nor the Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2017 prescribe a statutory buffer around Ramsar sites or expressly prohibit mining within a specified distance of them. The earlier Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2010 contained a detailed list of prohibited activities within wetlands, including reclamation, establishment of new industries, dumping of solid waste and any activity likely to adversely affect the wetland ecosystem. They also required prior approval for activities within a wetland's zone of influence and mandated environmental impact assessments for specified projects. The 2017 Rules replaced this framework with a decentralised system under State Wetland Authorities. They removed the explicit list of prohibited activities contained in the 2010 Rules and shifted responsibility for identifying and regulating wetlands largely to the States. The constitutional validity of these rules is currently under challenge before the Supreme Court. Petitioners argue that the framework excludes many artificial wetlands recognised under the Ramsar Convention

and weakens protections that existed under the 2010 Rules. Against this backdrop, the Supreme Court's Asan directions assume significance because they create an additional judicial safeguard by requiring wildlife clearances before mining can proceed within 10 km of wetland conservation reserves.

**How does this compare with mining around national parks, wildlife sanctuaries and forests?** Mining around protected forests and wildlife habitats is governed by a combination of statutes and Supreme Court directions. Within national parks and wildlife sanctuaries, mining is prohibited under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972. In addition, the Supreme Court has held that mining is impermissible within one kilometre of the boundary of every national park and wildlife sanctuary across India, unless a larger Eco-Sensitive Zone (ESZ) has already been notified, in which case the larger notified buffer prevails. The court extended this prohibition nationwide after observing that mining within one kilometre of protected areas is hazardous for wildlife. Projects located within protected areas or likely to affect wildlife habitats also require scrutiny by the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife. In forest areas, diversion of forest land for mining requires prior approval of the Union government under the Van (Sanrakshan Evam Samvardhan) Adhiniyam, 1980. Mining projects are also generally subject to environmental clearance under the Environment Impact Assessment Notification, 2006.

## THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz on the occasion of National Handloom Day celebrated today

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1**  
Why was August 7 chosen as the National Handloom Day?
- QUESTION 2**  
After whom is the country's highest recognition for handloom weavers who have demonstrated extraordinary craftsmanship and dedication to the preservation and promotion of India's weaving traditions named?
- QUESTION 3**  
Which State is synonymous with the Wangkhei Phee and Shapee Lanphee

- weaves?
- QUESTION 4**  
Name the master weaver of the Gods in Hindu mythology from whom the silk weavers of Kanchipuram consider their descent.
- QUESTION 5**  
What is special about Eri silk, locally called Ryndia, from Meghalaya?
- QUESTION 6**  
Which popular weave from Central India was patronised by Queen Ahilyabai Holkar?
- QUESTION 7**  
Where is the Calico Museum of Textiles located?



**Visual Question:** Name this social reformer affectionately called 'Hatkargha Maa' (Handloom Mother) for her monumental role in reviving and promoting handlooms.

**Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:** 1. What were the nicknames of the bombs dropped on the two Japanese cities? **Ans: 'Little Boy' and 'Fat Man'. The codenames were chosen by their creator, Robert Serber** 2. What were the core nuclear materials used in the two bombs? **Ans: Little Boy used uranium-235, whereas Fat Man used plutonium-239** 3. Apart from the two unfortunate cities that bore the brunt of the dastardly attack, which other three cities were in the initial list? **Ans: Kokura, Kyoto, and Niigata** 4. Name the two intended aimpoints in both the cities that were not hit because of weather conditions. **Ans: Aioli Bridge and a Mitsubishi arms plant** 5. Which flower became the official flower of Hiroshima because it was the first plant to bloom on the scorched earth? **Ans: Oleander** 6. Which legendary scientist remarked, "Had I known that the Germans would not succeed in developing an atomic bomb, I would have done nothing for the bomb"? **Ans: Albert Einstein, whose letter had ushered in the age of the atomic bomb** Visual: This is Tsutomu Yamaguchi, a 'hibakusha'. What is his unique claim to fame as regards the survivors? **Ans: The only person officially recognised as a survivor of both the bombings** **Early Birds:** Prem Nath Tiwari | Varghese Joseph | Deepak Jiloha | Suchit Narottam | Anoop G.



## FROM THE ARCHIVES

# Know your English

S. Upendran

**What is the origin of the expression "lion's share"? (V. H. Ninoy, Cochin)** This is an expression which owes its origin to a story from Aesop's Fairy Tales. In the story, a lion and three of his friends – a fox, an ass, and a wolf – go hunting. After they make a kill the lion says that he is going to keep three-fourths of the meat for himself. The reasons he provides for keeping the "lion's share" are the following: one fourth as his just share, one fourth for his lioness and cubs, and the other one fourth for his courage. The lion then goes on to inform his friends that he is prepared to part with the remaining one fourth provided one of them challenges him to a fight and defeats him. The three friends refuse to take him on and, as a result, leave the entire kill to the king of beasts. "Lion's share," as you can guess from the story, means the larger share of something.

**How is the word "dilettante" pronounced? (D. Devayani, Hyderabad)** The T in the first syllable and the final "e" are pronounced like the 'i' in 'pit', 'sit', and 'hit'. The vowel "e" in the second syllable is like the "a" in "china". Some people pronounce the "a" like the 'a' in 'act', 'pact', and 'hat'. Others pronounce it like the "a" in "bath" and "path" (British English). The main stress is on the third syllable. Any idea what the word means? Well, a 'dilettante' is someone who tries to cultivate an area of interest without really making the necessary commitment. The person may do a course in painting, for example, without taking the subject seriously. He merely dabbles in the subject. *I wouldn't take him too seriously. He is a musical dilettante.*

**What is the difference between "corrigenda" and "errata"? (Chhoto Gawai, Nagpur)** Both "corrigenda" and "errata" refer to the errors – usually in spelling – that occur in writing or printing. The words are mainly used to refer to the list of errors in a book along with their corrections. Of the two words "errata" is the more common. The errata or corrigenda are usually appended to the book – one usually finds this page at the back. The singular of 'corrigenda' is 'corrigendum'; while that of "errata" is "erratum". A note about the pronunciation of "corrigenda". The 'o' in the first syllable is like the 'o' in 'cot', 'pot', and 'hot', while the 'i' in the second is like the 'i' in 'pit', 'sit', and 'bit'. The 'gen' in the next syllable sounds like the 'gen' in 'gentle' and 'gentleman'. The 'a' in the final syllable is like the 'a' in 'china'. The main stress is on the third syllable. In the case of "errata", the first "a" is pronounced like the "a" in "cat", "bat", and "har", while the second sounds like the "a" in "china". The stress is on the second syllable.

**One of my teachers keeps telling us to "chill out". What exactly does he mean by that? (Vinta Manohar, Adoor)** If the teacher has to use the expression "chill out" very often in class, then chances are you are not allowing him to talk in class! The teacher is asking you to calm down, to relax – in other words, he is pleading with you to stop talking! The plight of most teachers these days! *Published in The Hindu on July 17, 2001*

## Word of the day

**Encomium:** a formal expression of praise

**Synonyms:** tribute, commendation, homage

**Usage:** *The teacher gave an encomium to the student for her hard work.*

**Pronunciation:** newsth.live/encomium

**International Phonetic Alphabet:** /ɪnˌkɒmiəm/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'



From Page One

DMK lays down terms to back delimitation Bill

Though the government doesn't have the two-thirds majority yet to push through a constitutional amendment, the political situation has changed since April 17, when the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill was defeated on the floor of the House. The numerical strength of the INDIA bloc has since vastly changed.

In the present 540-member Lok Sabha, the two-thirds majority mark is 360, and if 22 Lok Sabha members of the DMK vote for the Bill, the government's strength would go up to 346. While the government would still be short of 14 MPs, the threshold changes if there are abstentions during the proceedings. If the government brings the Bill to the Rajya Sabha, it will find it easier to reach the two-thirds majority mark. In the Rajya Sabha, if all 244 members are present for voting, the government will need 164 votes. The BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) currently has 158 MPs.

Home Minister Amit Shah had earlier said that once it is assured of the numbers, the government would once again bring the constitutional amendment Bill to increase the strength of the Lok Sabha to 850 seats in order to implement the 33% reservation for women after fresh delimitation.

Since April, the government has secured the support of 20 rebel Trinamool Congress MPs, who are now part of the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPD), and six Shiv Sena MPs who had switched sides from the Uddhav Thackeray faction to the Eknath Shinde-led faction.

HC convicts Tejpal in 2013 sexual assault case

According to the prosecution, Tejpal sexually assaulted a junior colleague inside a hotel elevator in 2013 during an event organised by the magazine in Goa. In its 81-page judgment, the court expressed disapproval about the way the defence highlighted the complainant's personal life, and noted that it found it surprising that the trial court "remained silent and allowed the defence to harass and humiliate her during the cross examination".

The court said that the prosecution had established its case "beyond every reasonable doubt" and the victim too had stood firm in her testimony. The trial court had proceeded with the notion that a sexual assault complainant must behave in a stereotypical manner, the court said.

"The 'perfect victim' concept, more formally known as an 'ideal victim', described an unspoken cultural archetype where a person is fully believed, sympathised with and granted legitimacy only if they exhibit absolute vulnerability, complete innocence and total passivity," the court said. When a victim does not fit the description, the trauma is devalued, it added.

While Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta requested the court to award the maximum sentence, senior advocate Abad Ponda, representing Tejpal, appealed for leniency, stating that this was Tejpal's first offence and he was 62 years old.

"Let me be given an opportunity to approach the Supreme Court," Mr. Ponda said on behalf of Tejpal. He assured the court that Tejpal was not going to flee from the law. Tejpal, with permission from the court, addressed the Bench. "For the last 13 years, we have been working to bring facts and truth to light. Obviously, that holds no significance today. I am a father to two daughters, and I have a family. All I want to say is that we now have the option to appeal in a higher court," he said.

The court convicted Tejpal under Sections 376 (2)(f), 376(2)(k), 354A, and 354B of the Indian Penal Code and also imposed a fine of ₹5 lakh under Section 376(2)(f).

(With inputs from PTI)

Jharkhand protesters form 11-member team to meet govt.

Students say the agitation will continue until the govt. takes a concrete decision on their demands; key demand is a CBI inquiry; Jharkhand CID has arrested 19 people in connection with the case

Amit Bhelari  
PATNA

Students protesting in Jharkhand on Thursday formed an 11-member delegation to hold talks with the Jharkhand government over their demands.

Hundreds of students gathered at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium in State capital Ranchi, demanding an inquiry by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) followed by action against those responsible for the alleged irregularities in competitive exams for government jobs in the State, including in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) Combined Civil Services Examination, and the Jharkhand General Graduate Level Combined Competitive Examination, which is also known as Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level (JSSC-CGL) exam.

The JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch was scheduled to hold talks with the four-member committee formed by the government on Thursday evening. However, till filing this report, no message had been sent to the Manch with regard to the timing and place of the talks. However, the Manch has sent the names of the 11 delegates who will be part of the talks.

**Demands to be tabled**

The delegation included eight students – Ravindra Paswan, Piyush Kumar Singh, Ravindra Kumar Ravi, Rajesh Prasad, Neetu Kujur, Kartik Soren, Sandeep Kumar and Shaalu Singh. Along with them, there will be one journalist representing the media, one person in the role of guardian and one legal expert.

The JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch has asserted that journalists and legal experts will be present in the capacity of mentors to the students, and have been instructed not to engage in any conversation and not to carry microphones, cameras or any recording devices to the meeting.

During the dialogue, all issues, facts, and demands will be presented to the government only by the student representatives in a peaceful and orderly manner. Student representative Ravindra Paswan said students were ready for talks with the government. "Our objective is to put the real demands of the students before the government. We hope that the government will listen to us seriously and take positive decisions in the interest of the students," he said.

**19 arrested so far**

Meanwhile, the peaceful protest entered its 13th day on Thursday. The students have asserted that their agitation would continue until the government takes a concrete decision on their demands.

The Jharkhand Crime Investigation Department (CID) is investigating the irregularities and has arrested 19 persons in the case.

The main demand of the protesting students is a CBI inquiry into the issue. The protesters have also called for the cancellation of the Preliminary Test of the 14th JPSC Civil Services Examination, and a review of exams conducted through agencies, including TSR Data Processing Private Limited.



Student leader Devendra Nath Mahto during a hunger strike as part of the protest against alleged irregularities in the JPSC exam, JSSC-CGL and other recruitment tests in Ranchi on Thursday. PTI

one person in the role of guardian and one legal expert.

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Gen Z's grievances must be addressed: RSS chief

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit  
MUMBAI

Gen Z's grievances are genuine and need to be addressed, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat said on Monday. Speaking days after the massive youth protest at Jantar Mantar, the RSS chief said that protest is a way of dialogue in a democracy, and that it should be used to evolve a consensus.

He was participating in an interview at an event organised by India's International Movement to Unite Nations, a youth-run non-profit, at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre.

Disagreeing with the tag of "anti-nationals" slapped on the young protesters by some people, Mr. Bhagwat said that Gen Z was in fact much more honest than his generation.



Mohan Bhagwat

"They are not anti-national. They are our own next generation. They have to be addressed with that relation. There has to be love," he said.

The event's organisers said that the questions Mr. Bhagwat was asked – on topics ranging from LGBTQI rights, women's empowerment, social media use, and educational reforms, to India's relations with Pakistan and China, reservation poli-

cies, climate change, and unemployment – were collected from members of Gen Z and Gen Alpha. The interview was moderated by IIMUN's Rishabh Shah, who was cheered by the crowd when he asked questions about youth being labelled as anti-national, empowerment of women within the RSS, and the Sangh's stance on same sex marriages.

**On same sex couples**

Mr. Bhagwat called for a law to allow same sex companions to stay together, though not in the form of a marriage. "LGBTQIs are a part of our community. But in our community, marriage is not a convenience created for two persons to stay together. It is an institution. Family is the unit of society where the next generation is trained by their relations," he said.

After Jantar Mantar, CJP eyes national footprint

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit  
MUMBAI

Less than two weeks after ending its successful agitation at Jantar Mantar, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) is ready to move to the next level. The group announced a nationwide membership drive, a public dialogue initiative, and an expansion plan, apart from naming its first national working committee. The announcements were made on Thursday, at the end of a two-day core committee meeting at Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar in Maharashtra.

Announcing the launch of its "Kya Bolti Public" initiative (which translates to "What do you say, public?"), the CJP said it was keen to listen to the voices of ordinary people from different parts of the country. It also plans to launch a



Abhijeet Dipke

crowd-funding initiative to support its expansion. It will continue to focus on education reforms, but will also highlight electoral and judicial reforms and seek to enforce institutional and media accountability.

Founder and national convener Abhijeet Dipke said that the group would go to the grassroots level and build a culture among the people of seeking accountability from political systems. "We want to

change the political discourse. Youth issues will have to be taken up, whoever fights the elections. We will not support or oppose a political party," he said.

He took a swipe at RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat over the timing of his interaction with members of Gen Z, arguing that it was the Jantar Mantar protest that had forced the RSS to stop dismissing the concerns of the youth. The CJP's first national working committee puts young millennials and older members of Gen Z at the helm of the organisation, with the leadership ranging in age from 25 years to 35 years. A zonal architecture is being put in place to create organisational structures across the country. The CJP's organisational structure is to be divided into five zones across the country.

SC stays arrest of Abhishek Banerjee's personal aide

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday stayed the arrest of Sumit Roy, personal assistant to Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee, in connection with the Salboni land-grabbing case.

The Bench however, directed him to cooperate fully with the ongoing investigation. On August 3, 2026 the Calcutta High Court rejected the anticipatory bail plea of Mr. Roy.

The case was registered under penal provisions relating to cheating, criminal breach of trust, use of forged documents, and criminal conspiracy.

"The petitioner shall remain available for investigation from 10:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. However, his arrest will remain stayed," the Bench ordered.

Cong. rebel leader Meena surrenders after bail cancellation

The Hindu Bureau  
JAIPUR

Congress rebel leader Nareish Meena, accused of slapping a Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM) during the Assembly by-election at Deoli-Uniara in November 2024, surrendered at Nagar Fort police station in Rajasthan's Tonk district on Thursday following the cancellation of his bail. His bail was cancelled last month on the ground of violation of conditions.

The police produced Mr. Meena, 45, in the court of the Special Judge (SC/ST Atrocities) in Tonk, which remanded him to judicial custody. A large number of Mr. Meena's supporters raised slogans outside the police station and the court, while the administration imposed prohibitory orders to prevent any untoward incident.

The Rajasthan High Court had granted conditional bail to Mr. Meena on July 11, 2025, after nearly nine months in jail. The Special SC/ST Court in Tonk cancelled the bail on July 13 this year, citing violation of conditions after his subsequent arrest during a protest in Jhalawar, and issued arrest warrants against him.

**‘Curbing popularity’**

As the court directed the police to arrest Mr. Meena and produce him by Thursday, he himself surrendered at the police station, travelling from Jaipur in a procession of his supporters. The rebel leader's supporters accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government of trying to curb his growing popularity by keeping him behind bars ahead of the Panchayati Raj elections.

Modi and Netanyahu discuss West Asia issues

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday received a telephone call from his Israeli counterpart Benjamin Netanyahu during which they exchanged views on the recent developments in West Asia.

The two leaders also reviewed sustained progress in the India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership and reaffirmed their commitment to further strengthening the bilateral cooperation across various sectors to benefit both countries, a statement issued by the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) said.

In a post on X, Mr. Modi said, "We reviewed progress on various aspects of the India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership which continues to grow from strength-to-strength."

Question paper leaks are more heinous than murder, says HC

Shubhomoy Sikdar  
RAIPUR

The Chhattisgarh High Court has observed that leaking question papers for competitive examinations and jeopardising the future of lakhs of students is an offence more heinous than murder. The remark came while dismissing the bail plea of Janak Kumar Dhruv, an accused in the alleged Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission (CGPSC) recruitment scam.

The case pertains to the alleged corruption, question-paper leak and manipulation of the CGPSC State Service Examinations conducted in the years 2021 and 2022.

"...A person who facilitates leakage of question papers for competitive examinations plays with the careers and futures of

lakhs of young aspirants... Such an act is more heinous than murder because, while the killing of a person affects one family, the destruction of the careers of lakhs of aspirants adversely impacts society as a whole," noted the judgment delivered by the single-judge Bench of Bibhu Datta Guru.

Mr. Dhruv, who served as the Secretary of the CGPSC during the relevant period, is accused of helping his son, Sumit Dhruv, secure selection as a Deputy Collector.

Counsel for the applicant, however, argued that Mr. Dhruv had been falsely implicated in the case.

The court rejected the bail application and said that the alleged charges levelled against the accused persons could by no stretch of imagination be termed ordinary.

Celebrate National Handloom Day: PM

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday urged Indians to mark National Handloom Day, which falls on Friday, by sharing videos of their favourite handloom products.

Posting on his Instagram account, Mr. Modi was seen handling various pieces of handloom material from different parts of the country. He recalled that the Swadeshi movement of

boycotting foreign goods in favour of Indian goods was launched on August 7, 1905.

He urged people to remember handloom workers and their contribution. "Let's make India's handloom diversity popular. Share your videos with your favourite handloom products, including GRWM videos. Don't forget to use #NationalHandloomDay," he said. GRWM (Get Ready With Me) is a popular Internet trend.



**Mr. Harsh Makhijani**, Christian Medical College Hospital No. AE07421, 18 years has been diagnosed to have Thalassemia major. This is a type of Blood Disorder which is life threatening. The treatment option for him would be to undergo Allogeneic stem cell Transplantation (PBSCT). The estimated cost of MUD transplant at our centre will come to Approximately Rs.55,00,000/-.

Please send donation however small by Cheque/D.D/M.O Fav. **Save Poor Lives** A/c Harsh Makhijani. **Our A/c Details:** S/B A/c No. 20000913487. S.B.I. R.A.Puram, IFSC CODE: SBIN001855. Please Donate by G-pay No.9884607377, UPI Id: savepoorlives@oksb. Donations are exempted under 80G of I.T.ACT.

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**APPEAL**





# FCRA Bill is ‘religion-neutral’, Shah assures Christian bodies

Bill likely to be taken up for discussion in Parliament on August 12; Home Minister tells Christian delegations that the govt. has ‘no intention to harass the Christian community’; forum requests Bill be referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee

Vijaita Singh  
NEW DELHI

Amid concerns raised by Christian bodies over the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 (FCRA), Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday met two delegations, including one representing all Christian denominations and communities, and assured them that the proposed legislation was “religion-neutral”.

A member of the delegation said Mr. Shah asserted that the “government has no intention to harass the Christian community, or any faith (or) community for that matter”.

The other delegation included Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma, who said that Mr. Shah had conveyed that the Bill was likely to be taken up for discussion in Parliament on August 12, a day before the Monsoon Session ends. “We were given an assurance that the provisions of the Bill will not be applied retrospectively,” he said.

Reverend Asir Ebenezer



Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma with Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi, in this file photo. ANI

er, general secretary of National Council of Churches in India, who met Mr. Shah, said the 18-member delegation of the Joint Action Forum on Minorities included representatives from all the three Christian traditions – Catholic, Protestant, and Orthodox.

“We had written to the Prime Minister to register our concerns against the FCRA Bill. The Home Minister gave us time and listened to us patiently for an hour. He said it is not against the Christian faith but against anyone who violates the law. We re-

quested him that a comprehensive review of the Act that was introduced in 2010 is required,” Mr. Ebenezer told *The Hindu*.

### Main concern

One of the key provisions in the FCRA Bill, 2026, is the appointment of a “designated authority” to take over, manage, or dispose of assets created from foreign funds when an NGO’s FCRA registration is suspended, cancelled, or not renewed. This authority will have the powers of a civil court and can order the transfer or sale of assets

owned by NGOs to either the government or any other body. The Bill was initially listed for passage in the ongoing Monsoon Session of the Parliament but did not figure in this week’s list of business.

Mr. Ebenezer said that the “deemed cessation” of assets in case the FCRA registration is not renewed or cancelled by the government in absence of a formal order was also flagged at the meeting.

“The Minister asked us for a list of cases where registrations of NGOs had been cancelled without any notice. We also sought clarity on the powers of the vesting authority to dispose the assets without a judicial oversight. How can a government authority just take over my property?” he asked.

The meeting is among a series of interactions that the Home Minister has held with the Christian community to assuage concerns over the Bill.

On July 10, Mr. Shah assured the Catholic Bishops Conference of India, the apex body of the Catholic church in India, that the

Bill was not against the Christian NGOs, which receive a little under 15% of the total foreign donations.

DMK MP P. Wilson, chairman of the Joint Forum, who led the delegation, said, “We clearly spelt out the illegalities in the Bill. Even if a registration is going to be cancelled, there was no necessity to take over the properties of these organisations... it was also explained to the Home Minister that these bodies have employed expert hands for running these organisations, institutions, hospitals, and by taking over it will clearly destroy them, including the hospitals...”

The delegation submitted a representation requesting the withdrawal of the Bill in its present form. It requested that the Bill be referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee for comprehensive stakeholder consultation.

Government sources ruled out further changes to the Bill adding that the specifics on taking over assets by designated authority will be clarified when the Rules are notified.

# RS Chairman tells Rijiju to ‘echo the sentiments’ of the Opposition to Shah

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

On the 14th day of the Monsoon Session, Rajya Sabha Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan on Thursday asked Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju to “echo the sentiments of the Opposition” to Home Minister Amit Shah. The session has been marked by disruptions, especially in the first half of the day.

The Rajya Sabha saw two adjournments in the morning session. Twenty minutes into the sitting, with Opposition sloganeering drowning out the Zero Hour speeches of members, Mr. Rijiju raised a point of order. Citing two rules that bar interruptions during speeches by members and allow the Chair to truncate speeches in cases where members are repeating their arguments, he said, “Mr. Kharge has been saying the same thing every day. There is a rule against repetition.”

He said the newly elected Congress MP Pawan Khara had not even delivered his maiden speech in the House but was sloganeering. The House was adjourned at 11.25 a.m.



Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan conducts the proceedings of the House during the Monsoon Session of Parliament on Thursday. ANI

When it reconvened at noon for Question Hour, the protests continued.

Heeding the Opposition’s request, Mr. Radhakrishnan asked the Leader of the Opposition, Mallikarjun Kharge, to speak. The Treasury Benches objected to this. Amid the noisy exchange, Mr. Kharge said, “If I don’t read the rules, if I don’t read my matter, should I read what you (Mr. Rijiju) give? It’s my right, what to speak, when to speak, how to speak.”

Mr. Kharge said the Opposition raised genuine questions concerning the country and its 140 crore people. “We are asking the Home Minister and the Prime Minister to come to the House. We request the

Chair to direct the Home Minister to come and give a statement. We are ready to discuss it,” he said.

Mr. Radhakrishnan said the Opposition had been asking the Home Minister to come to the House. “Now I request you to consider his (Kharge’s) request... As Parliamentary Affairs Minister, you can echo the sentiments of the Opposition to the HM,” Mr. Radhakrishnan said.

Addressing a press conference later, Mr. Kharge expressed satisfaction with the Chairman’s direction. He claimed that there could be only two reasons to explain the Home Minister’s absence. Either he believes that “Parliament does not matter” or he is “scared”, he said.

## Centre spent over ₹550 cr. on PM Modi’s foreign visits

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The government spent around ₹557.51 crore between 2021 and July 2026 on Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s foreign visits, the External Affairs Ministry stated in the Rajya Sabha on Thursday.

Responding to a question from V. Sivadasan of the CPI(M), Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita said Mr. Modi visited 77 countries during this period.

The 35-page response among other details mentioned that this year for the February 25-26 Israel visit by Mr. Modi, the government spent around ₹11.92 crores. For Mr. Modi’s joint France and U.S. visit of February 10-13, 2025, the government spent ₹25.59 crore and ₹16.54 crore, respectively.

The government also informed Parliament that 316 Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) were signed with various countries during this period. It mentioned that overall FDI inflow during this time was ₹381.8 billion.

# House panel flags fertilizer shortage, calls for proper mechanism to address it

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

Citing recurring reports of shortages, farmer protests, and distribution-related disruptions despite repeated assurances about adequate availability of fertilizers, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Chemicals and Fertilizers demanded the Union government institutionalise a permanent joint fertilizer command and monitoring cell, comprising the Department of Fertilizers, the Department of Agriculture, the Railways, and the State governments to provide “continuous, real-time coordination” on the supply of fertilizers during every cropping season.

The report on the “Alignment of logistics for efficient fertilizer movement and availability at affordable prices during peak season and steps taken to curb forced bundling of unnecessary boosters with essential fertilizers”, which was tabled on Thursday in both Houses, also said the Un-



Kirti Azad

ion government’s interventions to ensure adequate supply of input materials for fertilizer production during the ongoing war in West Asia were “largely reactive” and not guided by “a pre-existing institutionalised contingency framework” for foreseeable disruptions at critical maritime chokepoints, including the Strait of Hormuz.

### Last-mile distribution

The panel, headed by Trinamool Congress MP Kirti Azad, also noted that the Centre limits its role to ensuring State-level availability, with the last-mile distribution treated “solely as” a State responsibility, blam-

ing such an approach as inadequate for addressing recurring supply bottlenecks.

Noticing “persistent underperformance” of new generation urea plants, the panel said they continued to operate significantly below their potential despite being counted amongst the country’s latest manufacturing facilities.

It recommended that all future technology transfer, and engineering and equipment supply contracts for fertilizer public sector undertakings and joint ventures must incorporate robust performance guarantees and warranty obligations to ensure the financial consequences of technology failure were borne by the supplier and not by the public exchequer.

It also recommended an urgent plant-wise diagnostic assessment of underutilised and idle diammonium phosphate units to identify the raw material, technical, commercial and operational constraints limiting production.

## P.J. Kurien urges Speaker to ensure Home Minister’s presence in LS

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

Former Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman and veteran Congress leader P.J. Kurien on Thursday urged Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla to “perform the duty of directing” Union Home Minister Amit Shah to be present in the House and respond to the questions raised by the Opposition members.

In a letter to the Speaker, Mr. Kurien said that as a citizen of the country, he was disappointed over the “non-functioning” of the House and its “failure” to ensure the accountability of the government and avoid the “consequent stalemate”. Noting that the Lok Sabha was not functioning for about one week because the Union Home Minister was “not coming to the House to respond to the questions of his department raised by the Opposition members”, he said in a democracy, the Opposition had an equally important role to play as the ruling party.

### Constitutional duty

He said the government was accountable to Parliament and it was the constitutional duty of the Opposition to ensure accountability. It was the constitutional duty of the Speaker to protect the rights of members in their effort to ensure accountability, said Mr. Kurien, adding that if the Union Home Minister “evaded” Parliament continuously, he was “failing to perform his constitutional duty”.

# Congress is not allowing Parliament to function: BJP

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The BJP on Thursday accused the Congress of spreading “false narratives” and preventing Parliament from functioning, while attacking Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi over the alleged examination irregularities in Jharkhand.

At a press briefing, BJP MP and former Union Minister Ravi Shankar Prasad said that Mr. Gandhi and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge were causing repeated

disruptions in Parliament. He said Mr. Gandhi and Mr. Kharge “come up with new stories every day and arrive with new posters”.

Mr. Prasad said the Jharkhand government had entrusted several examinations to a blacklisted company. “The same company that was blacklisted by the governments of Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan has been assigned responsibility for conducting several examinations in Jharkhand,” he said. “Rahul Gandhi is a hypocrite. He says one thing here while remaining silent there,” he added.

# RS clears Appropriation Bill for expenditure of ₹54,067 crore

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

Amid protests and a walkout by Opposition members demanding the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah in the House, the Rajya Sabha on Thursday considered and returned the Appropriation Bill, 2026 that allows the expenditure of around ₹54,067 crore incurred during the 2022-23 financial year.

Replying to a brief discussion on the Bill, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said the excess expenditure arose under

two heads and had already been examined by the Public Accounts Committee (PAC). She noted that the demands formed part of the PAC’s 39th Report, which was presented to the Lok Sabha in April.

Ms. Sitharaman said an excess demand of ₹196.44 crore stemmed from a court order relating to the Ministry of Railways, while the larger demand of ₹53,871 crore was towards debt repayment.

Responding to a demand for greater financial assistance to Jammu and Kashmir, the Finance Minister said the Centre bears

the entire salary and pension of Jammu and Kashmir Police, amounting to approximately ₹13,000 crore annually.

“We paid back the entire debt of Ladakh and after taking care of readjustments, restructured J&K’s debt. Also, for the years 2024-25 and 2025-26, an additional amount of ₹5,000 crore each year has been given, over and above the revised estimates of their budgets, to make sure the urgent requirements of the J&K administration [are met] and it is not left without anybody’s support,” Ms. Sitharaman said.

**अजमेर विकास प्राधिकरण, अजमेर**  
अजमेर शहर, विभिन्न व्यूह, अजमेर, Email :- [ajmeradev@gmail.com](mailto:ajmeradev@gmail.com),  
Website :- [www.rajasthan.gov.in/ada](http://www.rajasthan.gov.in/ada), Tel.No. :- 0145-2627748-2627749  
प्रजापक :- अजमेर (रा.2/राजनीति)/2026-27/राजकाय 23723839 दिनांक :- 31/07/2026

**E-TENDER - 21/2026-27**  
Bids for Design, supply, installation, testing and commissioning of integrated Audio-visual, Projection mapping, Laser, lighting system and multimedia content generation for light and sound show at pushkar amounting Rs. 1197-19 Lacs are invited from interested bidders for upto 19.08.2026, 6:00 PM. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>) & (<http://sppp.raaj.nic.in>) <http://www.urban.rajasthan.gov.in/ada> departmental website. UBN No. : A/JD2627WLOB00125  
Raj.Samwad/C/26/8808 Executive Engineer

**OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER  
UPPER INDRAVATI RIGHT CANAL DIVISION NO.II  
AT/PO. JUNAGARH, DIST. : KALAHANDI**

**Auction Sale Notice**  
The undersigned has invited 5 Nos of Auction Sale Notice for selling T & P materials "as is where basis" in the premises of Superintending Engineer, Right canal Division No-II, Junagarh on date - **12.08.2026 at 11.00 A.M.**

|                            |                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Name of the work</b>    | <b>Auction Sale</b>                                                                                          |
| <b>Auction Schedule</b>    | Date-12.08.2026 at 11.00 AM<br>Place- Office of the Superintending Engineer, U.I.R.C.D.No-II, Junagarh       |
| <b>Annexures</b>           | 1. Auction Sale details and Conditions<br>2. Item Description for Auction Sale (Annexure-1)                  |
| <b>Special Instruction</b> | Details of the Items and Conditions of Auction Sale are displayed on the Notice board of Divisional Officer. |

**Superintending Engineer,  
Right Canal Division No.II, Junagarh.**  
32001/651/2627 OIPR-32001/32016/126-27/0001

| NAVODAYA VIDYALAYA SAMITI<br>Engagement of Project Staff for Vigyan Jyoti Phase-VII (2026-27) |                              |                                                                                                                                                             |                 |                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------|
| S. No.                                                                                        | Name of Position             | Essential Qualification                                                                                                                                     | Upper Age Limit | Remuneration                |
| 1.                                                                                            | Project Scientist-I (1 Post) | Doctoral Degree in Science or Master's Degree in Engineering or Technology from a recognized University or equivalent                                       | 40 Years        | Rs. 56,000/- + HRA          |
| 2.                                                                                            | Accountant (1 Post)          | B.Com from any recognized university.<br><b>Desirable:</b> Three years' experience of Account work in Government / Semi-Government Autonomous Organization. | 35 Years        | Rs. 40,000/- (Consolidated) |

The project staff will be engaged for a period of one year on contract or coterminous with the project, whichever is earlier, they will work with the Project Office **Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti, Noida** or any other assigned location. Preference will be given to candidates with experience in science outreach programs and project management.

The qualifications details and application form are available on NVS official website <https://navodaya.gov.in>. Interested applicants are invited to submit their applications in the format given at **Annexure-I** to the **Project Coordinator, Vigyan Jyoti, NVS, Noida** via email at [vigyanjyotinvs@gmail.com](mailto:vigyanjyotinvs@gmail.com) by **10<sup>th</sup> Aug, 2026**.

Vigyan Jyoti Section  
Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti

ANNEXURE-I

**Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti: Vigyan Jyoti Project**  
**Application for the Post of Project Scientist-I/ Accountant**

1. Application for the Post : .....  
2. Name of the Applicant : .....  
3. Father /Husband Name : .....  
4. Category (General / SC / ST / OBC) : .....  
5. Date of Birth : .....  
6. Age as on 01.08.2026 .....  
7. Aadhaar No. : .....  
8. Address for Correspondence : .....  
9. Contact No. (Mob) : .....  
10. Email ID : .....  
11. Educational Qualification (in Chronological order from Senior Secondary (Class-XII on wards) (Copies of supporting documents are to be enclosed):  
12. Experience (in chronological order) (Documentary evidence is to be closed)

Affix your latest passport size photograph

| S. No. | Examination Passed | Year of Passing | Board/ University | Subject Taken | % of marks obtained (up to 2 decimal points) |
|--------|--------------------|-----------------|-------------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------|
|        |                    |                 |                   |               |                                              |
|        |                    |                 |                   |               |                                              |
|        |                    |                 |                   |               |                                              |

| S. No. | Post held | Organization | Period From To | Nature of Duties | Remarks |
|--------|-----------|--------------|----------------|------------------|---------|
|        |           |              |                |                  |         |
|        |           |              |                |                  |         |
|        |           |              |                |                  |         |

**DECLARATION**  
I solemnly declare the statements and details given above in the application form are correct to the best of my knowledge and belief. In case of any of the details in the application form are found false at a later state, my candidature/engagement may be cancelled/withdrawn.  
Date: .....  

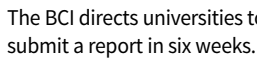
(Signature of the Candidate)



Advocating “full Statehood” for J&K, Congress on Thursday demanded constitutional safeguards for land and public employment for the people of J&K. Party’s Member of Parliament Syed Naseer Hussain, while commenting on seven years of abrogation of Article 370, said that constitutional safeguards for land and public employment for the people are one of the key demands of the party. He said delimitation has been completed and elections have been held in J&K, yet J&K continues under a constitutional arrangement where an unelected Lieutenant Governor exercises overriding authority.

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to grant interim bail on medical grounds to self-styled godman Asaram, but permitted him to engage a caretaker of his choice for round-the-clock medical assistance in jail. On May 27, Rajasthan High Court upheld the life sentence imposed on the octogenarian for sexually assaulting a minor devotee at his Jodhpur ashram in 2013. A Bench of Justices M.M. Sundresh and P.B. Varale took on record a medical report on Asaram's health condition. The report concluded while he did not require hospitalisation, he may need medical assistance. The top court also gave him liberty to seek interim relief if his condition deteriorated.

The Bar Council of India (BCI) has directed all universities to physically inspect all affiliated and constituent law colleges under their jurisdiction and submit a consolidated compliance report within six weeks. It has also ordered an end to weekend, evening, and shift-based law programmes used to overcome shortages of classrooms, faculty, and other infrastructure.



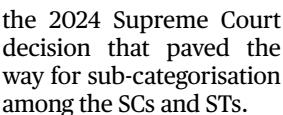
full-time faculty, adequate infrastructure and meaningful practical training," the BCI said.

The directions follow a July 29 judgment of the Andhra Pradesh High Court in *All Saints Christian Education Society vs State of Andhra Pradesh* case. The court held that universities have a continuing duty to ensure that law colleges comply with the minimum standards prescribed under the Rules of Legal Education. It also observed that universities could face statutory consequences for granting affila-

**O**pposing a batch of petitions in the Supreme Court seeking the exclusion of the “creamy layer” from the Scheduled Castes (SCs) and the Scheduled Tribes (STs), on the lines of the system in place for the Other Backward Classes (OBC), the Union government has argued that judicial precedents had clarified that the “principles of creamy layer are not applicable to SCs and STs”.

The Social Justice and Empowerment Ministry further told the top court in an affidavit that in a “majority” of welfare and development schemes for the SCs, STs, and OBCs, except reservation in educational institutes and services under the State, there was already a “means test which ensures that benefits of schemes percolate to those who actually deserve them”.

The stand comes after the apex court in February issued a notice on the petitions. The court had also asked the Centre to file an Action Taken Report after



No such report appears to have been filed with this affidavit.

## 'Need holistic review'

In its submission, the Ministry said, "Modification of reservation policy, particularly to introduce income-based preferences within reserved categories, should be preceded by a holistic review and thorough empirical study, including socio-economic data of reserved category beneficiaries."

It said the main objective of the reservation policy for the SC, ST and OBC groups was to “achieve so-

cial equality and justice, overcome historical disadvantages and discrimination, ensure economic empowerment and upliftment for marginalised communities, and promote their inclusive participation in education, public services, and decision-making processes”.

Further, the government has said that the current matter neither raises a constitutional issue nor discloses the violation of any fundamental right under the Constitution.

It went on to say that the petitioners had “indulged in misstatement of facts solely with the intention of misleading” the court.

The Ministry was referring to certain parts of the

The Gujarat High Court has granted regular bail to a Surat woman accused of beating her two-year-old daughter to death, observing that the case exposes a broader failure of the state and society to protect vulnerable families from hunger and extreme poverty.

Granting bail to Lakhiben Solanki, who has been in custody since her arrest in March, Justice Hasmukh D. Suthar last week said the incident should not be viewed solely as an individual crime but as a reflection of systemic shortcomings in ensuring access to basic necessities such as food, healthcare and dignity.

According to the prosecution, Ms. Solanki allegedly assaulted her daughter, Eesha, after the child repeatedly asked for food.

In its order, the court said social justice rests on the principle that every individual is entitled to basic needs, including food and shelter. It observed that when starvation pushes a mother to such an extreme, the failure extends beyond the individual to society as a whole.

The court said the incident underscored shortcomings in social welfare mechanisms and highlighted the constitutional responsibility of the state to safeguard the nutrition, health and welfare of children and other vulnerable sections. Describing the case as a reminder that hunger is not merely an economic issue but one involving human dignity and justice, it said the tragedy should prompt greater compassion and renewed efforts to ensure that no mother or child suffers because of starvation.

In a renewed push for the idea of federalism, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Thursday said India needs every State to be “strong”, and that “laggard” States need to be given “every hand-holding” so they can improve.

At the same time, the country also needs a strong Centre to manage defence, exports and manufacturing, which a few States cannot take care of for the whole country, she added.

"I strongly believe States have to be strong," she said in response to a question on Centre-State relations.

"I strongly believe States have to be helped. I also strongly believe laggards among States will have to be told that you cannot be a laggard. Many times, we hesitate to say the fact, but they have to be pulled up."

Ms. Sitharaman, who



was speaking at the India Policy Forum 2026 organised by the National Council of Applied Economic Research, said, "It cannot be that some States can do well and some others can remain where they are... We have to give them every hand-holding to get them to be back."

## ‘Not sufficient’

However, the Finance Minister said that strong States themselves are not sufficient for the country.

“You also need a Centre which has the resources to take care of the defence of this country, which takes

care of having a policy which will enable exports, which will enable manufacturing," she said.

"It cannot be left to the States, and a 'beggar your neighbour' policy to get the industries and the investment."

Ms. Sitharaman said the country needs a Centre that can set “all the clear tones” to get investments and policies and ensure that parts of this country that have remained underdeveloped for a long time are helped to catch up with the rest of the country.

“So, there is a role for the Centre, and that role cannot be played by one or two States,” she said.

"But yet, unless the States, and I mean each one of them, are empowered and given the resources and also given thoughts about how capacity can be built, the aspirations of India cannot be met," the Finance Minister added.

# SUDOKU

▼

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|   |   |   |   | 5 | 8 |   |   | 1 |
|   |   |   |   | 3 |   | 4 |   | 5 |
|   | 4 |   | 1 |   |   |   | 7 |   |
|   | 5 |   |   |   |   |   |   | 3 |
| 7 | 1 |   |   |   |   |   | 4 | 6 |
| 8 |   |   |   |   |   |   | 5 |   |
|   | 3 |   |   |   | 5 |   | 9 |   |
| 2 |   | 6 |   | 9 |   |   |   |   |
| 9 |   |   |   | 8 | 2 |   |   |   |

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

**Solution to previous puzzle**

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| E | F | Y |   | P | A | S |   |   |
| O | A | T | T | I | M | O |   |   |
| I | L | L | U | S | T | V | O | O |
| T | U | T | T | F | R | A | R | L |
| Y | O | G | A | T | E | E | L | O |
| N | A | E | E |   |   |   |   |   |
| H | O | R | S | D | O | E | U | V |
| R | E | B | R |   |   | O | R |   |
| B | E | A | R | E | R | O | L | D |
| F | I | A | N | C | E |   |   |   |
| F | I | A | N | C | E |   |   |   |
| T | T | D |   |   |   |   |   |   |

**Solution to yesterday's Sudoku**

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 4 | 1 | 7 | 5 | 6 | 2 | 9 | 3 | 8 |
| 6 | 3 | 5 | 1 | 8 | 9 | 4 | 2 | 7 |
| 2 | 9 | 8 | 3 | 7 | 4 | 6 | 5 | 1 |
| 7 | 2 | 9 | 4 | 1 | 6 | 5 | 8 | 3 |
| 8 | 5 | 4 | 7 | 9 | 3 | 1 | 6 | 2 |
| 3 | 6 | 1 | 8 | 2 | 5 | 7 | 9 | 4 |
| 5 | 8 | 2 | 6 | 4 | 7 | 3 | 1 | 9 |
| 9 | 7 | 3 | 2 | 5 | 1 | 8 | 4 | 6 |
| 1 | 4 | 6 | 9 | 3 | 8 | 2 | 7 | 5 |

The Five Principles, called *Artha Panchakam*, are the core teachings that every seeker of liberation should know. Sri Desika Srinivasa Thathachariar said in a discourse that understanding them is necessary before a person can receive initiation into the *Rahasya Trayam*, the three sacred secrets, from a spiritual teacher known as Acharya. As seekers move towards liberation, the Acharya offers guidance.

The first principle is *Para Svarupa*, the nature of the Supreme Being. Sriman Narayana is the Supreme Brahman. He is eternal, unchanging, and the very embodiment of knowledge (*gnana*). He alone is the ultimate cause, sustainer, and ruler of the entire universe.

The second principle, *jīva svarūpa*, addresses the nature of the individual soul. The soul is distinct from the body, mind, and senses. Its essential nature is to serve as the eternal servant (*śeṣha*) of the Lord. The third principle is *Upaya svarūpa*, the essential nature of the means to attain the Supreme Lord. The way to liberation includes *Siddhōpaya*, the already achieved means consisting of the Lord Himself, and *Sādhyōpaya*, the means the seeker should practice, such as Bhakti Yoga or Prapatti (Saranagati).

The fourth principle is *Phala Svarupa*, which describes the ultimate goal. When a soul is liberated, it goes to Sri Vaikuntha, leaves behind its subtle body, regains eight divine qualities, and enjoys the happiness of serving the Lord forever in His divine home. The fifth and final principle is *Virodhi Svarupa*, the nature of obstacles that prevent liberation. By understanding these five principles under the guidance of an Acharya, a seeker progresses towards moksha and service at lotus feet of Lord Vishnu.



INBRIEF



LIC Q1 net at ₹13,492 cr. up 23% on premium, business

Life Insurance Corporation of India's (LIC's) standalone net profit for the June quarter rose 22.81% year-on-year (YoY) to ₹13,492 crore on higher premium income and a surge in value of new business (VNB). Total premium income of the State-owned insurer increased 6.75% YoY to ₹1,27,250 crore. CEO and MD R.Doraiswamy said despite increasing competition in life insurance, LIC was able to maintain leadership in individual and group business during the quarter.

Milky Mist Dairy IPO opens on Aug. 11 at ₹133-140/share

Milky Mist Dairy Food Ltd. set price band of ₹133-140/share for its ₹1,553-crore initial public offering (IPO) opening for subscription on August 11. The IPO comprises fresh issue of equity shares aggregating up to ₹1,428 crore and an Offer For Sale (OFS) of up to ₹125 crore. K. Rathnam, CEO, told *The Hindu* a part of the IPO funds would go towards closing debt and the rest investments. Singapore sovereign fund Temasek invested ₹482 crore in the firm in May, taking a 5% stake.

Lumina Datamatics acquires 100% stake of TNQTech

Lumina Datamatics which is into content, retail support and technology solutions, said it acquired 100% stake in TNQTech, a Chennai-based publishing technology firm. In 2024, the company signed a pact to buy 80% stake in TNQTech. Mariam Ram, founder and director, TNQTech, said,“Our technology and domain expertise align perfectly with their scale and reach in scholarly publishing.”

July auto retail sales surged 26% to almost 26 lakh units

Lalathendu Mishra  
MUMBAI

In July, Indian automobile industry retailed 25,91,138 units, up 26% year-on-year, making it the strongest July growth in the series outside COVID-distorted base years, said Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA).

Growth was broad-based with wheeled construction equipment sales up 46%, two-wheelers (2W) up 28.2%, tractors 28.1%, commercial vehicles (CV) up 24%, passenger vehicles (PV) 19.13% and three-wheelers (3W) up 16.2% as per FADA data. Total EV retail sales touched 3,27,901 units – the highest for any month



Commercial Vehicle retails at 99,666 units grew 24%. REUTERS

in history – with 2W and CV EV volumes at a record, taking overall EV growth rate to about 12.7% from 9.6% a year ago. Sai Giridhar, VP, FADA said, “July etched itself into Indian auto retail history – for the first time on record, every single category post-

ed its best-ever July with two- and three-wheelers, CVs, PVs, tractors and wheeled construction equipment all at all-time July highs.

**GST 2.0 momentum** “Dealers attribute this moment to GST 2.0-led affordability, ease of retail finance and favourable festival timing on a July 2025 base that had slid almost 4%, alongside a quiet inflection that deserves the industry’s attention: alternative fuels are now within striking distance of petrol in the PV market,” he said. “With FY27’s first four months EV retail sales up 18.27%, the runway into the festive season is firmly intact,” he added.

Taxation bill passed in the Lok Sabha

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

The Taxation and other Laws (Amendment) Bill, through which the government wants to promote domestic electronics manufacturing, attract foreign funds and modify the zero-MDR framework on digital payments was passed by the Lok Sabha.

The intention of the government behind bringing the Bill is to make India a more attractive and predictable place for global capital, manufacturing and business to come and stay.

The Taxation and other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, replaces the June 5 Ordinance that provided I-T exemption to interest income and capital gains made by FPIs from invest-



The bill would allow merchant charges on UPI transactions.

ments in G-Secs. The Bill proposes to remove the linkage between the Payment and Settlement Systems Act and the Income Tax Act and give a legal backing to the government to modify the zero-MDR framework on UPI and RuPay card transactions. The move could allow merchant charges on select UPI transactions.

Sugar mills to advance cane crushing schedule

The Hindu Bureau  
COIMBATORE

Sugar mills will start operating 10-15 days before the normal schedule for the 2026-2027 sugar marketing season to ensure adequate availability of sugar during the festival season.

At a meeting held with the Joint Secretary (Sugar) last month, the Indian Sugar and Bio-energy Manufacturers Association and the National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories committed the mills will advance the sugarcane crushing schedule.

“This proactive decision will enable fresh sugar to reach the local market well ahead of the festive season,” the associations said.

Govt. okays ₹23,371 cr. GOBARdhan scheme

The National Circular Bioenergy Scheme aspires to raise local production of CBG by tenfold, mobilise private investments on a large scale

Saptaparno Ghosh  
NEW DELHI

The Union cabinet approved the National Circular Bioenergy Scheme - GO-BARDhan, provisioning ₹23,731-crore to catalyse the growth of compressed biogas (CBG).

The GOBARDhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) outlay, to be in place until FY2035-36 seeks to raise local compressed biogas production almost tenfold via assured offtake, administered pricing, capital subsidies, boosting pipeline infrastructure and easier access to finance, the Centre said.

The government emphasised the scheme would seek to impart a “strong and predictable framework” to fuel the up-tick of the CBG ecosystem.



Energy security: The compressed biogas plant at Brahmapuram currently processes about 50 tonne of biodegradable waste a day.

The programme would involve the use of agricultural residue, cattle dung, sugar industry waste such as press mud, municipal organic waste and other biomass to produce compressed biogas, which can be blended into CNG used in automobiles and also piped natural gas (PNG).

Three imperatives

Welcoming the government initiative, A.R. Shuk-

la, President of the Indian Biogas Association said the scheme addresses three imperatives – remunerative price, assured offtake and capital support – sought by the industry.

“This scheme delivers all three,” he said, adding, “moving from 300 operating plants towards 5,000 [plants] will create lakhs of rural jobs. Industry must respond with speed, quality and discipline.”

‘Oil cargoes from Russian Black Sea ports down two-thirds’

M. Kalyanaraman  
CHENNAI

The Ukraine-Russia conflict has led to a 66% cut in India-bound oil cargoes from Russian Black Sea ports in the last two weeks, said Bimco, a leading shipowners association. Though Russia’s Baltic ports have the major share of India’s crude imports

from Russia, Black Sea ports provide some 30% of Russian imports. In June, over 50% of India’s crude imports came from Russia. Ukraine’s Black Sea attacks were concentrated around the CPC Novorossiysk terminal that supplied 0.7 million barrels/day to India in June. India’s oil import need is 5 million barrels/day. “Crude supplies

are secured till month end. If the situation persists beyond August, India will have to find alternative sources,” said Pankaj Srivastava, SVP, Rystad. Meanwhile, at least five Indian seafarers have been killed in ship attacks in Black Sea in July presumably from attacks by both belligerents. Two from a July 25 incident are still re-

RBI tags Tata Sons NBFC-UL, pressure mounts for listing

Lalathendu Mishra  
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) released a list of 17 large (upper layer or UL) non-banking finance companies (NBFCs), which included Tata Sons subjecting them to enhanced regulatory norms for at least five years and mandatory listing within three years of identification.

The banking regulator released the list of NBFCs, which have been categorised as Upper Layer NBFC (NBFC-UL) for the year 2026-27 even as it said the status of Tata Sons would depend on its de-registration application outcome.

“The inclusion of Tata Sons Pvt. Ltd. in the list of NBFC-ULs is without prejudice to the outcome of its application for de-registration, which is under examination,” the RBI said.

It means Tata Sons, categorised as a core investment company, must adhere to the strict guidelines of the RBI and get listed.



RBI released the list of NBFCs categorised as Upper Layer.

Last year, following repeated demands for its listing as per RBI norms, Tata Sons applied for de-registration of its NBFC licence. However, the RBI is yet to approve the same.

The central bank’s framework categorises NBFCs in Base Layer (NBFC-BL), Middle Layer (NBFC-ML), Upper Layer (NBFC-UL) and Top Layer (NBFC-TL) and provides the criteria to identify the NBFCs in the Upper Layer.

The Shapoorji Pallonji Group which has 18% stake in Tata Sons, had been demanding the listing to re-

lease the capital blocked in the Tata Group holding entity. About 66% of Tata Sons is owned by charitable trusts and many Tata Trusts trustees reportedly supported it’s listing.

Other companies

Other companies that figure in the list are REC Ltd, Power Finance Corporation Ltd., Indian Railways Finance Corporation Ltd, Bajaj Finance, Shriram Finance, Tata Capital, LIC Housing Finance, Cholamandalam Investment & Finance, Muthoot Finance, Aditya Birla Capital, Housing & Urban Development Corporation, Mahindra Financial Services, L&T Finance, Bajaj Housing Finance, HDB Financial Services and Piramal Finance. All of these are listed except for Tata Sons.

As per the RBI’s framework of Scale Based Regulation, the UL would comprise NBFCs specifically identified annually by it as warranting enhanced regulatory requirements.

ported missing.

India has year-to-date been the single largest destination from Black Sea ports, receiving 25% of the exports from Russian ports in the Black Sea and Sea of Azov, according to Bimco.

On July 6, Ukraine unveiled Operation MoLoChKa, a large-scale maritime drone campaign starting with Russia-linked ship-

ping in the Sea of Azov. Ukraine says it is aimed at disrupting Russian oil, fuel and cargo logistics. “Initially, the campaign reportedly targeted smaller ships operating from Sea of Azov ports and expanded to the Black Sea on July 15. By July 28, Ukraine claimed over 200 ships had been attacked,” says Niels Rasmusen, Bimco’s chief shipping

analyst. Ukraine’s drone operation hit Sea of Azov shipments and reportedly contributed to Russia suspending navigation via Kerch Strait and Don-Azov Canal, impacting exports. Oil loadings from the Caspian Pipeline Consortium terminal in Novorossiysk fell 62% in past two weeks compared with the previous four weeks, he says.

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE  
Bangalore - 560012  
IISc/CCMD/Tenders/2026-27 Date: 04.08.2026  
Tender Notification- IISc/ Tender-ELE-04/2026-27  
Indian Institute of Science invites bids in two cover system through e-procurement platform <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Any specialised firms company registered under KPWD / CPWD/ railways/ MES/ central PSUs/ or any Government department of **Class I/Class A Electrical Contractors** are eligible to apply for the work of **"SITC of 6-passenger Elevator in Electrical Engineering Department in IISc, Bangalore"**. Estimated Cost of Project is **Rs. 20,37,052.00**. Last date of receipt of application is **24<sup>th</sup> August 2026 at 15:30 Hrs.** Any other details can be obtained from the office of the Centre for Campus Management & Development, Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore on all working days or e-mail [office.ccmd@iisc.ac.in](mailto:office.ccmd@iisc.ac.in) **Sd/-, Registrar**

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE  
Bangalore - 560012  
IISc/CCMD/Tenders/2026-27 Date: 05.08.2026  
Tender Notification- IISc/ Tender-AMC-1/2026-27  
Indian Institute of Science invites bids in two cover system through e-procurement platform <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Any specialised firms company registered under KPWD / CPWD/ railways/ MES/ central PSUs/ or any Government department are eligible to apply for the work of **"Renovation and retrofitting of 2\*500 KLD sewage treatment plants and 1\*100 KLD Effluent Treatment plant with two years Annual Maintenance Contract at IISc, Bangalore."** Estimated Cost of Project is **Rs. 3,71,82,873.00**. Last date of receipt of application is **25<sup>th</sup> August 2026 at 15:30 Hrs.** Any other details can be obtained from the office of the Centre for Campus Management & Development, Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore on all working days or e-mail [office.ccmd@iisc.ac.in](mailto:office.ccmd@iisc.ac.in) **Sd/-, Registrar**

Government of Kerala  
Published Tenders from 03-08-2026 to 05-08-2026  
Stationery Department  
Tender ID: 2026\_STY\_864241\_1 \* Stationery Controller \* Supply of Multilayered Board 58 cm x 78 cm x 200 GSM \* Closing Date: 31-Aug-2026 \* PAC: Rs49997506  
Tender ID: 2026\_STY\_864279\_1 \* Stationery Controller \* Supply of Maplitho Paper 75 gsm RA1 \* Closing Date: 31-Aug-2026 \* PAC: Rs24750000  
Tender ID: 2026\_STY\_864307\_1 \* Stationery Controller \* Supply of Maplitho Paper 75 gsm 86 cm reel \* Closing Date: 31-Aug-2026 \* PAC: Rs47768000  
Tender ID: 2026\_STY\_864031\_1 \* Stationery Controller \* Supply of Maplitho Paper 38 cm Reel, 70 GSM \* Closing Date: 29-Aug-2026 \* PAC: Rs644924203  
Tender ID: 2026\_STY\_864160\_1 \* Stationery Controller \* Supply of Maplitho Paper 41.5 cm Reel, 70 GSM \* Closing Date: 29-Aug-2026 \* PAC: Rs30275029  
Tender ID: 2026\_STY\_864170\_1 \* Stationery Controller \* Supply of Maplitho Paper 76 cm Reel, 70 GSM \* Closing Date: 29-Aug-2026 \* PAC: Rs266473977  
Tender ID: 2026\_STY\_864190\_1 \* Stationery Controller \* Supply of Maplitho Paper 38 cm Reel, 70 gsm \* Closing Date: 29-Aug-2026 \* PAC: Rs16272025  
Tender ID: 2026\_STY\_864232\_1 \* Stationery Controller \* Supply of Multilayered Board 58 cm x 86 cm x 200 GSM \* Closing Date: 31-Aug-2026 \* PAC: Rs95550541  
Visit <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> for more details.  
Ro.No:03-05/Aug/2026/PRD/(N)/7

GOVERNMENT OF GOA  
DIRECTORATE OF TRIBAL WELFARE, PROJECT CELL, PATTO - PANAJIM, GOA.  
e-TENDER NOTICE  
No. GTWD(Project Cell)/F.08/2026-27/05 Dated: - 05/08/2026  
This office has published above e-Tender Notices. The details are available on (Website: <https://eprocure.goa.gov.in>). The last date and time for online application for issue & submission of Tender Bid is 26/08/2026 up to 17:00 hrs. Detailed tender notices may be seen on the notice board of this office. For any Further Clarification, The Project Cell of this office may be contacted.  
DI/ADVT/1122/2026

CENTRE FOR DEVELOPMENT OF IMAGING TECHNOLOGY (C-DIT)  
Thiruvananthapuram-27  
Ph: 0471-2380910/912  
E-TENDER NOTICE  
e-Tenders are invited for the Supply of "Aluminum Metalized Tamper Evident Polyester Film".  
Tender id: 2026\_CDT\_864482\_1  
For details and online submission of bid please visit [www.etenders.kerala.gov.in](http://www.etenders.kerala.gov.in)  
Last date of submission of bids: 13.08.2026, 03.00 PM.  
06.08.2026 Registrar, C-DIT

दिल्ली प्रौद्योगिकी विश्वविद्यालय  
DELHI TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY  
Established by Govt. of Delhi vide Act 6 of 2009 (Formerly Delhi College of Engineering)  
SHAHBAD DAULATPUR, BAWANA ROAD, DELHI-110042  
File No. F.DTU/Rect./T&P/2025/F-988/5363 Dated: 28/07/2026  
ADVERTISEMENT NOTICE No. 02/2026  
RECRUITMENT TO THE POST OF ASSISTANT PROFESSOR OF PRACTICE (TRAINING & PLACEMENT) AND PROFESSOR OF PRACTICE (TRAINING & PLACEMENT) on Tenure Track Appointment basis (for a maximum 05 years term)  
The opening date and closing date for receipt of applications are as under:-  
Opening Date for Submission of Online Applications :- 07/08/2026 (7<sup>th</sup> August, 2026) from 11:00 AM  
Closing Date for Submission of Online Applications :- 07/09/2026 (7<sup>th</sup> September, 2026) till 05:00 PM  
Closing Date for Submission of Hard Copy of Applications :- 21/09/2026 (21<sup>st</sup> September, 2026) till 05:00 PM  
Delhi Technological University is a teaching-cum-research University committed to foster excellence in education, research, technology incubation, product innovation, outreach and extension activities in Engineering, Management, and Applied Sciences. The University invites applications from the talented individuals to fill up the following posts on Tenure Track Appointment basis (for a maximum 05 years term):  

| Sr. No. | Nomenclature of Post                                   | Classification of the post (Group) | Total No. of Posts* (Tenure Track Appointment basis) | Category |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 1.      | Assistant Professor of Practice (Training & Placement) | Group A                            | 01                                                   | UR       |
| 2.      | Professor of Practice (Training & Placement)           | Group A                            | 01                                                   | UR       |

\*The number of posts advertised is provisional and can be varied as per the requirement of the University. The interested candidates are required to fill up the online application form. After submitting the applications through ONLINE, candidates should take a printout of application form and submit it alongwith self-attested copies of certificates/documents to the Recruitment Cell, Room No. 801, 8<sup>th</sup> Floor, AB-3 Block, DTU, Delhi-110042. All further communications related to recruitment will be displayed on the university website [www.dtu.ac.in](http://www.dtu.ac.in) from time to time. No personal communication will be entertained in this regard. The candidates are advised to visit the university website i.e. [www.dtu.ac.in](http://www.dtu.ac.in) for detailed advertisement.  
-Sd- Registrar

THE HUTTI GOLD MINES COMPANY LIMITED  
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)  
Hutti - 584 115, Raichur Dist., Karnataka State. Phone: 08537-276339/275463  
e-Mail: [material276339@gmail.com](mailto:material276339@gmail.com) website: [www.huttigold.karnataka.gov.in](http://www.huttigold.karnataka.gov.in)  
TENDER NOTIFICATION No.14/26-27 Dt: 07.08.2026 (Through KPP Portal only)  
Tender is invited by "The I/c. Dy. General Manager (Materials)" for the following Tenders as detailed below  

| Sl. No. | Description                                                                                                                                               | EMD in Rs. |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| 1       | Supply of Sodium Cyanide 98 Percent Purity. HGML/2026-27/IND0529                                                                                          | 6,97,500/- |
| 2       | Supply of High Capacity Auxiliary Fan for Mechanized Development. HGML/2026-27/IND0534                                                                    | 1,68,000/- |
| 3       | Supply, Laying of Geotextile Coir Mat with Planting & Maintenance of Greenery on Slope of Tailing Dump at Hutti Gold Mine. HGML/2026-27/OW/WORK_INDENT144 | 2,31,000/- |

Calendar of Events: (1) Pre-Bid Meetings (Zoom): 17.08.2026 for Sl.No.1 at 11.00 AM, for Sl.No.2 at 11.30 AM & for Sl.No.3 at 12.00 PM  
(2) Last date for receipt of tender: 07.09.2026 at 04.00 PM  
(3) Opening of Technical Bid on: 09.09.2026 at 10.00 AM  
For further details interested bidders are advised to log on to website <https://www.kppp.karnataka.gov.in> or contact the office of undersigned during working hours. For participating in the above tender bidder needs to be registered in KPP Portal.  
Sd/- I/c. Dy. General Manager (Materials)  
LEADING GOLD PRODUCER IN INDIA



WASHINGTON

Trump rejects munitions shortage report, says U.S. has ‘huge amounts’



President Donald Trump said on Thursday the United States has a vast supply of munitions and threatened those who suggested otherwise with jail terms as his frustration with the Iran war boiled over. The Republican leader lashed out on his Truth Social platform at media reports about the dwindling weapons stockpile. AFP

CAIRO

Houthi rebel attacks kill at least 30 Yemeni govt. forces, say officials



Attacks by the Iran-backed Houthi rebels on Thursday in central and eastern Yemen killed at least 30 government troops and wounded at least 50 others, Yemeni government officials said. A Houthi leader said Saudi-backed troops were targeted in the attacks and that “hundreds” were either killed or injured. AP

BEIRUT

Rights groups decry Israeli killing of Lebanon reporter as ‘war crime’



Rights groups said on Thursday that an Israeli attack in south Lebanon that killed reporter Amal Khalil and wounded another journalist earlier this year was an apparent “war crime”. The attack took place in the village of Al-Tiri on April 22, days after a ceasefire was announced between Israel and militant group Hezbollah. AFP

WASHINGTON

U.S. sanctions Cuban Armed Forces Minister, five state-owned entities



The U.S. announced new sanctions on Thursday that target Cuban Armed Forces Minister General Alvaro Lopez Miera, seven others and five state-owned entities for “foreign military cooperation and arms procurement”. Earlier, UN experts had warned that U.S. sanctions risked pushing the island nation into “full-blown crisis”. AFP

‘Proposed deal will give Tehran control over inbound strait traffic’

Under the proposal, Tehran will be able to intervene if necessary with any inbound traffic in the strait, while outbound traffic will follow a route between Iran and Oman, with exit clearance granted through Muscat after notifying Iran

Reuters  
LONDON

A proposed deal between Iran and Oman that would give Tehran control over ships entering the Gulf through the Strait of Hormuz is not easily workable due to U.S. sanctions and restrictive insurance clauses on any payments, four industry sources said.

Under the latest proposal, Tehran would be able to intervene if necessary with any inbound traffic, while outbound traffic would follow a route between Iran and Oman, with exit clearance granted through Oman after notifying Iran, a senior Iranian



A small boat sails past cargo ships and other commercial vessels anchored in the Strait of Hormuz off Bandar Abbas in Iran. AP

source told *Reuters*.

The ability of merchant ships to navigate international waterways “safely, predictably and without unnecessary impediment is fundamental to resilient

supply chains, economic stability and energy security”, the world’s leading shipping associations said in an open letter this week.

Introducing compulsory charges through the

strait for transit or service fees was “a toll in all but name”, the letter said, which was sent to the UN’s shipping agency.

What is known as a two-way traffic separation scheme was adopted by the UN’s shipping agency in 1968 with the agreement of countries in the region. It created the current ship routing system that split sailing corridors through Iranian and Omani waters. Iran is seeking fees of between 5% and 7% of the price of cargoes from ships using the strait. Oman is discussing fees of around 3%.

For shipping companies and oil traders, any imposition of fees creates major

compliance issues given the U.S. has imposed sanctions on the Persian Gulf Strait Authority, which Iran set up in May to operate the waterway. The U.S. Treasury has also prohibited U.S. persons from receiving services from Iran’s government related to a “guarantee of safe passage”. Any payment could lead to asset freezes, the industry sources said.

A further complication is the introduction in late July by Lloyd’s Market Association of a clause for use by war underwriters that terminates insurance cover for a vessel if it has paid a transit fee for passage through the Strait of Hormuz.

Ukraine strikes Russian oil refineries far from frontline

Agence France-Presse  
MOSCOW

Ukraine struck two Russian oil refineries hundreds of kilometres from the border in an overnight attack, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Thursday, as Russia hit a train station and commercial ship in Ukraine.

Both sides have been intensifying their long-range attacks in recent months, leading to a jump in civilian deaths.

Kyiv has been firing record numbers of drones at Russia, while Moscow has been launching all-time high missile attacks.

Mr. Zelenskyy said Ukraine had hit oil refineries in the Bashkortostan and Yaroslavl regions – about 1,300 and 700 km from the front. The attacks were “strengthening the pros-



Smoke rises after a Ukrainian drone attack on an oil refinery, as per the regional governor, in Yaroslavl region of Russia. REUTERS

pects for diplomacy”, Mr. Zelenskyy said.

“Russia must choose peace,” he added, posting a video from Russian social media of black smoke rising above an oil facility.

Russia’s Defence Ministry said earlier it had downed 605 Ukrainian drones in the night.

Russian missile attacks on Kyiv a day earlier had

killed at least 17 and destroyed warehouses belonging to a number of retailers in what was widely seen as a direct response to Ukraine’s campaign targeting Wildberries.

Kyiv was unable to down any of the missiles Russia fired, prompting urgent calls from Mr. Zelenskyy for air defence supplies.

Bangladesh to hold presidential election on August 20, says EC

Press Trust of India  
DHAKA

Bangladesh’s presidential election will be held on August 20, the Election Commission announced on Thursday, two weeks after President Mohammed Shahabuddin resigned on health grounds before completing his five-year term. Mr. Shahabuddin, 76, was a long-time ally of deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina.

“Chief Election Commissioner AMM Nasir Uddin has finalised the dates in consultation with [acting parliamentary] Speaker Kayser Kamal,” the EC’s senior secretary Akhtar



Akhtar Ahmed

Ahmed told presspersons. Nomination papers will be accepted at the office of the Chief Election Commissioner on August 13. The scrutiny of nomination papers will be held on August 16. The last date for withdrawal of candidature is August 18.

International media need NOCs to report outside Pak’s cities

Agence France-Presse  
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan’s government has instructed international media to register presspersons and seek permission for any reporting outside the country’s three main cities, sparking concern from rights and media groups over a threat to press freedom.

The Information Ministry sent a statement on Monday to an international media message group on the requirement to seek permission for reporting outside Islamabad, Lahore and Karachi.

Written guidelines published by the Ministry

stated all presspersons working for international media, including freelance reporters, should register with the government’s external media wing.

Organisations would then need to seek Non Objection Certificates (NOCs) from the government for reporting outside the three cities. It was not clear how widely the guidelines would be enforced or if penalties would apply for non-compliance. Local media and rights groups called for the requirements to be withdrawn.

Pakistan is ranked 153 out of 180 nations for press freedom in a Reporters Without Borders index.

China-Japan row escalates after Tokyo terms Beijing ‘greatest strategic challenge’

Press Trust of India  
BEIJING

China has lodged a “serious diplomatic” protest with Japan over its latest defence white paper, which portrayed Beijing as Tokyo’s “greatest strategic challenge” and made “brazen comments” on Taiwan, further escalating tensions between the two countries.

“The white paper once again targeted China with groundless accusations, rehashing the so-called ‘China threat’ and grossly interfering in China’s internal affairs with brazen comments on China’s Taiwan region,” Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jing said on Wednesday.

“We deplore and firmly reject this, and have lodged serious representations with Japan,” he said while answering questions over Japan’s new defence white paper.

**‘Internal affair’**

Defending recurring military drills around Taiwan, which China claims as part of its territory, Mr. Lin said, “Taiwan is an inalienable part of China’s territory. The Taiwan question is entirely China’s internal affair. How to resolve it is a matter for the Chinese ourselves and Japan is in no place to interfere.”

About disputed islands in the East China Sea, he said, “Diaoyu Dao and its affiliated islands have been



Shinjiro Koizumi

China’s territory since ancient times.”

The islands, called Senkaku by Japan and Diaoyu Dao by China, are controlled by Tokyo. The Chinese coast guard periodically conducts patrols around them to assert Beijing’s sovereignty.

The white paper approved by Japan’s Cabinet

on Tuesday said China’s growing military actions are Japan’s top security challenge and “must be addressed through overall national strength and cooperation with allies and like-minded nations”.

The nearly 600-page white paper contained a detailed assessment of the increasingly volatile regional security environment.

In his preface to the white paper, Japanese Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi hoped that it would “deepen the public’s understanding of Japan’s defence and security, and serve as an opportunity for people to reflect on how security is linked to the future of every citizen”.

**The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd**  
(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking) Sankaramangalam, Kollam-691 583  
Phone: 0476-2651215 to 2651217, e-mail: md@kmmll.com, URL: www.kmmll.com

**TENDER NOTICE**  
For more details, please visit E-Tendering Portal, <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> or [www.kmmll.com](http://www.kmmll.com)

| Sl No. | Tender ID          | Items                                           |
|--------|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| 1      | 2026_KMML_864071_1 | Tender for Stack Gas and Ambient Air Monitoring |

Chavara 06.08.2026 Sd/- Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd

**TAMIL NADU NEWSPRINT AND PAPERS LIMITED**  
Unit-1: Kagithapuram – 639 136, Karur Dist. Tamil Nadu  
Unit-2: Mondipatti – 621 306, Trichy District, Tamil Nadu

**NOTICE INVITING TENDERS**

| Tender No     | Description                                                                                 | Due Date |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 262713 002992 | Procurement of Fuel Oil for Unit-I & II                                                     | 20.08.26 |
| 262713 003030 | Procurement of 180GSM Kraft Reels of various sizes for Unit-I & II                          | 20.08.26 |
| 262723 001948 | Procurement of LUBRICANT for Board Machine (CCK) of TNPL Unit-II                            | 21.08.26 |
| 262723 001949 | Procurement of AKD for Liquid Packaging Grade (ALU) for Board Machine (CCK) of TNPL Unit-II | 31.08.26 |

Corrigendum if any will be issued in TNPL Website and NIC Portal only. Detailed Terms & conditions are available in tender document at our websites: [www.tnpl.com](http://www.tnpl.com) / [www.tenders.tn.gov.in](http://www.tenders.tn.gov.in), [www.tntenders.gov.in/nicgepp/app](http://www.tntenders.gov.in/nicgepp/app) DIPR/2451/Tender/2026

**BENGALURU EAST CITY CORPORATION**  
Office of the Executive Engineer, K. R Pura Division,  
Old Madras road, K.R.Pura, Bengaluru-560036  
No: BECC/EE/KRP/TEND/04/2026-27 Date: 05-08-2026

**INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION (IFT) (TWO COVER SYSTEM)**

The Executive Engineer, K. R. Pura Division, BECC, invites tenders on behalf of the Commissioner, BECC, Bengaluru from eligible Tenderers for the construction works detailed in the table below.

| Sl No. | Name of the works                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1.     | Asphalting of Roads at SBI Colony, K V layout, Club Road and Surrounding Areas in Ward No-91 KR Pura (CAT-II (A) Reserve). <b>Amount put to tender : ₹.70.00 Lakhs, EMD: ₹.70,000/-</b>                                                                                                                  |
| 2.     | Asphalting of Roads at Bosco Nagara 5th Cross, Papanna Layout and Surrounding Areas in Ward No-91 KR Pura. <b>Amount put to tender : ₹.95.00 Lakhs, EMD: ₹.1,90,000/-</b>                                                                                                                                |
| 3.     | Ashalting of Roads and Improvements of Drains at Bethal Nagara, Munisawappa Layout, Muneshwara Layout, SV Layout, Domanic Layout, Ashwini Layout, Gayathri Layout, Priyadarshini Layout and Surrounding Area in Ward No-92 Basavanapura. <b>Amount put to tender : ₹.165.00 Lakhs, EMD: ₹.2,47,500/-</b> |

**Calender of Events :** (1) Last date for submission for queries on **14-08-2026 at 3:00 pm.** (2) Date and Time for Pre-Bid Meeting on **14-08-2026 at 3:30 pm.** (3) Last Date and Time for Submission of Tenders on **20-08-2026 at 4:00 pm.** (4) Date and Time for Opening of Technical Bid is **21-08-2026 at 4:30 pm** (5) Date and Time for Opening of Financial Bid is **24-08-2026 at 4:00 pm.**

Sd/- Executive Engineer  
KR Pura Division, BECC

**INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE**  
Bangalore - 560012

**IISc/CCMD/Tenders/2026-27 Date: 04.08.2026**

**Tender Notification- IISc/ Tender-CIV-06/2026-27**

Indian Institute of Science invites bids in two cover system through e-procurement platform <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Any specialized firms company registered under KPWD / CPWD / railways / MES / central PSUs / or any Government department of **Class I/Class A Civil Contractors** are eligible to apply for the work of “**Painting, Waterproofing & Miscellaneous works of Ramanujan hostels (Hostel No. 01 to 28), IISc**”. Estimated Cost of Project is **Rs. 36,96,447.00**. Last date of receipt of application is **24<sup>th</sup> August 2026 at 15:30 Hrs.** Any other details can be obtained from the office of the Centre for Campus Management & Development, Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore on all working days or e-mail [office.cmd@iisc.ac.in](mailto:office.cmd@iisc.ac.in)

Sd/-, Registrar

**DEPARTMENT OF WOMEN AND CHILD DEVELOPMENT**  
Office of the Director, Dept. of Women and Child Development  
PWD Building, Anand Rao Circle, Bengaluru - 560 009

**No: WCD/ICDS/PSY/2/2025 Date:06-08-2026**

**TENDER SCHEDULE (PRE SCHOOL KIT FOR FY:2025-26 ANGANAWADI CENTRES)**

Department of Women and Child Development hereby invites tenders from officially registered and eligible suppliers for the supply of **Pre School Kit to 69922 ANGANAWADI Centres** in the State of Karnataka for the year 2025-26. Interested bidders shall submit the bids through Government of Karnataka's Karnataka Public Procurement portal (<https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>).

| 1 | Tender Reference No.                                                                                                                                      | DWCD/2026-27/IND0112 Dated: 06-08-2026                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2 | Date of Commencement of Download of Tender Document from e-Procurement website: <a href="https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in">https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in</a> | From:- 07-08-2026                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 3 | Date, Time & Venue of Pre- bid Meeting                                                                                                                    | 11-08-2026<br>Director office, Department of Women and Child Development, Anand Rao Circle, Bengaluru-560009, Karnataka.                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 4 | Last Date and Time for uploading Online Queries in Karnataka Public Procurement portal                                                                    | 14-08-2026 up to 5:00 pm                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 5 | Last Date and Time for uploading Tender in Karnataka Public Procurement portal                                                                            | 07-09-2026 up to 5:00 pm                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 6 | Tentative Date and Time of Online Opening of Technical Bids                                                                                               | 09-09-2026 @ 10:00 am                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| 7 | Tentatively fixed date for opening of financial bid after verification of documents Submitted in technical bid Date and Time                              | 10-09-2026 @ 11:00 am                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| 8 | Place of opening of Tenders                                                                                                                               | Karnataka Public Procurement portal                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 9 | Address for Communication                                                                                                                                 | Office of the Director, Department of Women and Child Development, Anand Rao Circle, Bengaluru-560009 Karnataka, Phone:080-22353776 Email: <a href="mailto:directorwcd01@gmail.com">directorwcd01@gmail.com</a> <a href="mailto:jointdirector02@gmail.com">jointdirector02@gmail.com</a> |

Sd/- Director,  
Dept. of Women and Child Development,  
Bengaluru

DIPR/CP/2029/CCL/2026-27



PREDICTION

Buttler believes Sooryavanshi will break his all-time T20 runs record



GETTY IMAGES

It's really cool, actually, to think you've got the most T20 runs out of anyone. Someone will surpass it one day — and his name's probably [Vaibhav] Sooryavanshi — England star Jos Buttler who surpassed Kieron Pollard to become the leading run-getter (14,833 to 14,803) in T20 history on Wednesday.

FRESH CHALLENGE

Forlan appointed head coach of Uruguay national team



FILE PHOTO

Diego Forlan has been appointed head coach of the Uruguay national team. He will take over from Marcelo Bielsa who stepped down following Uruguay's group-stage exit from the World Cup. "Forlan will take charge of the under-20 national team and the senior national team," the country's football association said.

BREAKING THE BANK

Real Madrid signs Ivorian winger Diomande in a record deal



AFF

Real Madrid on Thursday announced the signing of 19-year-old Ivory Coast winger Yan Diomande from Leipzig for what Spanish media reported was a club-record fee of €140 million euros including bonuses. *Los Blancos* said in a statement that "Diomande is tied to our club for the next seven seasons, until June 30, 2033".

STAKING CLAIM

Spain confident it will get to host the 2030 FIFA World Cup final



GETTY IMAGES

The Spanish government remained confident the final of the 2030 World Cup will be held in the country. Speaking after a report that FIFA allegedly awarded the final to co-host Morocco, sports minister Milagros Tolon said Spain "deserved" to host the summit clash. "We are the reigning men's and women's World champions," Tolon said.

# Indian batters hope to come out on top in the spin test

The three-day practice match against Sri Lanka XI offers a chance for the visiting side to get a feel of the conditions in the island; however, rain threat looms over the contest in Colombo and may jeopardise the plans of Gill & Co.

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

Press Trust of India  
COLOMBO

Indian batters will be keen to fine-tune their skills against spin during a three-day warm-up match against Sri Lanka XI at the Nondescripts Cricket Club here on Friday as they gear up for a two-match Test series against the Islanders next week.

Quality spin proved to be India's Achilles Heel against New Zealand and South Africa at home in the last couple of years, and the challenge will not be any different in Sri Lanka.

The Lankans have a capable unit of tweakers, particularly in home conditions, and thus this practice game assumes massive importance for the Indian batters ahead of the first Test at Galle on August 15.

Some frontline batters like skipper Shubman Gill,



Vital cog: Rahul's experience of having played Tests in Sri Lanka should stand him in good stead. x@BCCI

K.L. Rahul and Yashasvi Jaiswal had started preparations against spin individually at their home facilities before boarding the flight to Colombo, but that cannot really supplant an outing on a Sri Lankan pitch.

The outing will give them valuable first-hand idea about local conditions, and it is important because many of them are playing the red-ball format for the first time on these shores.

India's last Test series in

Sri Lanka was in 2017, and the team composition has undergone vast changes in the last decade.

In fact, among the current squad only Rahul, Kuldeep Yadav and Ravindra Jadeja have appeared in Test matches in Sri Lanka.

In the absence of an injured Jasprit Bumrah, pacer Mohammed Siraj will be the bowling spearhead with support coming from Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain.

Raring to go

Both Gurnoor and Saransh had very good outings for India-A against Sri Lanka-A last month at Galle, and they will be raring to have another round of practice under their belt.

However, intermittent rain is predicted to lash the city from Friday and that may jeopardise India's plans.

Meanwhile, Sri Lanka also announced a strong XI that contained some frontrunners to make it to the Test squad.

Led by Sonal Dinusha, who has played three Tests, the squad features pacers Vishwa Fernando, Lahiru Kumara and spinners Isitha Wijesundara and Ramesh Mendis.

# Come 15th morning, we will be ready: Gambhir

Press Trust of India  
COLOMBO

Their home Test run in recent past may not have been particularly impressive but India head coach Gautam Gambhir has asserted that his team will be ready with all the answers when the two-match series against Sri Lanka gets underway here from August 15.

New faces

In a short address to the team before a practice session here, Gambhir also welcomed the new entrants — spin-bowling all-rounder Saransh Jain and pacer Aujib Nabi.

"We know what's in front of us, we know what we are playing for. We can do the volume, we can push our limits, we can tick all the boxes," Gambhir said in the video shared by the Board of control for Cricket in India on social media.

"Come 15th morning (August 15), whether we are batting first, whether we are bowling first, we're absolutely ready with every answer, every question that's thrown at us, and every



Consistent performer: Pacer Aujib has made it to the Test squad on the basis of his Ranji exploits. x@BCCI

answer we are ready to give. So make sure we tick all the boxes from now on."

Back in action

The first match will be played in Galle while the second game will be held here from August 23. It would be India's first ICC World Test Championship assignment since the disastrous 0-2 home defeat to

South Africa last November.

Saransh has been picked in the squad on the basis of his consistently fine run for Madhya Pradesh on the domestic circuit. Aujib is in to replace an injured Jasprit Bumrah. He played a stellar role in Jammu & Kashmir's maiden title-winning run in Ranji Trophy last season.

## Tanvi enters Korea Masters last eight

BADMINTON

ANI  
ASAN (KOREA)

Taipei Open champion Tanvi Sharma continued her impressive form by defeating compatriot Shriyanshi Valishetty 21-16, 17-21, 21-13 to reach the women's singles quarterfinals at the Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament here on Thursday.

Ashmita Chaliha and Rakshitha Ramraj also advanced to the last eight.

In doubles, the men's duo of Krishna Prasad Garaga and Pruthvi Krishnamurthy Roy got the better of the Korean combination of Kim Young Hyuk and Shin Tae Yang 21-18, 21-19 to make the last eight.

The results (round of 16):

**Women:** Tanvi Sharma bt Shriyanshi Valishetty 21-16, 17-21, 21-13; Ashmita Chaliha bt Kim Min-ji (Kor) 21-17, 21-6; Rakshitha Ramraj bt Manami Suizu (Jpn) 22-20, 21-10; Kim Min-sun (Kor) bt Isharani Baruah 21-17, 21-18; Vu Thi Trang (Vie) bt Anmol Kharb 23-21, 15-21, 21-18; Han Qian Xi (Chn) bt Mansi Singh 21-12, 14-21, 21-17.

**Doubles:** Sumire Nakade & Miyu Takahashi (Jpn) bt Sonali Singh & Ritika Thaker 21-15, 21-9.

**Men: Doubles:** Krishna Prasad Garaga & Pruthvi Krishnamurthy Roy bt Kim Young Hyuk & Shin Tae Yang (Kor) 21-18, 21-19.

**Mixed doubles:** Shin Tae Yang & Kim Yu Jung (Kor) bt Ishaan Bhatnagar & Shruti Mishra 21-16, 16-21, 21-13.

# Indian women's team gets the top billing

CHESS OLYMPIAD

P.K. Ajith Kumar

The Indian women are seeded first in the Chess Olympiad, to be held from Samarkand from September 15 to 28. The men are seeded second, behind the top seed United States. India is the reigning champion in both sections.

Koneru Humpy, Divya Deshmukh, R. Vaishali, Vantika Agrawal and B. Savitha Shri make the women's team, while in the open section — women are free to compete with men in chess — D. Gukesh, R. Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi, Nihal Sarin and Vidit Gujrathi will defend the crown.

The men's team shows one change, with P. Harik-

rishna being replaced by Nihal.

And there are two changes in the women's team, with Humpy and Savitha coming in for D. Harika and Tania Sachdev.

Formidable outfits

In the open section, the United States, which features top players like Fabiano Caruana, Wesley So and Levon Aronian, host and third seed Uzbekistan, which includes Javokhir Sindarov, Nodirbek Abdusattorov and Nodirbek Yakubboev, China, Germany, and the Netherlands are among the stronger teams in the open category. The USA's average rating is 2751, while India's is 2733.

In the women's section, India would be challenged by the likes of second seed Georgia, Kazakhstan, Chi-

na — which isn't fielding some of its best players, — Ukraine and the United States.

The average rating of the top-seeded India is 2476, while Georgia is 2449.

The 46th edition of the Olympiad, the equivalent of the Davis Cup in tennis, has attracted a record 400 teams — 208 in the Open and 192 in the women's sections. At Budapest in 2024, there were 380 teams.

The Olympiad will be played over 11 rounds and games will be contested over four boards. The best players in each section are also awarded individual board medals.

In the last Olympiad, Gukesh, Arjun, Divya and Vantika had won individual gold medals for India.



In focus: Gukesh's form will be vital for India's chances in the Open event while Vaishali is expected to pull her weight for the defending champion in the women's section. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

# Newcastle's talent exodus: are the Magpies becoming a feeder club?



Seeking better opportunities: Gordon and Tonalì have completed big money moves to other clubs while Guimaraes is close to sealing his. REUTERS & AFP



FOOTBALL

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

Newcastle United's ambitious project to reign supreme over the Premier League kingdom is collapsing like a poorly built sandcastle.

The Magpies are losing world-class talent left, right, and centre, evidently moving farther away from realising CEO David Hopkinson's target of putting Newcastle "in the debate about being the top club in the world" by 2030.

In the 2026-27 summer transfer window, Newcastle has sold winger Anthony Gordon (to Barcelona for almost €80 million), midfielder Sandro Tonali (Tottenham Hotspur, approximately €108 million), and has all but lost captain Bruno Guimaraes to champion Arsenal.

The exodus is not limited to the players, as head

coach Eddie Howe, too, stepped down from his role last Friday, less than a month before the start of the season.

The English manager — who won the club its first domestic trophy in 70 years (2025 Carabao Cup) — decided to move on, seemingly frustrated by the club's inability to retain its top players.

Baffling play

While feeder clubs have historically made a successful business out of selling their finest talent to the 'big boys' for big bucks, a team of Newcastle's stature resorting to this transfer strategy is perplexing.

Even after considering the club's compulsions to comply with the sports' financial regulations, the underlying trend of football's heavyweight names not wanting to stay or sign for Newcastle cannot be overlooked.

Last year's Alexander

Isak transfer saga will be a grim reminder for the club, which is backed by the financial might of Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund.

The incomings at St. James' Park have been more out of hope than expectation, with the club buying youngsters who are yet to perform consistently at the highest level.

The likes of Sean Steur (18 years old), Bazoumana Toure, and Aladji Bamba (20) are fine outfield prospects to have, but are hardly ready to anchor a squad hollowed out by elite departures.

Shattered team

It is this shattered team that new head coach Matthias Jaissle is inheriting.

Can the German gaffer make some prudent signings in the remainder of the window and build a team worthy of the Newcastle colours?

## Vinicius to stay at Real until 2032

Reuters  
MADRID

Real Madrid has secured the future of Brazilian winger Vinicius Jr., extending his contract until June 2032, the Spanish giant announced on Thursday and bringing an end to months of speculation over his future.

The 26-year-old Brazil international has been a central figure in Real's attack in recent seasons and had been linked with a move to English champion Arsenal. His previous contract was due to expire in June 2027.

"Real Madrid and Vinicius Jr. have agreed to extend our player's contract, which now keeps him with the club through June 30, 2032..." Real said in a statement.

"Vinicius has become one of the most important players during one of the most successful periods in our history."

Vinicius has scored 128 goals and registered 100 assists for Real.



Vinicius Jr. AFP



INBRIEF



FIFA apologises over abandoned proposal

FIFA apologised to its members for mistakes made over its abandoned proposal to sell commercial rights to the World Cup as the body’s leadership reaffirmed its support for president Gianni Infantino after a crisis meeting in Morocco on Wednesday. Infantino bore the brunt of the criticism, including some from inside FIFA, which raised questions over his re-election as president next March. “Following a meeting in Rabat, Morocco, the FIFA secretary general and members of the FIFA management board in attendance reaffirmed their full support for FIFA president Gianni Infantino,” the statement said.

CSA adds three T20Is to Women in Blue’s tour

Cricket South Africa (CSA) on Thursday revised the schedule of India women’s team tour later this year to accommodate three T20Is in addition to a Test and three ODIs. As per the revised itinerary, the one-off Test will be played from December 9-12 before the ODI series (Dec. 16-22). Now, the Indian team will spend an extra week in South Africa to play the T20I series between Dec. 26 and 30.

Please reconsider withdrawal: AIFF chief Chaubey to JFC

All India Football Federation president Kalyan Chaubey has urged the Tata group to reconsider its “shocking” decision of withdrawing Jamshedpur FC from the Indian Super League. “AIFF would be happy if Tata remains in football, especially in senior top tier football. If an AIFF request or application can change their mind... the AIFF would like to appeal that for the interest of the players and football, Tata should remain in the senior football league,” Chaubey said.

Bodoland surges back with a big win over FC 1

Langsning FC fights back in the second half to hold Nongkseh SS&CC to a 2-2 draw in a Group E fixture played in Shillong



Job well done: Aron Thapa, left, celebrates after scoring Bodoland’s third. X@THEDURANDCUP

DURAND CUP

Sports Bureau

Bodoland FC bounced back from its opening-match defeat with a convincing 3-0 victory over FC 1 in a Group F league match of the 135th Durand Cup at the Indira Gandhi Athletic Stadium, Guwahati, on Thursday.

After suffering a 6-0 loss to NorthEast United FC, Bodoland produced an impressive display against FC 1, the debutant side representing Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh.

Robinson Rendon put

Bodoland ahead just before the hour mark heading in a cross from Halicharan Narzary. Substitutes Rituraj Mohan and Aron Thapa then struck in quick succession during the closing stages to seal the win.

The victory earned Bodoland its first three points of the campaign, drawing level with NorthEast United FC and FC 1 in Group F. NorthEast United continues to lead the standings on superior goal difference after one match, with FC 1 second and Bodoland third on the same count.

The other match at Shillong’s Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium ended in a 2-2 draw between Meghalaya

State League champion Nongkseh SS&CC and local rival Langsning FC in a Group E fixture.

Nongkseh led 2-0 at half-time through Shano Tariang and Hardycliff Nongbri before Langsning fought back, with Mebanshgain Kurkalang and Syed Ahmed scoring within two minutes.

**The results: Group F (at Guwahati):** Bodoland FC 3 (Robinson Rendon 57, Rituraj Mohan 78, Aron Thapa 82) bt FC 1 0.

**Group E (at Shillong):** Nongkseh SS&CC 2 (Shano Tariang 29, Hardycliff Nongbri 38) drew with Langsning FC 2 (Mebanshgain Kurkalang 48, Syed Ahmed 50).

Three Indians in finals at u-20 Worlds

Press Trust of India  
EUGENE (USA)

Javelin throwers Ashish Yadav and T. Dharanidharan along with discus thrower Amanat Kamboj qualified for the final rounds in a decent opening day performance by the Indians at the World Athletics u-20 championships here.

Ashish topped the men’s javelin Group A qualification round with 69.87m and ended at second spot overall, behind South Africa’s title favourite Jan-Hendrik Heymans who won Group B with a 76.02m throw.

The 19-year-old Indian has a season’s best of 74.49m, which is also his personal best.

Dharanidharan made it to the final round, taking the 12th and the last spot overall after finishing fifth in Group B qualification round with 68.07m.

In women’s discus, Amanat produced a season’s best of 52.58m to finish sixth in Group A qualification and take the 12th and last available spot.

Mogali Venkatram made it to the men’s 800m semi-finals while Uwin Anand bowed out after the Round 1 heats.Venkatram finished third in Heat 5, clocking 1 minute 52.81 seconds.

LIVE TELECAST

Ireland vs Afghanistan: Second ODI, FanCode, 3.15 p.m.

TNPL: Sony Sports Ten 4 Tamil & TNPL Official YouTube channel (youtube@tamilnadupremierleague), 3.30 & 7.30 p.m.

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 7 p.m.



Hit-man: Saini, celebrates one of his three scalps. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Yajas and Saini guide Warriors to a facile win

DPL

Sports Bureau  
NEW DELHI

Yajas Sharma smashed an unbeaten 64 while Navdeep Saini took three for nine as Outer Delhi Warriors romped to a 39-run win over South Delhi Superstarz in the Delhi Premier League at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Thursday.

With the rainy season in effect in the national capital, the game was shortened to 10 overs per side.

Warriors, sent in to bat, responded with an imposing total of 132 for two in 10 overs. Though Priyansh Arya fell in the third over, Yajas managed to take charge with a blazing knock comprising five fours and as many sixes.

The opener stitched together a 52-run stand with one-drop Akshay Saini, and added 49 runs with Monu Shukla for the third wicket. For South Delhi,

Aman Bharti and Pranshu Vijayran snared a wicket each.

In response, Superstarz’s fate was sealed once they were reduced to 16 for four inside three overs. While Anmol Sharma fell to Shivam Sharma for a duck off the very first ball, Saini accounted for Ayush Badoni and Pranav Pant in the second over.

Saini also got the better of Tejasvi Dahiya in the seventh over.

Ekansh Dobal hit a 15-ball 35 at No.6, but it did little to alter the outcome as Superstarz were bundled out for 93 in 9.4 overs.

**The scores:** Outer Delhi Warriors 132/2 in 10 overs (Yajas Sharma 64 n.o.) bt South Delhi Superstarz 93 in 9.4 overs (Ekansh Dobal 35, Navdeep Saini 3/9, Siddhant Sharma 2/13, Pratham Saluja 2/22, Anant Sareen 2/5). Match reduced to 10 overs per side. Purani Dilli 6 177/8 in 20 overs (Aryan Gaur 91, Laxman 4/29, Hrithik Shokeen 4/18) bt New Delhi Tigers 150/8 in 20 overs (Himmat Singh 36, Vaibhav Rawal 33, Rajneesh Dadar 3/26).

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In grief  
Mrs. Arunthuthi (wife)  
Senthil Kumar (Son) & Rupalakshmi (Daughter in law)  
Priya (Daughter) & Sivakumar (Son in law)  
Grandchildren: Nandita, Anish, Pranav & Arundhathi.

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Offers are invited in two parts system on e-tendering on the portal of Delhi Govt. at <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in>, for the below items with tender closing time at 11:00 hrs. on bid submission date:-

|    | Tender ID & Description                                                                                                                                                                              | T-Value(Rs.)   |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| 01 | 2026_IPGCL_293674<br>Procurement of 01 multipurpose Diesel, BS VI Compliance Fire Tender at PPS-III Bawana                                                                                           | 1,34,66,666.00 |
| 02 | 2026_IPGCL_293250<br>Procurement of four set of Blended Media India Air Filters (F9 AS PER en779:2012 OR MERV 15AS PER ASHRAE 52.2:2012 STANDARD) for 9 Fa Gas Turbines installed at PPS-III, Bawana | 2,80,60,800.00 |

**Corrigendum/Retender**

|    |                                                                                            |                |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| 01 | 2025_IPGCL_287686_1<br>Paving Work at different location of unpaved area at PPS-III Bawana | 1,20,72,261.33 |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|

**Note:** 1) Tender Issue Date & EMD details :- Please visit IPGCL-PPCL website ([www.ipgcl-ppcl.gov.in](http://www.ipgcl-ppcl.gov.in))  
2) Bid Submission End Date & Bid Opening Date: As per IPGCL-PPCL website and Delhi Govt. e-portal  
3) No Corrigendum/ addendum/modification for tender value up to Rs. 50.00 Lacs will be advertised in newspaper and bidders are requested to regularly visit IPGCL-PPCL website as well as Delhi Government E-procurement site for getting themselves updated.  
DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0168/26-27

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In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit-III, Bhubaneswar-751001  
Tel.:(0674) 2380608; Website: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in>;  
Email: [proc.osmcl.od@od.gov.in](mailto:proc.osmcl.od@od.gov.in)  
Notification No. 7425/OSMCL/2026 Date : 05.08.2026  
**NOTICE INVITING Re-Tender for SUPPLY, INSTALLATION & COMMISSIONING OF MULTIPARA PATIENT MONITOR (5-PARA) EQUIPMENT ON CONTRACT BASIS**  
Online Bids through e-Tender portal (<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>) are invited from eligible bidders for supply, Installation & commissioning of Equipment as per the particulars mentioned below:

| Sl. | Bid Reference No.                | Item Name                                                                                                            | Bid Document Cost inclusive of GST (Rs.) |
|-----|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| 1.  | OSMCL/2026-27/ MONITOR_5 Para/03 | Re-tender for Supply, Installation & Commissioning of Multipara Patient Monitor (5-Para) Equipment on Contract Basis | Rs. 5,900/-                              |

| Sl. No. | Particulars                                                                                                                         | Date and time                                                                                                                                         |
|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1.      | Date & time of release of bid                                                                                                       | 05/08/2026, 5 PM                                                                                                                                      |
| 2.      | Date & time of Pre-Bid Meeting                                                                                                      | 12/08/2026, 11.30 AM<br>Venue : Conference Hall, Odisha State Medical Corporation Ltd., In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit-III, Bhubaneswar |
| 3.      | Date & time of Online bid submission                                                                                                | Start Date & Time<br>19/08/2026, 3 PM<br>End Date & Time<br>08/09/2026, 5 PM                                                                          |
| 4.      | Date & time for submission of Tender Documents, Tender Document Fee and EMD amount as per Clause No.3.1 and 6.17 of tender document | Start Date & Time<br>09/09/2026, 10 AM<br>End Date & Time<br>18/09/2026, 2.30 PM                                                                      |
| 5.      | Date & time of Online Technical bid Opening                                                                                         | 18/09/2026, 3 PM                                                                                                                                      |
| 6.      | Date of opening of Price Bid                                                                                                        | To be informed to the qualified bidders                                                                                                               |

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> and <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason thereof.

**Managing Director, OSMCL**  
10001/442/2627 CIPR-10001/10112/1/26-27/0009

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# From World champions to a side in panic mode

Post the IPL, Indian cricket has been grabbed by a sense of despair and dismay. The bubble emphatically burst in Ireland when, against all odds and in an upset of gargantuan proportions, the home side stunned the Men in Blue 2-0 in a T20I series; the Sri Lanka tour will be a big test of Gill's batsmanship and his man-management skills



GETTY IMAGES

R. Kaushik

It's only been five months since India successfully defended their T20 World Cup crown in Ahmedabad. It's been five long months since Suryakumar Yadav's men became the first outfit to triumph on home soil.

The euphoria of a grand campaign which climaxed in two powerhouse batting displays that netted team totals in excess of 250 in both the semifinals and the final disappeared in less than three weeks as the IPL carnival marched into town and pitched tent. The exploits of a 15-year-old quickly relegated the World Cup heroics to a footnote, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi setting the world afire with one spectacular knock after another to break down the doors to international cricket.

However, post the IPL, Indian cricket has been grabbed by a sense of despair and dismay. The bubble emphatically burst in Ireland towards the end of June when, against all odds and in an upset of gargantuan proportions, the home side stunned India 2-0 in a Twenty20 International series. India were at full strength, under a new captain with Suryakumar having been given the heave-ho because of a poor run of scores that couldn't make up for his wonderful leadership abilities at the World Cup. Yet, the Irish breezed past Shreyas Iyer's side in the first game and held their nerve to eke out a one-run victory in the next, triggering euphoria in the little nation and disbelief and shock elsewhere in the world. India had an immediate chance to make amends in England against the team that had run them perilously close in the World Cup semifinal. But with Harry Brook firing on all cylinders and his colleagues taking their cue from the skipper, England stormed to a 4-0 victory (the first match was washed out) to ensure there was no joy on the snappy tour of the United Kingdom for the new leadership group of Shreyas and head coach Gautam Gambhir.

**Some redemption**

The only salve came in the form of a 3-0 sweep in Zimbabwe when V.V.S. Laxman stood in as head coach. After Ireland, nothing was a formality anymore and therefore those who might point out that there was nothing flash about the 'expected' outcome might want to think again. India were back to their dominant selves, almost, in the three fixtures at the Harare Sports Club to briefly dispel the pall of gloom. But as they embark on their latest challenge in the World Test Championship, the picture of a ship in trouble, with the crew disjointed and pulling in different directions when the need of the hour is to stay on the same page and resuscitate a challenge now floundering desperately, is discouraging, at the very least.

The list of injuries has mounted alarmingly in the last few weeks. It was bad enough that all-rounders Washington Sundar and Nitish Kumar Reddy, as well as Harshit Rana, the pacer whom Gambhir is trying to shape into an all-rounder, were ruled out of the

two-Test tour of Sri Lanka long before the selectors under Ajit Agarkar met to pick the squad. Among those selected was Jasprit Bumrah, the pace king who is the best bowler in the world, his tribulations in the IPL notwithstanding, and who can take the pitch and the conditions out of the equation anywhere in the universe. Subject to the caveat that he needed to clear a fitness test at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru, a caveat that also accompanied left-handed batter Sai Sudharsan's selection.

Bumrah has since been ruled out, yet to fully recover from the impact injury to his left knee sustained while fielding in the second One-Day International against England in Cardiff some three weeks back. It's a bitter blow because there is no greater gamechanger in world cricket than the man from Ahmedabad with a quirky walk/run-up and action.

Often, Bumrah's presence creates the pressure that allows bowlers operating from the other end to garner wickets - that's when Bumrah himself isn't cutting a swathe through the opposition batting. Without him, India's chances of extending their winning streak in Sri Lanka have taken that much of a beating, necessitating the other bowlers to step up and share the burden so that Shubman Gill isn't left wondering who to turn to - in every sense of the term - for the breakthroughs so crucial to winning Test matches.

Injury management has become a massive bone of contention, with a convenient accusatory finger pointed at the CoE, a soft target when the actual 'culprits', for want of a better word, are more firmly entrenched within the contours of the national side and whose task it is to monitor the fitness and recovery from injury of those who are playing international cricket on a reasonably regular basis.

In the last few days, rumours that Agarkar's tenure as chief selector might come to an end in the next month or so have gained traction. Insiders say the former India paceman had indicated to the Board of Control for Cricket in India as early as in February that he would like to be relieved of his responsibilities in September, though there is no clarity of any nature on why so when he still has a couple of years of the maximum permissible five to serve out. Agarkar took over as the chairman of the senior selection panel in the middle of 2023 and his stint has seen some grand highs and several debilitating lows, some of them alongside Gambhir and others independent of the latter, when Rahul Dravid was the head coach.

Among the terrific accomplishments are two T20 World Cup trophy runs and an unbeaten charge through the draw at the Champions Trophy in Dubai in March 2005. The lows, notwithstanding the 6-0 T20I drubbing in Ireland and England, have largely come in Test cricket, and that too at home - 0-3 against New Zealand in October-November 2024, 0-2 against South Africa in November last year.

India have been hoist with their own petard, continuing to operate in the erroneous and misplaced conviction that they are still the best players of the

turning ball when the ground realities paint an entirely different picture.

**Change of guard?**

All of a sudden, CoE boss Laxman's name has cropped up as a potential successor to Agarkar, just as it had more than two years back when it was taken for granted that he would take over as the head coach of the national side from his friend Dravid. Laxman isn't coaching-averse - he wasn't in 2024 either - but perhaps having to spend so much time away from home didn't appeal to him. In a stand-in capacity, first for Dravid and more recently for Gambhir, he has done a stellar job. In so many ways, Laxman is a bit like Ravi Shastri, a man for a crisis. Laxman's reputation as a crisis man was firmly established during his playing days when he bailed the team out of a spot more than once, several of them with the bowlers - he has never liked the word 'tailenders' - for company. Whether Agarkar is actually contemplating stepping down and, in that eventuality, whether Laxman is the preferred and willing choice, remains to be seen. But it is clearly this artificial uncertainty that Indian cricket could do without as it approaches a crucial phase in the five-day game with nine Tests lined up in the next seven months, four of them away in Sri Lanka and New Zealand.

In some respects, it would seem as if the misadventures in the UK have forced a pressing of the panic button when the crying need is for calm heads and an acceptance that while the results didn't go according to plan, it doesn't mean the end of the world. India contributed to their misery in England, especially, choosing not to respect the conditions or the quality of the opposition bowling - Jofra Archer on tracks that have a bit in them is a far different proposition from Archer of Rajasthan Royals playing his wares on batting beauties in the IPL. Instead of embracing equanimity, there is, those in the team insist, a shrill insistence on outcomes, which can never be a positive development.

In strict confidence, some of the more established players have hinted at a feeling of insecurity because of the mixed messaging from the regular think-tank, which will be without two established names when the tour of Sri Lanka kicks off on Friday with a three-day First Class fixture. Assistant coach Ryan ten Doeschate, who came on board nearly two years back when Gambhir took over from Dravid, and fielding coach T. Dileep, who has been with the national squad for a lot longer, are now surplus to requirement. How the players, already feeling the pinch after being pushed to a corner, adapt to this new normal, however temporary it might be, will determine how well they acquit themselves in a land where India are unbeaten in a Test series since 2010.

For Gill, this is a huge challenge, a big test of his batsmanship but also his man-management skills and his tactical awareness. With Bumrah only playing three of five Tests in England last

summer, Gill came through with flying colours on his maiden foray into Test captaincy. That he led from the front, with a mountain of runs (754), helped. After making elementary if understandable errors in his first couple of matches, Gill gradually grew into his role and was in complete command by the time of the last Test at the Oval, when he eked out match-winning and series-levelling performances from experienced pacer Mohammed Siraj and relative newcomer Prasidh Krishna. He led in only one of two Tests against South Africa, missing the huge rout (by a record 408 runs) in Guwahati with a neck injury, and therefore doesn't carry a great deal of baggage. But he himself hasn't played a Test in Sri Lanka - very few in his squad have, given that India's last five-day outing in the Emerald Isle was in 2017--and this will be India's first Tests since last November (not counting the one-off game against Afghanistan in New Chandigarh in June). India have their task cut out on the field, against a Sri Lankan side with so much riding on the outcome. Gill's lads will be well advised to ignore off-field distractions and focus on the personnel available rather than mope about those who aren't. Transition and inexperience will no longer cut ice. Few will know that better than Gambhir, feisty and combative but clearly aware that his CV is anything but impressive, let alone exemplary.



## THE GIST

- ▼ The euphoria of a grand T20 World Cup campaign disappeared in less than three weeks as the IPL carnival marched into town and pitched tent
- ▼ Injury management has become a massive bone of contention, with a convenient accusatory finger pointed at the CoE
- ▼ It would seem as if the misadventures in the UK have forced a pressing of the panic button when the crying need is for calm heads



HEALTH

Growing your own food, time for leisure: what life is like in a blue zone

A blue zone, a concept introduced by journalist Dan Buettner, demographer Michel Poulain, and physician Gianni Pes, describes a region with high longevity; Ogimi, a village in Okinawa, Japan, is a lush landscape dotted with small farms where residents live with a strong sense of purpose

Meenakshy S.

The air is heavy, but the skies are clear on a July afternoon in Okinawa, Japan's southernmost and westernmost prefecture: a tropical paradise, a globally recognised 'blue zone', and home to some of the people who have lived the longest. It has been only a day or two since Typhoon Bavi churned its waters and toppled trees. But Okinawans believe typhoons are not merely inevitable; they are essential. "It cleanses our seas," says Hisami Takayama, 62, who has worked as a travel guide in the region for several years.

A blue zone, a concept introduced by journalist Dan Buettner, demographer Michel Poulain, and physician Gianni Pes, in essence, describes a region with high longevity. Sardinia in Italy and Nicoya in Costa Rica are some of the other recognised blue zones.

Perhaps the most remarkable thing about this island of longevity is that its nature and culture are so deeply intertwined that they are almost impossible to separate. The greatest living proof of this, is a village less than two hours from Naha city, along the coast overlooking Okinawa's brilliant blue and purple waters: Ogimi.

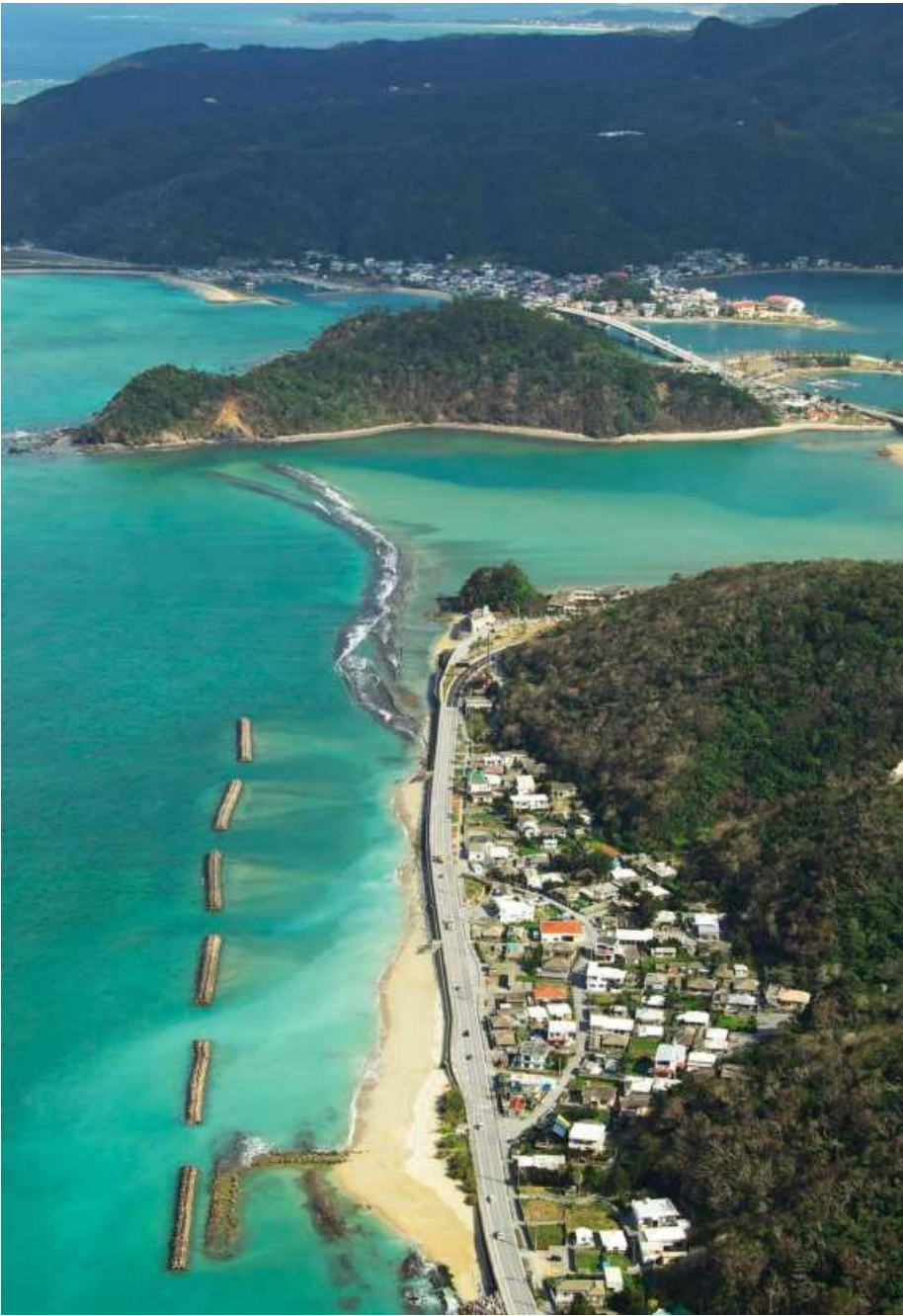
The residents of Ogimi are all about the spirit of *nankuru nai sa* – the Okinawan belief that, in the end, everything will be alright and life should not be taken too seriously

Home to an unusually large number of octogenarians, nonagenarians, and centenarians, Ogimi is a lush landscape dotted with small farms where residents grow much of their own food. Here, people live with a strong

sense of purpose, or *ikigai* – a word many of us became familiar with through the acclaimed self-help book – while embracing a certain slowness unique to the region, starkly different from the bustling city life of Tokyo.

**Prevention better than cure**  
What drives longevity here? Food, of course, is one of the biggest factors. Okinawans follow a basic rule: *hara hachi bu*, which means, eating until you are 80% full. They also believe that good health begins with the food they eat; Okinawans place greater emphasis on prevention than treating illness after it occurs - a philosophy influenced by Chinese culture, which believes that food and medicine come from the same source.

Morio Taira, 91, eats about three meals a day – meat, lots of vegetables, and fruits, whether they are bitter, sour, or sweet. An Ogimi table makes the best use of whatever is grown in the village during that particular season. Their diet is especially rich in green and yellow vegetables, including bitter melon, mugwort, and handama. A local specialty fruit, shikwasa lemon, is used abundantly; it is believed to be high in nobletin, a compound that may support cognitive function and help manage glucose levels, according to some studies. They also consume protein-rich tofu from the island. Purple sweet potato, which is rich



Blue waters: Ogimi is a lush landscape dotted with small farms. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



A typical meal, generally built around a bowl of rice and paired with soup. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

in antioxidants, is a staple ingredient in many of their dishes.

Traditional Okinawan cuisine relies heavily on dashi, a broth that forms the base of many dishes and is rich in *umami* (the savoury taste), a term that any food lover associates with Japanese cuisine. Ms. Takayama says that the *umami* in Okinawan cuisine also has much to do with longevity. It adds restraint and harmony to their food and helps reduce

salt intake - by enhancing the perception of saltiness - without sacrificing flavour.

The food grown in Ogimi uses little to no pesticides, says Makoto Takehara, a young farmer. Pointing to an okura (okra) farm, he says: "We even let weeds grow here. They are also life. They bring bugs, and bugs are necessary." Growing food is something children are taught from a young age; it forms part of the the Okinawan school curriculum. Even older



People live with a strong sense of purpose, or *ikigai* – a word many of us became familiar with through the acclaimed self-help book – while embracing a certain slowness unique to the region, starkly different from the bustling city life of Tokyo

people take part in farming, which helps them stay active, says Kenryu Miyagi, chairman of Ogimi Marugoto Tourism Society.

Staying active

But it's not just about food, says Mr. Morio; keeping the mind active is just as important. Even at 91, he plays Japanese chess every day.

Incidentally, it was through the game that he met the love of his life, Etsuko Taira, who is 81. The couple has been married for so long that they no longer remember exactly how many years it has been. They first met when Mr. Morio was working at a radio bullet-casting company, while Ms. Etsuko worked at a souvenir shop. Her father was an avid Japanese chess player, and as Mr. Morio often played with him, he and Ms. Etsuko gradually fell in love.

Living for loved ones is another principle Okinawans value, along with their strong sense of community. Mr. Morio and Ms. Etsuko enjoy karaoke nights and long morning walks along Okinawa's white sandy shores. Ms. Etsuko quips they are almost always together, but a little time apart is healthy too. Every now and then, she enjoys spending time with her girlfriends and indulging in *yuntaku*, which, in the Okinawan dictionary, means 'chatting and laughing', a principle through which local people strengthen their bonds by sharing stories about their day-to-day lives.

Sense of purpose

The residents of Ogimi are all about the spirit of *nankuru nai sa* – the Okinawan belief that, in the end, everything will be alright and life should not be taken too seriously. At the same time, they are guided by a strong sense of *ikigai*.

Hatsuko Yamashiro is a big proponent of the latter. At 83, she still runs her own PR company, employing 15 people. She says her mission is to introduce Okinawa's shikwasa lemons to the rest of the world. Community is very important, says Ms. Hatsuko, adding that she genuinely enjoys going to the office every day. One day, she hopes to see shikwasa become known across the globe.

The biggest secret of all, according to Ms. Takayama, is that all these values – these centuries-old secrets to a long and healthy life - are deeply ingrained in Okinawa's culture and way of life; they are organic. Like all things, life must come to an end, and Okinawans don't live with the goal of living a long life; they instead strive for contentment and a sense of purpose, she adds.

The secret to a long and healthy life is something many want to discover; the answer, says nonagenarian Mr. Morio, who has lived in the region all his life, is many things, all relatively simple. (meenakshy.s@thehindu.co.in)



Studies show that higher perceived stress is associated with greater acne severity, although the relationship is complex. GETTY IMAGES

Can stress cause acne? Experts explain the science

Stress is often blamed for acne breakouts, particularly during high-anxiety period such as examinations, work deadlines or emotionally difficult life events. While scientific evidence supports an association between psychological stress and worsening acne, dermatologists caution that stress alone is rarely responsible.

Studies show that higher perceived stress is associated with greater acne severity, although the relationship is complex and influenced by hormonal, genetic and environmental factors. Therefore stress is considered an aggravating factor rather than an independent cause of acne.

Stress activates the hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal (HPA) axis, increasing the production of cortisol and other stress mediators. These mediators can stimulate sebaceous glands, increase sebum production, alter the skin's immune responses and promote inflammatory pathways involved in acne.

"Stress places the body in a pro-inflammatory state, and the skin often reflects this inflammation," says K. R. Sharmatha, senior consultant, dermatology, SIMS Hospital, Chennai. She explains that elevated cortisol may increase inflammation while also reducing certain aspects of the skin's immune defence. This can result in greater sebum production and make acne lesions more susceptible to secondary bacterial infection. Inflammation may also alter the skin microbiome, contributing to inflamed or infected acne lesions in some individuals, she says.

However, not every breakout is stress-related. Hormonal disorders, metabolic abnormalities, medications and other underlying factors should be evaluated before attributing acne solely to stress. Stress affects acne not only through biological pathways but also by changing everyday behaviour.

According to Narayanan A., consultant, dermatology, SRM Prime Hospital, Chennai, patients frequently report worsening acne during examinations, periods of intense work pressure or emotional distress. People with oily skin, inflammatory acne, hormonal acne or a tendency to pick at their skin are particularly likely to experience stress-related flare-ups.

During stressful periods, many people sleep less, consume more high-glycaemic foods, discontinue acne medications, use heavier cosmetic products or repeatedly touch and pick their skin, all of which may aggravate acne. "An acne flare-up is therefore a complex interplay of multiple factors," he says.

**Stress management**  
Evidence increasingly supports lifestyle measures such as adequate sleep, regular physical activity and mindfulness-based stress reduction as part of comprehensive acne care. However, dermatologists caution against viewing stress reduction as a substitute for medical therapy.

"Stress responses are biological and acne is not a character flaw," says Dr. Narayanan. He adds that relaxation alone cannot cure acne because breakouts may also result from hormonal fluctuations, menstruation, pregnancy, medications, occlusive cosmetics, friction, sweating or inappropriate skin care.

The relationship is also bidirectional: stress can worsen acne, while acne itself can increase anxiety, emotional distress and reduced self-esteem.

Experts recommend addressing underlying skin disease and the psychological burden it creates. (athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)

THE HEALTH QUIZ

With World Breastfeeding Week having just come to an end, the focus has been on infant and child nutrition. Here is a quiz testing your knowledge on the topic

Zubeda Hamid

**QUESTION 1**  
The milk made by a woman's body in the first days after birth – thicker and more yellowish than breastmilk – and also known as 'liquid gold' due to its nutrients and antibodies is?

**QUESTION 2**  
True or False: Breastmilk is digested more quickly than formula

**QUESTION 3**  
Which of these is not one of the five essential food groups, and which is the missing group? Fruits, vegetables, oils, protein, dairy

**QUESTION 4**

Children can be fussy eaters. How many times does a child need to try a new food before they may like it?

**QUESTION 5**  
The deficiency of which micronutrient, common in children leads to symptoms including pale skin, irritability, lack of energy, fatigue, a fast heartbeat and a sore or swollen tongue.

**QUESTION 6**  
Which of these is a Vitamin A rich food? a) White rice b) Apples c) Sweet potato d) Chicken breast

**QUESTION 7**  
Name the most important hormone used to make breastmilk.



**Answers to previous edition's quiz**  
1. This number has been doing the rounds in media reports of late: the replacement level of the total fertility rate. **Ans: 2.1** 2. Is

the following statement true or false? A woman's eggs increase until she reaches puberty. **Ans: False** 3. The two hormones necessary for the production of sperm are

**Visual question:** What is this plate of balanced food called? GETTY IMAGES

\_\_\_\_\_ and \_\_\_\_\_. **Ans: FSH and LH**  
4. Polycystic Ovary Syndrome (PCOS) is a common, but treatable cause of infertility. This condition recently underwent a name change. What is it called now? **Ans: PMOS** 5. What is one of the few temporary organs of the human body that forms part of the reproductive health system? **Ans: Placenta** 6. The reproductive system contains the largest and smallest human cells. Name them. **Ans: Sperm cells and egg cells**  
Visual: What is the name of the vital reaction that a sperm must undergo to successfully fertilise an egg? **Ans: Acrosome reaction**

**Winners:** Viswanathan Neelakantan | Tamal Biswas | C Saravanan